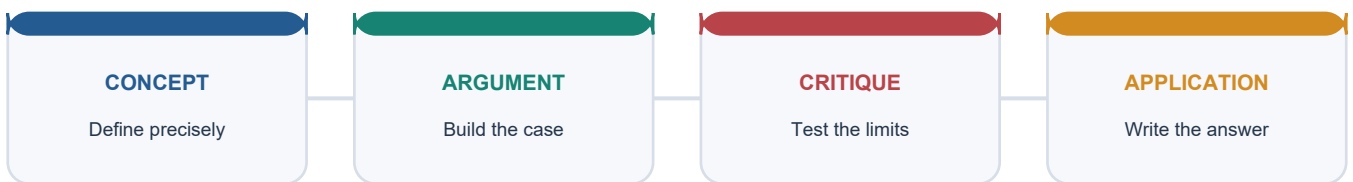


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 16 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 7 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil

Uncompressed complete learning session | Approval: pending explicit user approval

Syllabus owner: "Problem of Evil." **Learning rule:** simple explanation first, technical doctrine second; no artificial speed target and no skipped doctrine. **Evidence order:** canonical Markdown -> OCR-searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion* and the *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion* -> bounded official live anchor. Qdrant was not required. **PYQ control:** all 7 primary-owner Philosophy Optional question-parts from 2018-2025 are reproduced from the audited ledger, out of 112 Paper II parts. This clause owns no part in 2018 and exactly one part in every paper from 2019 through 2025. **Objective-question status:** Philosophy Optional is Mains-only. Every MCQ in this package is original UPSC-style practice, never a claimed Prelims previous-year question. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *privation of good (privatio boni)*, *unseen moral potency (adr̥ṣṭa)*, *karma-superintendent (karmādhyaṁṣa)*, *animal birth (tiryak-yoni)*, *imponderables (acinteyya)*, *beyond the senses (atīndriya)*, *suffering (duḥkha; Pali: dukkha)*, *ignorance (avidyā)*, *inflow of karmic matter (āsrava)*, *bondage (bandha)*, *purity and impurity (śuddhi/aśuddhi)*, *demerit and merit (pāpa/puṇya)*, *liberation (mokṣa/nirvāṇa/kaivalya)*, *empirical and ultimate levels (vyāvahārika/pāramārthika)*, *world-axis (axis mundi)*, *awe-inspiring and fascinating mystery (mysterium tremendum et fascinans)*.

Package counts

Component	Count
Verified owner PYQs with full model answers	7
Original core diagnostic MCQs	24
Original remedial MCQs	8
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Original solved Mains questions	6 (2 x 10m, 2 x 15m, 2 x 20m)
Correct-option placement	Independently randomised, balanced and unpatterned
Topic approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns the **logical, evidential, existential and moral challenge from evil**, together with defences, theodicies, revised God-concepts, Indian responses and the cost of each reply.

Owned here	Boundary
the omnipotence-omniscience-goodness profile under pressure from evil	the independent definition and coherence of each attribute remains with Notions of God
evil as evidence against classical theism	the positive and cumulative proofs remain with Proofs for the Existence of God
karma and rebirth only as explanations of suffering and its distribution	personal identity, rebirth mechanics and liberation remain with Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation
mystery and epistemic limitation only as replies to evidential evil	faith, revelation and properly basic belief remain with Reason, Revelation and Faith
creator-removal as one way of dissolving the classical problem	complete non-creator religious systems remain with Religion without God

Owned here	Boundary
evil and the profane as religion-forming categories	the sacred and the holy as the <i>object</i> of experience remains with Religious Experience

ANALYSIS: A **defence** proposes a possible compatibility story and defeats the charge of strict contradiction; a **theodicy** claims to identify God's actual morally sufficient reason. Neither is pastoral permission to explain a sufferer's experience back to them.

BASIC / MUST KNOW - independently complete for UPSC Philosophy Optional

This section contains every version of the problem, every named defence and theodicy, every Indian response, every objection with its reply and every verdict needed for the seven verified owner PYQs and for a complete core answer. No Advanced section is required to repair a missing thinker, doctrine, distinction or PYQ concept. In particular, **skeptical theism** and **horrendous evils** were promoted to Core on 15 August 2026 and are taught here in Sessions 9 and 10; they are **not** deferred to the optional block.

0A. VERSIONS, BURDENS AND REPLY-TYPES ANALYSIS:

Test	Question the examiner is really asking	Where the marks sit
Version	Which problem is on the table - logical, evidential, existential, horrendous, animal or distributional?	Naming the version in the first two lines
Burden	Must the theist show consistency, restore probability, or answer the sufferer?	Matching the reply to the burden
Reply-type	Is the reply a defence (possible reason), a theodicy (actual reason), a revision of the God-concept, or a dissolution that removes the defendant?	The distinction that separates a 60% script from a 70% script
Cost	What has the reply given up - omnipotence, personality, the creator, or moral confidence?	The closing verdict
Scope	Does the reply cover moral evil only, natural evil too, animal suffering, or the amount and distribution?	The residue paragraph
Ethics of reply	Does the answer respect lament and the duty to relieve suffering?	The qualification that prevents a callous conclusion

Burden rule: the logical problem is defeated by showing a *possible* morally sufficient reason; the evidential problem is not, because possibility does not restore probability. A script that answers Mackie and thinks it has answered Rowe has skipped an entire burden.

ANALYSIS: A theodicy is never refuted merely by having a cost. It is *measured* by its cost. State the cost explicitly and grade the reply against it.

Local source and factual control

- John Hick's local searchable PDF, print pp. 39-52 (PDF pp. 50-64), controls the problem's statement and the Augustinian, Irenaean and process taxonomy.
- The local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion* controls the logical/evidential division, skeptical theism and the horrendous-evils literature.
- Karma discussions in the local Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma texts control the Indian material; the Nyāya administrative role and the non-theistic Buddhist, Jain and Mīmāṃsā accounts are distinguished rather than merged.
- No contemporary disaster, epidemic or conflict is used as evidence for or against a theodicy; current events appear only as illustration, never as authority.

Origin and chronology of the debate

ANALYSIS: A chronology is examinable here because the replies are historically ordered: each defence answers a specific earlier formulation, and scripts that float free of the sequence misattribute positions.

Stage	Date	Development
The dilemma transmitted by Lactantius, <i>De Ira Dei</i> 13, traditionally ascribed to Epicurus	early 4th century CE, reporting a much older tradition	willing but not able, able but not willing, neither, or both - the classical shape of the question. CAUTION: No surviving Epicurean text contains it
Augustine, <i>Enchiridion</i> and <i>City of God</i>	late 4th-early 5th century	evil as privation of good (<i>privatio boni</i>); moral evil from defective will; the Fall; "all evil is either sin or punishment for sin"
Irenaeus' image/likeness theology	2nd century, recovered later	humans made in God's <i>image</i> and required to grow into his <i>likeness</i> - the theological seed of soul-making
Leibniz, <i>Theodicee</i>	1710	the word <i>theodicy</i> itself; the best possible compossible world
John Keats' journal-letter to George and Georgiana Keats	spring 1819	coins " The vale of Soul-making " in preference to "a vale of tears"
Whitehead, <i>Process and Reality</i>	1929	creativity as ultimate; the dipolar God; "the fellow-sufferer who understands"
Hartshorne, <i>The Divine Relativity</i> (1948) and <i>Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes</i> (1984)	1948-1984	classical omnipotence argued to be incoherent
Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence", <i>Mind</i>	1955	the logical problem as a set of inconsistent propositions plus the paradox of omnipotence
Hick, <i>Evil and the God of Love</i>	1966	the Augustinian/Irenaean typology, epistemic distance, and the modern soul-making theodicy
Plantinga, <i>God, Freedom, and Evil</i>	1974	the free-will defence ; transworld depravity establishes possibility, never actuality
Griffin, <i>God, Power, and Evil: A Process Theodicy</i> (1976) and <i>Evil Revisited</i> (1991)	1976-1991	persuasive power as metaphysical necessity, not divine self-limitation
Rowe, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism"	1979	the evidential argument and the suffering fawn
Wykstra's CORNEA	1984	the epistemic-access condition that blocks the <i>noseeum</i> inference
Adams, <i>Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God</i>	1999	goodness <i>to persons</i> ; defeat within a life rather than global balancing off

ANALYSIS: Two anachronisms are penalised every year: treating Plantinga as replying to Rowe, and treating Augustine as replying to Darwinian accounts of animal pain.

Source-complete coverage ledger and learning labels

[FACT] marks retained repository doctrine and question data. **[INFERENCE]** marks the learner-facing organisation and graded verdict. This ledger maps source units to their final location rather than merely asserting reconciliation.

Source corpus and unit	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical 0-1.1: one-screen map, logical/evidential division, kinds of evil, divine profile and the three burdens	Basic Sessions 1-3	Full doctrine retained in visual-first sequence; the three burdens become the answer spine
Canonical 2(a)-(d): free-will defence, Augustinian privation, soul-making, process theodicy	Basic Sessions 5, 6, 7 and 12	Each theodicy taught with its own argument, example, objection and cost
Canonical 3 and 9.5 karma module: karma-samsāra, Nyāya's just dispenser, beginninglessness and moral caution	Basic Session 13	Retained in full, including the victim-blaming control and the duty-of-compassion rider
Canonical 4 and 10: assessment grid and inter-school debates	Basic Session 15	Preserved once as a comparative matrix rather than duplicated in two places
Canonical 5-6: statement bank and applied drills	Practice	Absorbed into the solved conceptual drills and the MCQ set
Canonical 6A: India-West parity bench	Basic Session 15	Retained complete as the highest-value comparative device in the topic
Canonical 7.1-7.4: PYQ-mapped skeletons	Practice	Absorbed into the seven complete model answers so that no answer exists twice
Canonical 9.1-9.4: logical/evidential, free-will, privation, soul-making dossiers	Basic Sessions 3, 5, 6, 7	Core doctrine taught in Basic; only second-order refinements deferred
Canonical 9.5A: greater-good, best world, mystery, eschatology, anti-theodicy	Basic Session 12	Taught as the reply-space around the classical theodicies, with compensation-is-not-defeat retained
Canonical 9.6: evil, the profane and the sacred as religion-forming categories	Basic Session 14	Kept in Basic because it is the sole owner-module for the 2019 question
Canonical 9.7: horrendous evils	Basic Session 10	Promoted to Core on 15 August 2026; taught with balancing-off versus defeat
Canonical 9.8: animal suffering	Basic Session 11	Taught with all five replies and their costs, plus the Indian parity
Canonical 9.9: skeptical theism	Basic Session 9	Promoted to Core on 15 August 2026; CORNEA and the representativeness theses stated in full
Canonical 11-13: criticisms and replies, traps, keyword and statement bank	Sessions 15-16 and final register	Preserved where each performs a distinct learning role
Canonical 14-18: PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, verdict ladder, quotation discipline	Basic Session 16	Taught as an answer-construction session rather than listed as reference tables
Premium workbook practice apparatus	MCQs and Practice	Rebuilt as 32 original diagnostics with 128 option explanations, 7 solved PYQs and 6 original models
Philosophy of Religion dossier, Topic 3	Optional Advanced	Retained in full after core practice, with the two promoted rows marked as Core

Visible answer-worthiness labels. Versions of the problem, named defences and theodicies, Indian responses and the defence/theodicy distinction are **CORE PAPER II**. Burden-matching, objection and reply, comparison and cost-grading are **CORE ANSWER**. Historical supplements and extra illustrations are **SUPPORTING**. Modal machinery, technical value theory and specialist meta-epistemology beyond the taught level is **OPTIONAL**

ADVANCED.

What to do with the material. Memorise which version each reply answers and what it costs. Understand why possibility answers Mackie but not Rowe. Use one Indian comparator deliberately rather than decoratively. Reserve transworld depravity, incommensurable-goods theory and the finer skeptical-theist theses for a high-value 15- or 20-marker.

Current evidence policy - SUPPORTING

CURRENT: No dated news item is used as evidence in this topic. Contemporary catastrophes are pedagogically vivid but philosophically neutral: they restate the evidential problem without settling it, and using them as proof would breach the repository's verification rule. Where a contemporary reference appears, it is an illustration of the *distribution* question only, and carries no probative weight for or against any theodicy.

Learning route

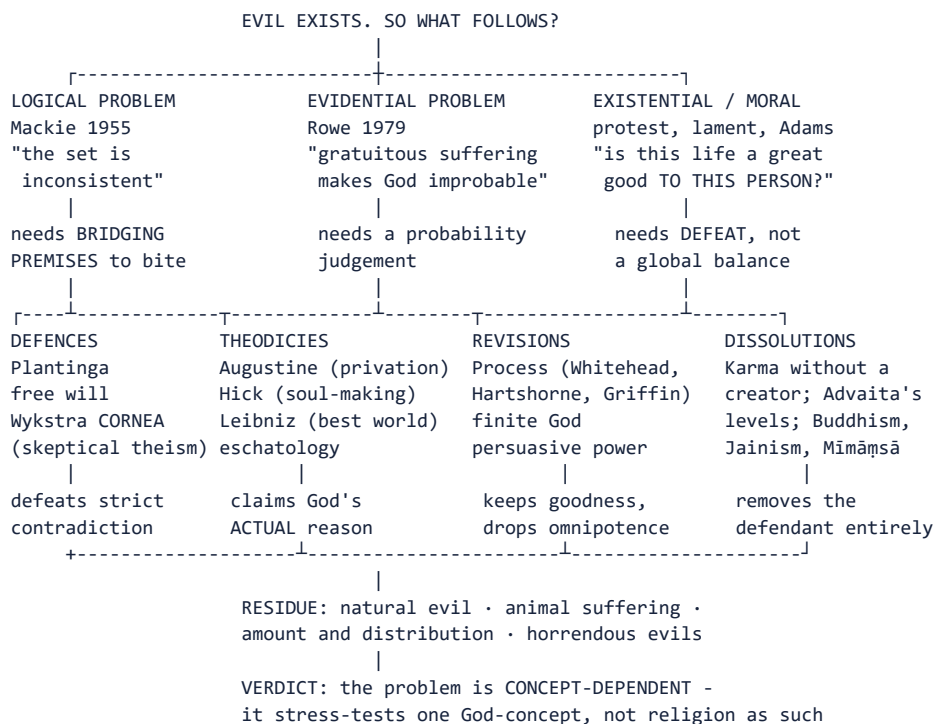
The retained source sequence moves from what the question is asking, through the classical formulation and its defences, to the evidential pressure, the hard cases, the Indian frameworks, and finally comparison and answer construction. Notions of God, rebirth mechanics, faith and religious experience appear only as bounded links or as the target of a premise; they are not silently absorbed into this topic.

UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Section B · Philosophy of Religion · Syllabus item 3

Evidence key used throughout: FACT: canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or a local source text · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis or inference for exam use · CAUTION: contested or textually variable · CURRENT: dated contemporary anchor only, never authority.

Roadmap

EXAM ROUTE High-value transition: the topic moves from naming the version of the problem, to reconstructing the classical set and its bridging premises, to testing each reply against the version it was designed for, and finally to grading what the theist has given up in order to survive.



Session	Subtopic	Core focus
1	Which problem is being asked	Versions, burdens, defence versus theodicy, the ethics of reply

Session	Subtopic	Core focus
2	Kinds of evil and the classical dilemma	Moral, natural, horrendous and animal evil; the Lactantius-transmitted dilemma
3	Mackie's logical problem	The set, the two bridging premises, why the triad alone is not contradictory
4	The paradox of omnipotence	Mackie's first- and second-order dilemma; sovereignty versus self-binding
5	Plantinga's free-will defence	Significant freedom, transworld depravity, possibility not actuality; divine responsibility
6	Augustinian privation	<i>Privatio boni</i> , defective will, the Fall, sin and punishment; inherited-guilt control
7	Hick's Irenaean soul-making	Image and likeness, epistemic distance, law-governed order, the Keats attribution
8	Rowe's evidential problem	Gratuitous evil, the suffering fawn, why possibility no longer suffices
9	Skeptical theism	CORNEA, Bergmann's representativeness theses, the <i>noseeum</i> inference and its costs
10	Horrendous evils	Adams' technical definition; balancing off versus defeat; goodness <i>to persons</i>
11	Animal suffering	Why free will and soul-making both run out; five replies and their costs
12	Process theodicy and non-classical revisions	Dipolar God, initial aim, persuasion by metaphysical necessity; Leibniz, mystery, eschatology, anti-theodicy
13	The Indian response	Karma-saṃsāra, beginninglessness, Nyāya's just dispenser, Buddhist, Jain, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita routes
14	Evil and the profane as religion-forming	Durkheim, Otto, Eliade; predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology
15	Concept-dependence and comparative synthesis	Varying the God-concept; the assessment grid and the India-West parity bench
16	Answer architecture	Directive decoder, graded verdict ladder, 10/15/20-mark construction, quotation discipline

PYQ priority: FACT: High and perfectly regular - **7 topic-owned question-parts across 2019-2025, exactly one in every paper**, spanning the religion-founding role of evil and the profane (2019), the logical problem (2020), the paradox of omnipotence (2021), divine responsibility under absolute creation (2022), Augustine's sin-and-punishment thesis (2023), concept-dependence (2024) and process theodicy (2025).

MEMORY: Master mnemonic - "F-S-P-A-K": Free-will, Soul-making, Process, Augustinian, Karma. Five ways to answer why a good God allows evil - and the Indian route needs no such God at all.

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST -----

BOOK: Book context: Authored Markdown paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Problem-of-Evil.md read in full, sections 0 through 19; local OCR-searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, print pp. 39-52, confirmed searchable and consulted for the problem's statement and the Augustinian/Irenaean/process taxonomy; the local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion* consulted for the logical-evidential division, skeptical theism and horrendous evils.

SEARCH: CA Search: "problem of evil, skeptical theism and horrendous evils - scholarly debate 2025-2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: None used as evidence. Contemporary suffering restates the evidential problem; it does not adjudicate it, and it is not cited here as proof.

SESSION 1 - WHICH PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The problem of evil is the challenge of showing how the suffering we actually observe can be squared with a God who is at once all-powerful, all-knowing and perfectly good.

Technical definition: The problem is a family of distinct arguments - logical, evidential, existential and distributional - each of which places a different burden on the theist and is answered by a different type of reply.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

There is no single problem of evil: there is a logical charge of inconsistency, an evidential charge of improbability and an existential charge about the sufferer's own life, and a reply that answers one leaves the others standing.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- logical problem
- evidential problem
- existential and moral burden
- defence
- theodicy
- morally sufficient reason

How to use them: Open by naming the version, state its burden, choose the reply-type designed for that burden, and close by saying what the reply leaves untouched.

EXAM-READY LINE: A defence shows that God *could* have a reason; a theodicy claims to say what the reason *is*; only the second is refuted by showing the proposed reason to be false.

"THE PROBLEM OF EVIL" - FOUR DIFFERENT QUESTIONS

LOGICAL	Are the propositions strictly inconsistent? Burden: show a POSSIBLE morally sufficient reason. Reply-type: DEFENCE.
EVIDENTIAL	Does the amount/kind/distribution of suffering make God improbable? Burden: restore PROBABILITY, not consistency. Reply-type: THEODICY or SKEPTICAL THEISM.
EXISTENTIAL	Can this person's life be a great good TO THEM? Burden: DEFEAT the evil within that life. Reply-type: Adams' goodness-to-persons.
DISTRIBUTION	Why THIS person rather than that one? Burden: explain allocation, not permission. Reply-type: karma; the West has no standard one.

MISMATCH = ERROR. Answering Mackie with Plantinga is correct; answering Rowe with Plantinga is a version error and loses marks.

ANALYSIS: This four-row grid is the single most examiner-pleasing device in the whole topic. Almost every UPSC stem on this clause ("what is the logical problem", "critically examine", "explain the main tenets") is answered by first locating the version and then matching the reply.

1. Three burdens, stated exactly

FACT: The full classical profile is **omnipotent + omniscient + perfectly good + creator**, confronting **evil exists**.

Omniscience is not one of the three propositions in Mackie's familiar set, but it blocks the reply that evil escaped divine notice.

Burden	What must be shown	Who carries it
Logical	The set is inconsistent, or a possible morally sufficient reason restores compatibility	Mackie presses it; Plantinga answers it
Evidential	The observed amount, kinds or distribution of suffering lowers - or does not lower - the probability of God	Rowe presses it; theodicies and Wykstra answer it
Existential / moral	A response respects lament, agency and the sufferer rather than merely balancing a world-total	Adams and the anti-theodicy tradition press it

ANALYSIS: Plantinga's defence addresses the first burden only. It does not by itself explain the actual quantity of suffering or make the divine reason probable. Saying so is itself a mark-earning move.

2. Defence versus theodicy - the distinction that separates bands

	Defence	Theodicy
Claim	God <i>could</i> have a morally sufficient reason	This <i>is</i> God's morally sufficient reason
Burden discharged	Logical consistency	Explanatory adequacy
Success condition	Bare logical possibility suffices	The proposed reason must be plausible and true
Failure condition	Only if the story is impossible	If the proposed reason is false or insufficient
Standard instances	Plantinga's free-will defence; skeptical theism	Augustine, Hick, Leibniz, process theodicy
Examiner value	Explains why Plantinga needs no evidence for transworld depravity	Explains why every theodicy carries a stated cost

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - "COULD versus IS"**: a defence says God **could** have a reason; a theodicy says what the reason **is**.

3. The ethics of replying at all ANALYSIS:

FACT: The canonical control is explicit: a causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid. Whatever its metaphysics, no reply to evil cancels the present duties of compassion, protection and relief.

- Protest or **anti-theodicy** refuses to justify suffering at all, on the ground that justification can corrupt truthfulness and displace resistance.
- The reply is that protest diagnoses the *ethics* of explanation but does not by itself settle the logical or evidential argument.
- ANALYSIS: The examiner rewards a script that states this without moralising: philosophy of religion asks whether the propositions are compatible; pastoral care asks what to say to a mourner. Confusing the two questions produces either a callous answer or an empty one.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The syllabus phrase is a bare two words - *Problem of Evil* - and the examiner therefore tests whether the candidate can *impose* structure on it:

NAME -> the version of the problem the stem is about
 RECONSTRUCT-> the set or the probability judgement as numbered steps
 MATCH -> the reply-type designed for that version
 COST -> what the reply gives up: omnipotence, personality, creator, moral confidence
 RESIDUE -> what it still leaves unexplained

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the inconsistent triad as self-contradictory without stating the bridging premises.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not call Plantinga's defence a proof of God's actual reason; it establishes possibility only.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not answer an evidential stem with a purely logical reply - the burden has changed.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not present a theodicy as refuted merely because it has a cost; state the cost and grade it.

5. ANALYSIS: Do not moralise in place of arguing, or argue as though the sufferer were absent; the topic owns both burdens.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not begin an answer with a definition of God; begin with the version of the problem, then the God-concept it presupposes.

Revision notes

- The problem of evil is a family of arguments, not one argument.
- The logical version alleges inconsistency; the evidential version alleges improbability.
- The existential version asks whether a particular life can be a great good to the person living it.
- The distributional version asks why *this* sufferer, and is India's structural strength.
- A defence needs only possibility; a theodicy claims actuality and therefore carries risk.
- Omniscience blocks the "God did not notice" reply even though it is not in Mackie's three propositions.
- Every reply must be graded by its cost as well as its coverage.
- Causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold help.
- Version-matching in the first two lines is the cheapest mark in the topic.
- The clause is examined once in every paper from 2019 to 2025, so structure is worth more than novelty.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - WHICH PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW WHICH PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS logical problem · evidential problem · existential burden · distribution · defence · theodicy · morally sufficient reason	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Name the version, state its burden, select the reply-type built for that burden, then price the reply.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST A defence that defeats Mackie leaves Rowe untouched, and a global balance leaves Adams' question unanswered.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not mismatch reply to version, and do not treat a stated cost as a refutation.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: There is no single problem of evil: there is a logical charge of inconsistency, an evidential charge of improbability and an existential charge about the sufferer's own life, and a reply that answers one leaves the others standing.			

SESSION 2 - KINDS OF EVIL AND THE CLASSICAL DILEMMA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evil in this debate means suffering and wrongdoing of any kind, divided by its source into what free agents do and what nature does.

Technical definition: **Moral evil** is harm traceable to the misuse of creaturely freedom; **natural evil** is suffering not caused by any will; **horrendous evil** is a technically defined subset that threatens the meaning of a whole life; **animal evil** is pre-human and pre-moral pain.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

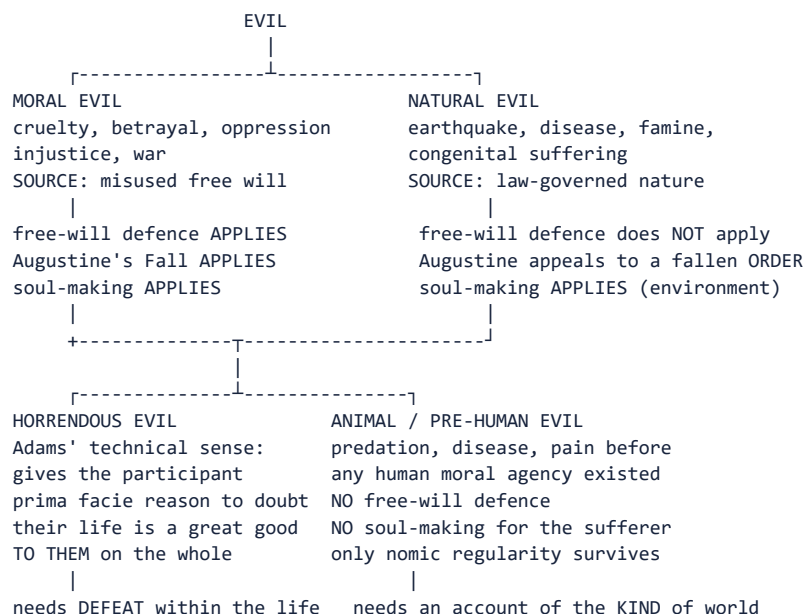
The classification is not decorative: each theodicy was built for a particular kind of evil, so a script that does not sort the evil first cannot match a reply to it afterwards.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- moral evil
- natural evil
- horrendous evil
- animal and pre-human suffering
- the Lactantius-transmitted dilemma
- quantity and distribution

How to use them: Sort the evil in the stem, then state which replies survive that sorting and which are immediately out of scope.

EXAM-READY LINE: Free will explains what agents do; it does not explain earthquakes, and it explains nothing at all about a fawn burned in a forest fire.



ANALYSIS: Sorting first is worth marks. The 2023 stem is about moral evil and punishment; the 2025 stem is about a theodicy that covers both kinds; the animal case is the standing residue in every 20-marker.

1. Moral and natural evil FACT:

	Moral evil	Natural evil
Definition	Harm arising from human wrongdoing	Suffering not caused by any will
Standard examples	Cruelty, injustice, betrayal, oppression	Earthquakes, disease, congenital disorder
Free-will defence	FACT: Direct application	ANALYSIS: No direct application
Augustinian account	FACT: Defective will; sin	ANALYSIS: Appeal to a fallen created order - CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained
Soul-making	FACT: Growth through freely chosen response	FACT: The law-governed environment in which growth is possible
Process account	FACT: Finite agency deviating from the lure	FACT: Finite causal powers, since power is intrinsically distributed
Karma	FACT: Moral causation of deeds	FACT: Explanation extended across lives, including animal births

2. The dilemma as it is actually transmitted CAUTION:

FACT: Attribution discipline. The famous "if God is willing but not able... able but not willing..." dilemma is **traditionally ascribed to Epicurus but transmitted through Lactantius, De Ira Dei 13**. CAUTION: No surviving Epicurean text contains it.

Safe formulation for the exam: *"the dilemma transmitted by Lactantius and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus."*

IS GOD WILLING TO PREVENT EVIL BUT NOT ABLE?	-> then not omnipotent
IS GOD ABLE BUT NOT WILLING?	-> then not perfectly good
IS GOD NEITHER ABLE NOR WILLING?	-> then why call this God?
IS GOD BOTH ABLE AND WILLING?	-> then whence evil?

ANALYSIS: The dilemma is rhetorically powerful and logically incomplete: it presupposes exactly the bridging premises that Session 3 makes explicit. Quoting it without those premises is what separates a lament from an argument.

3. Quantity, kind and distribution ANALYSIS:

Three separate complaints hide inside "there is too much evil":

- **Amount:** even granting that some hardship is needed, the scale seems unnecessary. **Reply:** epistemic limits and long-range goods. **Rejoinder:** unknown reasons cannot become a blanket licence.
- **Kind:** certain evils - horrendous and animal - appear to serve no developmental function at all.
- **Distribution:** why *this* person? ANALYSIS: This is the question on which Western theodicy is weakest and the karma frameworks are structurally strongest, because rebirth widens the temporal field of desert.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The examiner uses the classification to test scope discipline. A candidate who writes "free will explains evil" without qualification has silently claimed to explain earthquakes, congenital disease and animal predation - and has invited the single most common rejoinder in the topic.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not use "horrendous evil" loosely for "very bad evil"; Adams' sense is technical.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the four-horn dilemma to a surviving Epicurean text; route it through Lactantius.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat natural evil as a subspecies of moral evil without an argument; that is the Augustinian move and it needs defending.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not answer animal suffering with the free-will defence - it does not apply, and saying so earns marks.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not collapse amount, kind and distribution into one complaint; they have different replies.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not describe graphic detail; the philosophical distinction needs no illustration of that sort.

Revision notes

- Moral evil comes from misused freedom; natural evil comes from law-governed nature.
- Horrendous evil is technically defined by its threat to a whole life's goodness for the person living it.
- Animal and pre-human suffering predates moral agency and defeats both free will and soul-making for the sufferer.
- The four-horn dilemma reaches us through Lactantius, *De Ira Dei* 13; ascription to Epicurus is traditional, not textual.
- The dilemma presupposes bridging premises it does not state.
- Amount, kind and distribution are three complaints, not one.
- Distribution is the structural advantage of the karma frameworks.
- Every theodicy must be scored against the kinds of evil it actually covers.
- Sorting the evil in the first paragraph is what makes the rest of the answer matchable.
- The 2023 stem is about moral evil; the animal residue belongs in the critical section, not the exposition.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - KINDS OF EVIL AND THE CLASSICAL DILEMMA

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW KINDS OF EVIL AND THE CLASSICAL DILEMMA			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS moral evil · natural evil · horrendous evil · animal and pre-human suffering · Lactantius transmission · amount, kind, distribution	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Classify the evil in the stem, then admit which replies apply to that class and which are out of scope.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The free-will defence covers moral evil, soul-making extends to natural evil, and neither covers animal suffering for the animal.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not use "horrendous" loosely, and do not credit a surviving Epicurean text with the four-horn dilemma.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The classification is not decorative: each theodicy was built for a particular kind of evil, so a script that does not sort the evil first cannot match a reply to it afterwards.			

SESSION 3 - MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM AND THE BRIDGING PREMISES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The logical problem claims that believing in an all-powerful, wholly good God while admitting that evil exists is not merely odd but strictly self-contradictory.

Technical definition: FACT: J. L. Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence", *Mind* (1955), argues that the propositions *God is omnipotent*, *God is perfectly good* and *evil exists* form an inconsistent set - but only once two additional principles are supplied.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The three famous propositions are not formally contradictory by themselves; the contradiction is manufactured by two bridging principles, and the entire logical debate is a fight over those two principles.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- inconsistent set
- bridging premise
- quasi-logical rules
- adequate and fallacious solutions
- morally sufficient reason
- formal contradiction

How to use them: Write the propositions as a numbered set, add the bridges explicitly, then show that denying either bridge dissolves the contradiction - and say what that denial costs.

EXAM-READY LINE: The set becomes inconsistent only with the bridging premises; deny either and the contradiction dissolves - but the theist then owes an account of what a good, omnipotent being *would* tolerate, which is exactly where the evidential problem restarts.

THE SET AS USUALLY PRINTED

-
- (1) God is omnipotent
 - (2) God is perfectly good
 - (3) Evil exists

NOT a formal contradiction
- nothing in (1)-(3) entails
the negation of any other

THE SET AS IT MUST BE WRITTEN

-
- (1) God is omnipotent
 - (2) God is omniscient
 - (3) God is perfectly good
 - (4) Evil exists
- + BRIDGE A: a perfectly good being
eliminates every evil it can,
unless it has a morally
sufficient reason
- + BRIDGE B: an omnipotent being has
no non-logical limit on what it
can prevent
- NOW the set is inconsistent

THE THEIST'S THREE EXITS

deny BRIDGE A -> there IS a morally sufficient reason (defence/theodicy)
deny BRIDGE B -> omnipotence is limited (process, finite God)
deny (4)'s force -> evil is privation / empirical-level only (Augustine, Advaita)

1. Mackie's own frame FACT:

- Mackie presents the theologian as facing a set of beliefs that cannot all be true, and sorts the standard replies into **adequate solutions** - which abandon one of the beliefs - and **fallacious solutions**, which appear to keep all three but smuggle in an abandonment.
- FACT: Examples of what Mackie calls fallacious: "good cannot exist without evil", "evil is necessary as a means to good", "the universe is better with some evil", and "evil is due to human free will" - each, he argues, either limits omnipotence or redefines goodness.
- ANALYSIS: The examiner does not require Mackie's full taxonomy, but a script that names the adequate/fallacious framing shows it has read the argument rather than the slogan.

2. Why the bare triad is not a contradiction FACT:

A formal contradiction requires that the propositions, plus logic alone, entail both p and $\text{not-}p$. Nothing in "God is omnipotent", "God is perfectly good" and "evil exists" does that. What supplies the entailment are two *quasi-logical* rules about goodness and power:

Bridge	Statement	How it is attacked
A - goodness	A perfectly good being eliminates evil as far as it can	Insert "unless it has a morally sufficient reason for permitting it" - the whole space of defences and theodicies
B - power	An omnipotent being can eliminate every evil whose prevention is logically possible	Deny that free creatures who always freely choose good are within God's power to actualise (Plantinga); or deny classical omnipotence outright (Hartshorne, Griffin)

ANALYSIS: The logically possible/logically impossible boundary matters: almost every theist accepts that omnipotence does not extend to the self-contradictory. The dispute is over whether *a world of significantly free agents who never go wrong* falls inside or outside that boundary.

3. What answering the logical problem does and does not achieve ANALYSIS:

SHOW a POSSIBLE morally sufficient reason
-> the SET is consistent
-> the logical problem is DEFEATED
-> and NOTHING follows about how much suffering is likely
The atheist then reformulates:
"granted it is possible - but is it PROBABLE?"
-> Rowe 1979, Session 8

ANALYSIS: This is the highest-value sentence available in the 2020 question: the logical problem is now widely regarded as answered, and the live debate has migrated to the evidential form. Stating the migration is worth more than repeating the triad a second time.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2020 stem is exactly "*What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss.*" The marks are in the **bridging premises** and in the distinction between formal inconsistency and evidential improbability. A script that writes the three propositions, declares them contradictory and moves to free will has conceded the analytical core of the question.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not assert contradiction without the bridges; that is the single commonest failure on the 2020 stem.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the logical problem to Rowe or the evidential problem to Mackie.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Mackie "proved God does not exist"; he argued a set of beliefs is inconsistent.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "omnipotence includes the logically impossible" as the standard theist position; almost no one holds it.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not omit omniscience; without it the theist can reply that God did not know.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not finish without noting the migration to the evidential problem.

Revision notes

- Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence", *Mind*, 1955, is the canonical statement.
- The three propositions alone are not formally contradictory.
- Bridge A: a good being eliminates evil as far as it can. Bridge B: omnipotence has no relevant limit.
- Mackie sorts replies into adequate solutions and fallacious solutions.
- Inserting "unless there is a morally sufficient reason" is the theist's principal move.
- Omniscience blocks the ignorance reply and belongs in the full profile.
- Answering the logical problem establishes consistency only, never probability.
- Denying Bridge B costs classical omnipotence - the process route.

- Denying the reality of evil costs the seriousness of suffering - the privation and Advaita routes.
- The live philosophical debate has migrated to the evidential problem; say so.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM AND THE BRIDGING PREMISES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM AND THE BRIDGING PREMISES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

inconsistent set · bridging premise · quasi-logical rules · adequate and fallacious solutions · morally sufficient reason

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

State the four-proposition profile, add the goodness and power bridges, then show that each exit denies one bridge at a stated cost.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Defeating the logical problem establishes consistency only; the atheist immediately reformulates the charge as improbability.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not declare the triad self-contradictory without the bridges, and do not confuse Mackie's charge with Rowe's.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The three famous propositions are not formally contradictory by themselves; the contradiction is manufactured by two bridging principles, and the entire logical debate is a fight over those two principles.

SESSION 4 - THE PARADOX OF OMNIPOTENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The paradox of omnipotence asks whether an all-powerful being can create something it cannot afterwards control - and points out that either answer seems to limit its power.

Technical definition: FACT: Mackie's *Mind* (1955) formulation distinguishes **first-order omnipotence** (unlimited power to act on things) from **second-order omnipotence** (unlimited power to determine what powers exist), and argues that they cannot both be unrestricted.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The paradox is not a word-game about stones: it asks whether God's sovereignty is the power to control everything or the power to create genuinely uncontrollable things - and the free-will defence needs the second at the price of the first.

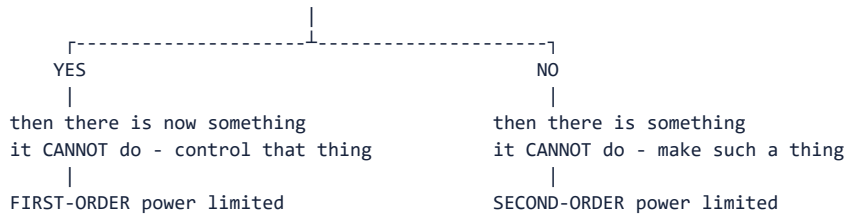
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- first-order and second-order omnipotence
- self-binding
- logically possible
- sovereignty
- significant freedom
- restriction that dissolves the paradox

How to use them: Write the paradox as a dilemma with both horns and both costs, then state the restriction that dissolves it and what that restriction concedes.

EXAM-READY LINE: If God cannot make beings he cannot control, his second-order power is limited; if he can and does, his first-order power over them is limited - so unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is incoherent, and theism must choose which sense it means.

CAN AN OMNIPOTENT BEING CREATE A THING IT CANNOT AFTERWARDS CONTROL?



MACKIE: unrestricted omnipotence in BOTH senses is incoherent

STANDARD RESTRICTIONS THAT DISSOLVE IT

- (a) omnipotence = power over the LOGICALLY POSSIBLE only
- (b) omnipotence = second-order sovereignty, freely SELF-BOUND in creation
- (c) omnipotence is abandoned as a classical attribute (process theodicy)

LINK TO EVIL: the free-will defence REQUIRES restriction (a) or (b) - God creates significantly free agents and cannot causally guarantee that they always choose well. That is a chosen self-limitation for Plantinga, and a METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY for Griffin.

1. The two orders of power FACT:

Order	What it covers	If unrestricted	If restricted
First-order	Power to act on and control existing things	God can override every creaturely choice	Creatures possess genuine, uncoerced agency
Second-order	Power to determine what powers exist at all	God can create beings with irrevocable independence	God cannot make genuinely independent beings

ANALYSIS: The paradox bites because theism traditionally wants both. The resolution always sacrifices something: either the scope of omnipotence, or the reality of creaturely freedom.

2. Three standard restrictions and their costs ANALYSIS:

- **Logical-possibility restriction:** omnipotence extends only to what is logically possible; a self-contradictory task names no task at all. **Cost:** modest, and almost universally accepted - but it does not by itself settle whether "free agents who never go wrong" is logically possible for God to actualise.
- **Self-binding sovereignty:** God's second-order power is exercised *in* creating free agents, and the resulting first-order limitation is chosen, not imposed. **Cost:** it makes divine restraint voluntary, which re-opens the question why God does not intervene in the worst cases.
- **Abandonment:** process theism denies classical omnipotence outright - power is intrinsically distributed and God's power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity. **Cost:** a God who cannot guarantee any final victory over evil.

3. Why the paradox belongs in an evil answer FACT:

The 2021 stem is "Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil." The connection is precise:

```

IF omnipotence is unrestricted in the FIRST-ORDER sense
  -> God could prevent every moral evil without loss
  -> the free-will defence FAILS
IF omnipotence is restricted by genuine creaturely freedom
  -> the free-will defence WORKS
  -> but "omnipotent" now means something the objector may refuse to grant
THEREFORE: the paradox is the hinge on which the free-will defence turns.
  
```

ANALYSIS: Route the *independent definition and coherence* of omnipotence to Notions of God; this file owns the attribute only insofar as evil places it under pressure.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The examiner wants a paradox stated as a dilemma with both horns, both costs, and then the restriction that dissolves it. A script that reduces the question to "can God make a stone too heavy to lift?" and stops has produced a puzzle, not an analysis, and has not connected the paradox to evil at all.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present the paradox only in the stone form; use the first-order/second-order distinction.

2. ANALYSIS: Do not claim the paradox disproves God; it shows that unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is incoherent.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not forget the connection to evil - the 2021 stem explicitly demands it.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate Plantinga's *chosen* restraint with Griffin's *metaphysically necessary* limitation.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not drift into the general coherence of omnipotence; that belongs to Notions of God.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "omnipotence covers the logically impossible" as a serious theistic option.

Revision notes

- Mackie's paradox appears in the same 1955 *Mind* article as the logical problem.
- First-order omnipotence is power over things; second-order omnipotence is power over what powers exist.
- Both cannot be unrestricted; the dilemma has a cost on each horn.
- The logical-possibility restriction is standard and cheap but not by itself decisive.
- Self-binding sovereignty makes restraint voluntary and re-opens the intervention question.
- Process theism abandons classical omnipotence entirely.
- The free-will defence presupposes some restriction; that is why the paradox belongs here.
- Plantinga: God *chooses* not to override. Griffin: God *cannot* coerce.
- The attribute's independent coherence belongs to Notions of God.
- Answer 2021 as a two-horned dilemma plus a dissolving restriction, explicitly tied to evil.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE PARADOX OF OMNIPOTENCE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW THE PARADOX OF OMNIPOTENCE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS first-order omnipotence · second-order omnipotence · self-binding · logically possible · significant freedom	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT State both horns with their costs, then apply the logical-possibility, self-binding or abandonment restriction and price it.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The free-will defence works only under a restriction, so the paradox is the hinge on which that defence turns.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not reduce the paradox to the stone puzzle or leave it unconnected to evil.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: If God cannot make beings he cannot control, his second-order power is limited; if he can and does, his first-order power over them is limited — so unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is incoherent, and theism must choose which sense it means.			

SESSION 5 - PLANTINGA'S FREE-WILL DEFENCE AND DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The free-will defence says that a world containing genuinely free people who sometimes choose wrongly is better than a world of guaranteed good behaviour, so God can be good and still permit moral evil.

Technical definition: FACT: **Alvin Plantinga**, *God, Freedom, and Evil* (1974), argues that significant creaturely freedom is a great good whose possibility includes morally wrong choice, so it is **possible** that God could not actualise a world containing moral good without also containing moral evil.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Plantinga's defence does not tell us why anyone actually suffers; it shows only that the theist's beliefs are not self-contradictory - and that modest claim is exactly what the logical problem required.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- significant freedom
- libertarian freedom
- transworld depravity
- defence, not theodicy
- moral good and moral evil
- divine responsibility

How to use them: Reconstruct the defence as numbered premises, state that it needs only possibility, answer the "why not always-good free agents" objection with transworld depravity, and then state the residue: natural evil.

EXAM-READY LINE: A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents, so significant freedom is a good whose price is the possibility of its misuse.

PLANTINGA'S FREE-WILL DEFENCE - AS PREMISES

- (1) A world with significantly free creatures is more valuable, other things equal, than a world with no free creatures at all.
- (2) Significant freedom entails the genuine availability of alternatives: an agent free with respect to an action can perform it or refrain.
- (3) God cannot CAUSALLY DETERMINE a creature to freely do only what is right - that description is self-cancelling.
- (4) Therefore God can create free persons only by accepting the POSSIBILITY that some will choose wrongly.
- (5) Therefore moral evil is COMPATIBLE with divine omnipotence and perfect goodness.

OBJECTION (Mackie): why not create free agents who ALWAYS freely choose the good? That is logically possible, so omnipotence covers it.

REPLY (transworld depravity): it is POSSIBLE that every creaturely essence God could instantiate would go wrong in some circumstance. If so, a world of free agents who never go wrong was not available to God to actualise.

STATUS OF THE REPLY: POSSIBILITY ONLY. Plantinga never claims transworld depravity is ACTUAL - and does not need to.

RESIDUE: natural evil. The defence is silent about earthquakes unless it is extended by a further hypothesis.

1. What "defence" means here FACT:

- The defence's target is Mackie's **logical** claim, and its success condition is bare logical possibility. That is why Plantinga is entitled to a hypothesis he does not assert to be true.
- FACT: Contrast: a theodicy claims to identify God's *actual* morally sufficient reason and is therefore refuted if the proposed reason is false.
- ANALYSIS: Presupposition to state: libertarian freedom must be coherent and sufficiently valuable. A compatibilist who denies premise (3) rejects the defence at its root; naming that is a mark-earning move.

2. Transworld depravity, stated carefully FACT:

ANALYSIS: The technical claim is that a creaturely essence suffers **transworld depravity** if, whatever circumstances God places it in where it acts freely, it goes wrong at least once. Plantinga's claim is that it is *possible* that every essence God could instantiate suffers from it.

Question	Answer
Does Plantinga assert it is actual?	WRONG: No. Possibility suffices for a defence
Does it explain the amount of suffering?	WRONG: No
Does it answer the evidential argument?	WRONG: No; that is Session 8
What does it do?	FACT: Blocks Mackie's "God could have made only-good free agents" reply

3. The 2022 stem: absolute creation and human responsibility ANALYSIS:

The 2022 question runs: "*If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine.*"

THE STEM'S ARGUMENT

God creates everything, including the agent, its powers and the circumstances of its choice
|
therefore every act traces back to the creator
|
therefore human responsibility is an illusion

THE REPLIES

- (a) FREE-WILL DEFENCE: God creates the CAPACITY, the agent supplies the ACT; authorship of the act is the agent's
- (b) PRIVATION: God creates natures, not the defect in them; evil is a lack, not a created substance
- (c) FOREKNOWLEDGE ≠ CAUSATION: knowing what will freely occur does not make it occur
- (d) PROCESS: God does not have the unilateral power the stem assumes

REJOINDER RETAINED: ANALYSIS: knowingly choosing to instantiate the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant even if it is not causation. A first-class script concedes this and grades it.

ANALYSIS: **Scope check first.** The stem is about **moral** evil and creaturely responsibility. Natural evil is relevant only as the residue that the free-will reply cannot reach.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The examiner is testing whether the candidate knows what a defence is *for*. The commonest error is to present transworld depravity as a discovery about human nature and then to attack it as empirically unsupported - an objection that misses the modal point entirely.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not call the free-will defence a theodicy; Plantinga explicitly offers a defence.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present transworld depravity as an actual fact about people.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use the defence against the evidential problem; the burden there is probability.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit natural evil as the acknowledged residue.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Augustine's theological free-will account with Plantinga's modal argument; they belong to different centuries and different projects.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2022 stem with theology; it is a question about agency, authorship and responsibility.

Revision notes

- *God, Freedom, and Evil* (1974) is the canonical source.
- The defence answers Mackie's logical charge and needs only possibility.
- Significant freedom entails genuinely available alternatives.
- God cannot causally determine a creature to act freely; the description cancels itself.
- Transworld depravity is a possibility claim, never an actuality claim.
- The defence is strongest for moral evil and silent about natural evil.
- Libertarian freedom is the presupposition a compatibilist will deny.
- The 2022 stem is about authorship: God creates the capacity, the agent supplies the act.
- Foreknowledge does not cause free action, but knowingly instantiating the system remains morally relevant.
- A world of programmed beneficence lacks moral authorship - that is the sentence to write.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PLANTINGA'S FREE-WILL DEFENCE AND DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW PLANTINGA'S FREE-WILL DEFENCE AND DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS significant freedom · libertarian freedom · transworld depravity · defence not theodicy · moral authorship	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Free creatures cannot be causally determined to choose well, so God can create them only by accepting the possibility of misuse.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The logical charge is defeated, but the amount of suffering and all natural evil remain untouched.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not treat transworld depravity as an empirical claim or deploy the defence against Rowe.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Plantinga's defence does not tell us why anyone actually suffers; it shows only that the theist's beliefs are not self-contradictory — and that modest claim is exactly what the logical problem required.			

SESSION 6 - AUGUSTINE: PRIVATION, DEFECTIVE WILL, SIN AND PUNISHMENT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Augustine argues that evil is not a thing God made but a hole in something good - a failure of what ought to be there - and that human wrongdoing and its consequences explain the rest.

Technical definition: FACT: Evil is **privation of a due good (privatio boni)**, not a positive substance; culpable evil originates in **defective will**; and the printed 2023 thesis is that *"all evil is either sin or the punishment for sin."*

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Augustine's achievement is metaphysical rather than pastoral: he shows how evil can be real without being created, but he does not thereby show why a good creator permitted the conditions in which the privation occurs.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- privation of good (privatio boni)
- defective will
- parasitic on good
- the Fall
- sin and punishment for sin
- convertibility of being and goodness

How to use them: Reconstruct the metaphysics before objecting to it - the 2023 directive requires the author's own system first.

EXAM-READY LINE: Calling blindness a privation does not call it unreal: it is a real lack in a subject that ought to possess sight, and the reality of the lack is precisely what makes it evil.

AUGUSTINE'S ARGUMENT - AS PREMISES

- (1) Being, insofar as it is being, is good.
- (2) God creates beings; God does not create evil substances.
- (3) Corruption is parasitic: it depends on a good nature to corrupt.
- (4) Moral fault is DISORDERED WILLING - the will turning from a greater good to a lesser one.
- (5) Therefore evil is PRIVATION, not a rival creative principle.

THE 2023 THESIS: "all evil is either sin or the punishment for sin"

MORAL EVIL = SIN	NATURAL EVIL = PUNISHMENT
misuse of created freedom	a fallen, disordered order
the will's own defect	consequent on the Fall

CANONICAL EXAMPLE: rot is not a rival substance to wood;
it is the loss of the wood's proper integrity.

OBJECTIONS THAT MUST BE STATED

- ANALYSIS: innocent suffering and animal pain resist a punishment reading
ANALYSIS: "privation" is metaphysically strained for intense positive pain
ANALYSIS: inherited guilt is morally harder to defend than inherited condition
ANALYSIS: CAUTION: a fallen natural order is historically and scientifically strained

1. Privation stated so that it is not a denial of suffering FACT:

ANALYSIS: The commonest misreading is that **privation makes pain imaginary**. It does not. A privation is a *real absence of a good that ought to be present in this subject*. Blindness is not nothing; it is a determinate lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight.

Claim	What it establishes	What it does not establish
Evil is privation	Evil has no independent creative source; dualism is avoided	That any particular privation was justified

Claim	What it establishes	What it does not establish
Being and goodness are convertible	God's creation is wholly good as created	That the created order is presently undamaged
Corruption is parasitic	Evil presupposes and depends on good	That the parasite is harmless or unreal

2. The inherited-guilt control ANALYSIS:

FACT: Two readings of inherited fallenness must be separated:

- **Personal inherited guilt:** later persons are personally culpable for an ancestor's act. ANALYSIS: Morally the harder claim to defend.
- **Inherited damaged condition:** later persons inherit a disordered condition and a disordered social-natural order without personal guilt. ANALYSIS: This reduces the inherited-guilt objection - but it still owes an account of why a good creator permits the condition and its unequal effects.

ANALYSIS: A first-class 20-mark script names both readings and shows that the second is the defensible one *and* that it does not close the question.

3. Where the account is strongest and weakest ANALYSIS:

STRONGEST

metaphysical economy: no evil
principle, no dualism
moral evil: defective will
preserves the creator's goodness
explains dependence of evil on good

WEAKEST

innocent suffering: infants,
congenital disease
animal pain, pre-human suffering
a "fallen order" preceding humanity
the retributive framing of natural evil

CONTRAST TO DEPLOY: Hick's soul-making replaces PUNISHMENT with DEVELOPMENT; Indian karma replaces a single Fall with a beginningless series that answers DISTRIBUTION.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2023 stem is a quotation with the directive *Critically discuss*, so the examiner is buying (i) faithful reconstruction of Augustine's own system, then (ii) evaluation. CAUTION: Treat the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a verified verbatim translation; the safest formulation attributes the doctrine to Augustine and analyses the printed stem as given.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say privation makes pain imaginary.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not object before reconstructing; the directive requires the system first.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not present the printed sentence as a certified verbatim translation.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat inherited guilt and inherited condition as the same claim.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not forget that a fallen order preceding human history is CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude that Augustine simply fails; conclude that he preserves God's goodness for moral evil while remaining incomplete for natural and innocent suffering.

Revision notes

- Sources: Augustine, *Enchiridion* and *City of God*.
- Evil is privation of a due good, not a created substance.
- Being and goodness are convertible; corruption is parasitic on a good nature.
- Moral fault is disordered willing - turning from a greater good to a lesser.
- The 2023 thesis divides evil into sin and punishment for sin.
- Rot in wood is the canonical example of parasitic privation.
- Privation is a *real* lack, not an illusion of suffering.
- Inherited condition is defensible; inherited personal guilt is not.

- Innocent and animal suffering are the standing objections.
- Verdict: preserves divine goodness for moral evil; incomplete for natural and innocent suffering.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - AUGUSTINE: PRIVATION, DEFECTIVE WILL, SIN AND PUNISHMENT

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW AUGUSTINE - PRIVATION, DEFECTIVE WILL, SIN AND PUNISHMENT			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS privation of good (privatio boni) · defective will · parasitic corruption · the Fall · sin and punishment for sin	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Being is good, God creates beings, corruption is a parasitic lack, and culpable evil is disordered willing.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Dualism is avoided and moral evil is explained, but innocent and animal suffering resist the punishment framing.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not say privation makes pain unreal, and do not object before reconstructing Augustine's own system.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Augustine's achievement is metaphysical rather than pastoral: he shows how evil can be real without being created, but he does not thereby show why a good creator permitted the conditions in which the privation occurs.			

SESSION 7 - HICK'S IRENAEAN SOUL-MAKING

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Soul-making theodicy says the world is not meant to be a comfortable place but a school: God creates people unfinished, at a distance from himself, in a world with real risk, so that they can grow into genuine goodness.

Technical definition: FACT: John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love* (1966), develops the **Irenaean** line - humans are created in God's *image* and must grow into his *likeness* - through **epistemic distance**, genuine freedom and a stable, law-governed order.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Ready-made virtue is not achieved virtue: courage requires danger and compassion requires another's need, so a world engineered to prevent all suffering would also prevent the goods that make persons.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- soul-making
- image and likeness (Irenaeus)
- epistemic distance
- law-governed world
- vale of Soul-making (Keats)
- eschatological fulfilment

How to use them: State the developmental rationale, distinguish it from punishment, add epistemic distance and nomic regularity, then price the eschatological reply.

EXAM-READY LINE: Soul-making is developmental, not retributive: suffering is not deserved payment but the environment in which freely achieved virtue becomes possible.

HICK'S ARGUMENT - AS PREMISES

- (1) Ready-made virtue is not ACHIEVED virtue.
- (2) Courage, compassion and trust require real difficulty, real need and real risk.
- (3) A world in which such virtues are possible must be LAW-GOVERNED and must therefore permit harmful consequences.
- (4) Humans are created IMMATURE, at an EPISTEMIC DISTANCE from God, so that faith and love are freely reached, not compelled.
- (5) Therefore suffering can be the ENVIRONMENT of soul-making.

IRENÆAN vs AUGUSTINIAN TYPOLOGY (Hick's own division)

AUGUSTINIAN	IRENÆAN
humanity created perfect	humanity created IMMATURE
FALL from that state	GROWTH toward likeness
evil = privation + sin	evil = the environment of development
backward-looking	forward-looking, teleological
retributive framing	

ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE FACT:

"The vale of Soul-making" is JOHN KEATS'S phrase, from his journal-letter to George and Georgiana Keats, spring 1819, where he prefers it to "a vale of tears".

- > IRENAEUS supplies the THEOLOGY (image/likeness)
- > KEATS supplies the PHRASE
- > HICK supplies the modern THEODICY

Do NOT attribute the phrase to Irenaeus or call it Hick's coinage.

OBJECTIONS

ANALYSIS: scale and proportionality: much suffering builds nothing

ANALYSIS: animal suffering: the animal does not morally grow

ANALYSIS: the reply is ESCHATOLOGICAL - universal fulfilment - and therefore depends on contested afterlife commitments

1. Epistemic distance, stated precisely FACT:

ANALYSIS: Epistemic distance is not divine hiding for its own sake. It is the claim that if God's reality were overwhelmingly evident, response would be compelled rather than freely given, and the relationship sought would be impossible. A world that is *religiously ambiguous* is therefore a condition of free faith.

ANALYSIS: **Boundary note:** the wider question of divine hiddenness as an independent argument, and the epistemology of faith, belong to *Reason, Revelation and Faith*. Here epistemic distance appears only as a structural component of Hick's theodicy.

2. Why the world must be law-governed ANALYSIS:

IF nature were adjusted ad hoc to prevent every harm

- > no reliable consequences
- > no genuine deliberation, planning or responsibility
- > no moral agency at all

THEREFORE a stable nomic order is a condition of agency, and such an order will sometimes injure.

COST: this explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT of pain in it.
Session 8 and Session 11 press exactly that gap.

3. Coverage and cost ANALYSIS:

Feature	Soul-making
Moral evil	FACT: Growth through freely chosen response
Natural evil	FACT: The environment of growth - its principal advantage over the free-will defence
Animal suffering	ANALYSIS: Weak: instrumentalises animals or leaves them out
Horrendous evil	ANALYSIS: Weak: some suffering destroys rather than builds persons
Attribute preserved	FACT: Purposive goodness
Chief cost	ANALYSIS: Proportionality, and dependence on a universal eschatological fulfilment

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: Soul-making is the theodicy most often reduced to a slogan. The canonical trap is explicit: do not reduce Hick to "suffering makes us stronger". The marks are in **epistemic distance**, **freedom**, and the **law-governed order** - the three components that convert a platitude into a theodicy.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce Hick to "suffering makes us stronger".
2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute "vale of Soul-making" to Irenaeus or present it as Hick's coinage.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse the developmental rationale with retributive punishment.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit epistemic distance; it is what makes the freedom genuine.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present the eschatological reply as uncontroversial; it depends on contested afterlife commitments.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not claim soul-making solves animal suffering; it instrumentalises it at best.

Revision notes

- *Evil and the God of Love* (1966) is the source of "epistemic distance" and the Irenaean/Augustinian typology.
- Irenaeus supplies the image/likeness theology of growth.
- Keats coined "The vale of Soul-making" in the spring 1819 journal-letter; Hick adopted it.
- Ready-made virtue is not achieved virtue.
- Courage requires danger; compassion requires another's need.
- A law-governed world is a condition of agency and will sometimes injure.
- The theodicy is developmental and forward-looking, not retributive.
- It covers natural evil better than the free-will defence does.
- Its costs are proportionality, animal suffering and dependence on universal fulfilment.
- Hick's typology is itself examinable: Augustinian looks back to a Fall, Irenaean looks forward to a likeness.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HICK'S IRENAEAN SOUL-MAKING

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW HICK'S IRENAEAN SOUL-MAKING			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS soul-making · image and likeness · epistemic distance · law-governed order · vale of Soul-making (Keats) · eschatological fulfilment	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Achieved virtue requires real risk, so a stable world at an epistemic distance from God is the condition of free moral growth.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST It covers natural evil better than the free-will defence, but proportionality, animal pain and the afterlife premise remain live costs.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not reduce it to a slogan or misattribute the Keats phrase.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Ready-made virtue is not achieved virtue: courage requires danger and compassion requires another's need, so a world engineered to prevent all suffering would also prevent the goods that make persons.			

SESSION 8 - ROWE'S EVIDENTIAL PROBLEM AND GRATUITOUS EVIL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The evidential problem grants that God and evil are not strictly contradictory, and argues instead that the sheer amount and pointlessness of suffering makes God's existence unlikely.

Technical definition: FACT: **William Rowe**, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism" (1979), argues from instances of intense suffering for which no justifying good is discernible to the conclusion that gratuitous evil probably exists, and therefore that an omnipotent, wholly good being probably does not.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Once the logical charge is answered, the argument does not disappear; it changes shape, and the theist who has proved consistency has still not made divine permission probable.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **evidential problem**

- gratuitous / pointless evil
- the suffering fawn
- probability rather than contradiction
- inductive inference
- the noseeum step

How to use them: Set out the argument as an inference with an explicit inductive step, identify the fawn as an *evidential* case, then show that the theist's reply must attack either the inductive step or the probability judgement.

EXAM-READY LINE: Rowe's fawn is not a deductive contradiction but an evidential case: it asks not whether God *could* have a reason, but whether it is reasonable to think one exists.

ROWE'S EVIDENTIAL ARGUMENT - AS STEPS

- (1) There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without thereby losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (2) An omniscient, wholly good being would prevent the occurrence of any intense suffering it could, unless it could not do so without losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (3) Therefore there does not exist an omnipotent, omniscient, wholly good being.

THE CANONICAL CASE - THE SUFFERING FAWN

a fawn is trapped in a forest fire started by lightning, is severely burned, and lies suffering for days before dying; no human observes it, and no moral growth follows from it.

WHAT THE CASE IS FOR: premise (1) - the EVIDENTIAL claim

WHAT IT IS NOT: a deductive contradiction

THE THEIST'S THREE ROUTES

- attack the INFERENCE from "no reason seen" to "no reason"
-> SKEPTICAL THEISM (Session 9)
- supply a POSITIVE REASON -> theodicy (Sessions 6, 7, 12)
- revise the GOD-CONCEPT so premise (2) no longer applies
-> process theism, finite God, non-creator systems

ANALYSIS: (a) and (b) sit AWKWARDLY together: to say "I cannot see the reason and neither can you" while also saying "here is the reason" is a tension the examiner rewards you for noticing.

1. Why the burden really has changed FACT:

	Logical problem	Evidential problem
Charge	The set is inconsistent	Theism is improbable given the evidence
Needed to defeat it	A possible morally sufficient reason	A reason to think permission is likely
Adequate reply	Defence	Theodicy, skeptical theism, or concept-revision
Rowe's own position	Grants consistency	Presses probability
Standard error	Applying Plantinga here	Applying a probability reply to Mackie

ANALYSIS: Rowe himself frames the argument as supporting a *variety* of atheism that acknowledges the theist may be rational; the argument claims evidential force, not demonstration.

2. The inductive step, isolated ANALYSIS:

"I can see no justifying reason for this evil."
↓ <- THIS STEP is the whole battleground
"There is no justifying reason for this evil."
↓
"Gratuitous evil exists."
↓
"An omnipotent, wholly good God probably does not exist."

ANALYSIS: The step is an inference from ignorance to absence. It is not automatically fallacious: we make such inferences constantly and correctly when we would expect to see the thing if it were there. Everything therefore turns on whether we *would* expect to discern a divine justifying reason - which is precisely Wykstra's question.

3. Why the fawn was chosen ANALYSIS:

The case is deliberately constructed to strip away every standard theodicy at once:

- No human free will is involved - the free-will defence is out of scope.
- No one learns anything from it - soul-making has no purchase for the sufferer.
- The animal cannot be said to deserve it - a retributive reading is unavailable.
- It is unobserved - even indirect human moral benefit is removed.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The distinction between the logical and evidential problems is the discipline the examiner enforces across this whole clause: the canonical trap is to conflate logical inconsistency, evidential improbability and the omnipotence paradox, and to match each theodicy to the version it addresses. A script that knows the fawn is evidential has already avoided the most heavily penalised error in the topic.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present Rowe's fawn as a deductive contradiction.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the evidential argument with the free-will defence alone.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say the evidential argument "proves" atheism; it claims probabilistic force.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the inference from unseen reason to absent reason as obviously fallacious; argue the case.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not deploy skeptical theism and a positive theodicy in the same paragraph without noticing the tension.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the reason the fawn case was built the way it was.

Revision notes

- Rowe, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism", 1979.
- The argument grants logical consistency and attacks probability.
- Premise (1) is the evidential claim; the fawn is its illustration.
- Premise (2) is a claim about what a wholly good being would do.
- The inductive step runs from "no reason seen" to "no reason exists".
- The fawn is designed to exclude free will, soul-making, desert and observer benefit.
- The theist may attack the inference, supply a reason, or revise the God-concept.
- Attacking the inference is skeptical theism; supplying a reason is theodicy.
- The two replies sit awkwardly together; say so.
- Version-confusion between Mackie and Rowe is the most penalised error in this clause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ROWE'S EVIDENTIAL PROBLEM AND GRATUITOUS EVIL

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ROWE'S EVIDENTIAL PROBLEM AND GRATUITOUS EVIL			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS evidential problem · gratuitous evil · the suffering fawn · inductive step · probability not contradiction	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT From undiscernible justifying goods infer gratuitous evil, and from gratuitous evil infer the improbability of a wholly good omnipotent being.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST A defence that answered Mackie is useless here, because the burden is now probability rather than consistency.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not treat the fawn as a deductive case or combine skeptical theism with a positive theodicy unreflectively.

SESSION 9 - SKEPTICAL THEISM AND CORNEA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Skeptical theism does not try to say why God permits suffering. It argues that we are in no position to tell whether a justifying reason exists, so our failure to find one proves very little.

Technical definition: FACT: Skeptical theism attacks the *inference* in the evidential argument - from "I can see no justifying reason for this evil" to "there is no justifying reason". Its principal proponents are **Stephen Wykstra**, **William Alston**, **Michael Bergmann** and **Daniel Howard-Snyder**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Skeptical theism is the strongest available defensive reply to the evidential argument and the most corrosive one: it neutralises the atheist's inference only by conceding that the moral structure of the universe is opaque to us.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORNEA
- the noseeum inference
- representativeness theses
- defence, not theodicy
- cognitive access
- moral-scepticism objection

How to use them: State CORNEA or Bergmann's theses explicitly; never let "God's ways are mysterious" stand in for the position.

EXAM-READY LINE: One may claim that it *appears* that p is absent only if it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p would likely be discernible if it were there.

WYKSTRA'S CORNEA (1984)

Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access

"It appears that p is absent" is a legitimate claim ONLY IF it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p WOULD LIKELY BE DISCERNIBLE if it were there.

BERGMANN'S REPRESENTATIVENESS THESES

our sample of (i) possible GOODS, (ii) possible EVILS, and (iii) the ENTAILMENT RELATIONS between them is NOT representative of the total space

THEREFORE the NOSEEUM inference -

"no see 'um, so none there" - is UNWARRANTED for goods that would justify divine permission

ANALOGIES

ALSTON: a novice examines a grandmaster's move, sees no point in it, and has no warrant to conclude there is none

WYKSTRA: an infant cannot see why a painful procedure is done; that inability is no evidence that there is no reason

WHAT IT IS: a DEFENCE against the EVIDENTIAL argument

WHAT IT IS NOT: a theodicy; and it does not target the LOGICAL problem

1. Presupposition and scope ANALYSIS:

- **Presupposition:** that the relevant justifying goods would plausibly exceed human cognitive reach, and that the theist may appeal to that gap without special pleading.
- **Scope:** FACT: it targets the **evidential**, not the **logical**, problem. FACT: It is compatible with also holding a positive theodicy, though the two sit awkwardly together - the optional residue is precisely that a candidate should

not deploy both in the same paragraph.

2. The three standing objections, with replies and residues ANALYSIS:

Objection	Statement	Reply	Residue
Moral scepticism (Michael Almeida, Bruce Russell, Erik Wielenberg)	If we cannot judge that an evil is gratuitous, we equally cannot judge that we ought to <i>prevent</i> it - perhaps God permits it for an unseen good	Obligation is fixed by what we <i>know</i> , not by unknown all-things-considered value	ANALYSIS: Critics find the reply unstable; the duty to rescue is exactly what the scepticism seems to unsettle
Divine deception / parity	The same scepticism undercuts confidence in divine promises, revelation and God's goodness	Restrict the scepticism to the value-entailment domain only	ANALYSIS: The restriction looks <i>ad hoc</i>
Bracketing / unfalsifiability	If extended, no empirical evidence could ever count against theism	-	ANALYSIS: The position becomes unfalsifiable, which is a cost even if it is not a refutation

3. Indian parity ANALYSIS:

Structurally analogous moves exist in the Indian material:

- The Nyāya and Vedāntic appeal that the workings of **unseen moral potency (adṛṣṭa)** are **beyond the senses (atīndriya)** and known only through scriptural testimony (*śabda*).
- The Buddhist treatment of the precise ripening of karma as one of the **imponderables (acinteyya)** - matters not profitable to speculate about.

ANALYSIS: The parallel is genuine, and it inherits the same objection: a mechanism placed permanently beyond checking cannot be evidence either for or against.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The canonical trap is explicit: **do not let "God's ways are mysterious" stand in for skeptical theism**. Either state CORNEA or Bergmann's representativeness theses, or do not use the position at all. A named, formulated epistemic principle is worth several marks; a gesture at mystery is worth none - and mystery without an access principle is an unfalsifiable appeal, of which skeptical theism is the disciplined version.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present skeptical theism as a theodicy; it denies the atheist's inference.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not substitute "God works in mysterious ways" for CORNEA.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not apply it to the logical problem; it addresses the evidential one.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the moral-scepticism cost; it is the position's standing price.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the *noseeum* inference as always fallacious; CORNEA specifies exactly when it fails.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not present the Indian parallel as an endorsement; it inherits the same unfalsifiability objection.

Revision notes

- Proponents: Wykstra, Alston, Bergmann, Howard-Snyder.
- CORNEA (1984) is the Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access.
- Bergmann's three theses deny that our sample of goods, evils and their relations is representative.
- The *noseeum* inference - "no see 'um, so none there" - is the target.
- Alston's grandmaster and Wykstra's infant are the canonical analogies.
- It is a defence, not a theodicy, and it addresses the evidential problem only.
- Objection 1: it threatens ordinary moral reasoning and the duty to rescue.
- Objection 2: it undercuts confidence in divine promises unless restricted *ad hoc*.
- Objection 3: extended far enough, it makes theism unfalsifiable.
- Indian parallels: *adṛṣṭa* as *atīndriya*; karmic ripening among the *acinteyya*.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SKEPTICAL THEISM AND CORNEA

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | SKEPTICAL THEISM AND CORNEA

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

CORNEA · noseum inference · representativeness theses · defence not theodicy · cognitive access

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

An appearance of absence licenses a claim of absence only where the thing would likely be discernible if present, and divine justifying goods are not.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The evidential inference is blocked, but at the price of conceding that the universe's moral structure is opaque to us.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not substitute an appeal to mystery for a stated epistemic principle.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Skeptical theism is the strongest available defensive reply to the evidential argument and the most corrosive one: it neutralises the atheist's inference only by conceding that the moral structure of the universe is opaque to us.

SESSION 10 - HORRENDOUS EVILS: BALANCING OFF VERSUS DEFEAT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Some evils are so devastating that even if the world as a whole comes out well, the person who lived through them may have no reason to think their own life was worth living - and that is a different problem from the general one.

Technical definition: FACT: **Marilyn McCord Adams**, *Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God* (1999), defines a **horrendous evil** as one whose participation - as perpetrator or as victim - gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt whether their life could be **a great good to them on the whole**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Global balancing is not personal defeat: a world can be good on the whole while a particular life is not, and a God who is good *to persons* owes an answer at the level of the person.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- horrendous evil (technical sense)
- balancing off
- defeat (Chisholm's term)
- goodness to persons
- global versus local/personal
- incommensurable good

How to use them: Use Adams' definition in its exact sense, distinguish balancing off from defeat, and state that compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it.

EXAM-READY LINE: A later good can compensate for loss while leaving the evil merely balanced; Adams' stronger requirement is that a horrendous evil be *defeated within the person's life as a whole*.

ADAMS' ARGUMENT - AS PREMISES

- (1) Standard theodicies work at the GLOBAL level: they seek a reason why God permits evil IN GENERAL, balancing it within the world's total value.
- (2) But horrendous evils threaten the INDIVIDUAL'S LIFE AS A WHOLE: a global balance can be struck while a particular person's life remains, for them, a net disaster.
- (3) A God who is good TO PERSONS - not merely a good PRODUCER OF WORLDS - must therefore DEFEAT the horrendous evil WITHIN the frame of the individual's life.
- (4) Only resources internal to a particular religion - divine identification with human suffering, beatific intimacy with God as an INCOMMENSURABLE good - can accomplish that defeat.

THE DISTINCTION THAT EARNS THE MARKS

BALANCING OFF the good OUTWEIGHS the evil in a sum evil remains EXTERNAL to the good	DEFEAT (Chisholm's term) the evil becomes an ORGANIC PART of a whole whose value it CONTRIBUTES to evil is INTEGRATED, not offset
GLOBAL defeat at the level of the world what theodicies deliver	LOCAL / PERSONAL defeat within THIS life, for THIS person what Adams says is required

ANALYSIS: COMPENSATION IS NOT DEFEAT. Paying someone afterwards leaves the evil externally balanced; it does not make the life a great good TO THEM from within.

1. The definition, used correctly FACT:

ANALYSIS: The canonical trap is explicit: **do not use "horrendous evil" loosely for "very bad evil"**. Adams' cases involve grave betrayal, coerced participation in severe wrongdoing and devastating violence against intimate relations - and graphic detail is unnecessary for the philosophical distinction. What makes an evil horrendous is not its intensity as such but the *doubt it gives the participant about the worth of their own life on the whole*.

2. Presupposition, objection and reply ANALYSIS:

Element	Content
Presupposition	ANALYSIS: That goodness-to-persons is a distinct, non-negotiable requirement; that there are incommensurable goods - for Adams, relationship with God - that can defeat rather than merely counterbalance; and, controversially, that the theodist may use religion-specific resources rather than only "generic theism"
Objection 1	ANALYSIS: The reply is purely eschatological and unverifiable, and it seems to make the horrendous evil instrumentally necessary
Reply 1	FACT: Adams denies instrumentality: the evil need not be <i>required</i> ; it must be <i>defeated</i>
Objection 2	ANALYSIS: Using religion-specific resources abandons the neutral philosophical arena
Reply 2	FACT: The atheological argument targets a <i>particular</i> theism, so a particular theism may answer
Canonical example	FACT: A person coerced into grave harm against someone they love: no aggregate of unrelated goods automatically makes that life a great good to that person from within

3. Indian parity - the highest-value paragraph in a 20-marker ANALYSIS:

THE QUESTION ADAMS ASKS: is THIS life a great good TO THIS PERSON?

KARMA answers a DIFFERENT question - it explains the DISTRIBUTION of horrendous suffering (why this person) but does not by itself show that the sufferer's life is a great good TO THEM.

ADVAITA answers by SUBLATION at the ultimate level: the standpoint from which the life is evaluated is itself provisional.

BUDDHIST LIBERATION answers by ENDING the standpoint of suffering rather than by redeeming its content.

ANALYSIS: CRITICS call this evasive; DEFENDERS call it therapeutic. Stating both readings is the mark-earning move.

ANALYSIS: CONTRAST TO NAME: defeat WITHIN the life (Adams) versus EXIT from the life-series (mokṣa/nirvāṇa).

ANALYSIS: Route rebirth mechanics and the metaphysics of liberation to *Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation*; this file owns them only as answers to suffering.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: Horrendous evils were promoted to Core on 15 August 2026 together with the balancing-off/defeat distinction and goodness-to-persons. The examiner uses them to separate scripts that treat theodicy as world-accountancy from scripts that notice the person. The optional residue - whether "defeat within the life of the sufferer" is a theodicy at all, or an admission that no general theodicy succeeds - belongs in the closing verdict of a 20-marker.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not use "horrendous evil" as a synonym for "terrible evil".
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat compensation as defeat.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit Chisholm's term when using "defeat" technically.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not claim Adams makes the evil instrumentally necessary; she denies it.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present karma as answering Adams' question; it answers distribution.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not give graphic detail; the distinction is philosophical.

Revision notes

- *Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God* (1999) is the source.
- A horrendous evil gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt their life is a great good to them on the whole.
- Perpetrators as well as victims can be participants.
- Standard theodicies operate globally; Adams demands a personal-level answer.
- Balancing off is a sum; defeat is organic integration - Chisholm's term.
- God must be good *to persons*, not merely a good producer of worlds.
- Only religion-specific resources - divine identification, beatific intimacy - can defeat.
- The eschatological and particularist objections both have Adams' replies.
- Karma explains distribution but not personal worth; Advaita and Buddhism dissolve the evaluating standpoint.
- Compensation is not defeat: this sentence is worth writing verbatim.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HORRENDOUS EVILS: BALANCING OFF VERSUS DEFEAT

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | HORRENDOUS EVILS - BALANCING OFF VERSUS DEFEAT

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE
horrendous evil (technical) · balancing off · defeat (Chisholm) · goodness to persons · incommensurable good · global versus personal	Global theodicy balances world-totals, but a person-level requirement demands that the evil be defeated within the individual life.	Compensation leaves the evil externally balanced, and karma answers distribution rather than personal worth.	Do not use the term loosely, and do not treat later compensation as defeat.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Global balancing is not personal defeat: a world can be good on the whole while a particular life is not, and a God who is good to persons owes an answer at the level of the person.

SESSION 11 - ANIMAL SUFFERING AND THE PRE-HUMAN PROBLEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Animals were being torn apart, starving and dying of disease for hundreds of millions of years before any human being existed - and none of the usual explanations for suffering apply to them.

Technical definition: FACT: Animal pain from predation, disease and pre-human natural processes is a hard form of natural evil because **no free-will defence and no soul-making rationale plainly applies** to a creature that neither chooses nor grows morally.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Animal suffering is the point at which the free-will and soul-making theodicies both run out, and the honesty with which a script says so is itself a mark-earning move.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- pre-human suffering
- nomic regularity
- neo-Cartesian reply
- animal birth (tiryak-yoni)
- graded living selves (Jain jīva)
- non-injury (ahimsā)

How to use them: State the four-step argument, run the five replies with their costs, then close with the verdict formula that names what survives on each side.

EXAM-READY LINE: Only nomic regularity survives on the Western side, and it explains the *kind* of world rather than the *amount* of pain in it; Indian karma answers the distribution question the West cannot, at the price of an unverifiable trans-life mechanism.

THE ARGUMENT - AS STEPS

- (1) Animal suffering PREDATES human moral agency.
- (2) It therefore cannot be the misuse of human free will.
- (3) It cannot straightforwardly be the environment of MORAL growth for the animal sufferer.
- (4) It cannot simply be called retributive.
- (5) THEREFORE standard theodicies leave a major remainder.

FACT: Rowe's fawn - severe, apparently unobserved suffering after a natural fire - is the evidential case, not a deductive contradiction.

THE FIVE REPLIES, EACH WITH ITS COST

REPLY	CLAIM	COST
NEO-CARTESIAN (canvassed by Michael Murray, Nature Red in Tooth and Claw, 2008)	animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain MATTER morally	the premise is philosophically and empirically contested
NOMIC REGULARITY	a stable, law-governed world capable of supporting any life at all requires reliable causal order	explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT of pain
SOUL-MAKING EXTENDED	a world of real danger is the only kind in which courage, compassion and stewardship TOWARD ANIMALS are possible	uses animals INSTRUMENTALLY
ESCHATOLOGICAL	animal fulfilment or redemption in a final state (a minority line)	unverifiable and undeveloped
FALLEN-ORDER	a cosmic fall distorts nature prior to human history	CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained

1. Indian parity FACT:

- **Karma-samsāra** offers a distinctive distribution-account by extending moral causation to **animal births (tiryak-yoni)**.
- **Jainism** ascribes living selves graded sense-capacity and grounds **non-injury (ahimsā)** in that recognition.
- **Buddhism** places animals within the same field of **suffering (duḥkha)** and extends **compassion (karuṇā)** to sentient beings.

ANALYSIS: The cost is symmetrical to karma's general cost: the explanation is unverifiable and must not be used to infer that present suffering is deserved.

2. Objection and reply within the karma route ANALYSIS:

OBJECTION: karma explains distribution but is itself the thing in question; and an animal cannot LEARN from a fruit it cannot understand.

REPLY: karmic maturation is not PEDAGOGICAL but CAUSAL; the moral response it demands - compassion, non-injury - is unaffected by whether the animal grasps it.

ANALYSIS: RESIDUE: the mechanism remains unverifiable, and the inference from "this creature suffers" to "this creature earned it" is unavailable.

3. Why the case is decisive for grading ANALYSIS:

Theodicy	Does it cover animal suffering?
Free-will defence	WRONG: No - no creaturely free choice is involved
Augustinian punishment	WRONG: No - animals are not sinners; a fallen order is CAUTION: strained
Soul-making, for the animal	WRONG: No - the animal does not grow morally
Soul-making, for humans	ANALYSIS: Only instrumentally, at moral cost
Nomic regularity	ANALYSIS: Partially - the kind of world, not the amount of pain
Process theodicy	ANALYSIS: Yes in principle - finite causal powers deviate from the lure
Karma	ANALYSIS: Yes in principle - distribution across animal births, but unverifiable

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The canonical trap is explicit: **do not answer animal suffering with the free-will defence** - it does not apply, and saying so is itself a mark-earning move. Because the case eliminates the two most-cited theodicies at once, it is the natural residue paragraph for any 20-mark answer on evil and the standing test of whether a candidate has graded rather than recited.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not answer animal suffering with the free-will defence.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present the neo-Cartesian reply as settled; the premise is contested.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not claim soul-making covers the animal sufferer; at best it covers human virtue toward animals.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the fallen-order reply as historically neutral; mark it CAUTION:.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not use karma to infer that a suffering creature deserved it.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the fawn's status as an evidential rather than deductive case.

Revision notes

- Animal pain from predation and disease predates human moral agency.
- Neither free will nor soul-making applies to the animal sufferer.
- Rowe's fawn is the canonical evidential illustration.
- Neo-Cartesian: Michael Murray canvasses it in *Nature Red in Tooth and Claw* (2008); the premise is contested.
- Nomic regularity explains the kind of world, not the amount of pain.
- Extended soul-making instrumentalises animals.
- Eschatological animal fulfilment is a minority, undeveloped line.
- A pre-human cosmic fall is CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained.
- Indian parity: *tiryak-yoni*, graded Jain *jīva* with *ahimsā*, Buddhist *duḥkha* and *karuṇā*.
- Verdict: only nomic regularity survives in the West; karma answers distribution at the price of verifiability.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANIMAL SUFFERING AND THE PRE-HUMAN PROBLEM

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ANIMAL SUFFERING AND THE PRE-HUMAN PROBLEM			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS pre-human suffering · nomic regularity · neo-Cartesian reply · animal birth (<i>tiryak-yoni</i>) · graded <i>jīva</i> · <i>ahimsā</i>	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Because the pain precedes agency and teaches its bearer nothing, free will, soul-making and retribution all fail to apply.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Only nomic regularity partly survives in the West, while karma answers distribution at the price of verifiability.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not deploy the free-will defence here, and do not use karma to imply desert.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Animal suffering is the point at which the free-will and soul-making theodicies both run out, and the honesty with which a script says so is itself a mark-earning move.			

SESSION 12 - PROCESS THEODICY AND THE OTHER NON-CLASSICAL REPLIES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Process theodicy answers evil by changing the God-concept rather than by justifying permission: God is not the kind of being who could simply stop things, because power is spread through reality rather than concentrated in one place.

Technical definition: FACT: Process thought limits unilateral divine control: God **persuades** finite actualities and **shares** their suffering. God is **dipolar** - a *primordial nature* that envisages possibilities and supplies each occasion its **initial aim**, and a *consequent nature* that receives and preserves what the world becomes.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Process theodicy purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty - and a first-class answer states the trade rather than concealing it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **dipolar God**
- **primordial and consequent nature**
- **initial aim**
- **persuasion, not coercion**
- **fellow-sufferer who understands**
- **metaphysical necessity, not self-limitation**

How to use them: Number the tenets, name Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb separately, and state the modal difference from the free-will defence.

EXAM-READY LINE: Griffin's God *cannot* coerce; Plantinga's God *chooses* not to intervene - the difference is modal, and it is the whole difference between a theodicy and a defence here.

PROCESS THEODICY - THE TENETS, NUMBERED

- (1) CREATIVITY, not God, is the ultimate; actual entities are self-creative occasions of experience.
- (2) God is DIPOLAR -
 - PRIMORDIAL NATURE : the ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its INITIAL AIM
 - CONSEQUENT NATURE : God's reception and preservation of what the world actually becomes
- (3) POWER IS INTRINSICALLY DISTRIBUTED: to be actual is to have some self-determination.
- (4) THEREFORE divine power is PERSUASIVE BY METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY (Griffin) - NOT by self-limitation. <- the line that separates process theodicy from the free-will defence.
- (5) EVIL = finite occasions DEVIATING from the divine lure; God is not culpable, because God could not unilaterally prevent it.
- (6) God is "the FELLOW-SUFFERER WHO UNDERSTANDS" (Whitehead) - solidarity, not detachment.

NAME THE LAYER YOU ARE USING - DO NOT WRITE "PROCESS (WHITEHEAD)" AND STOP

WHITEHEAD	Process and Reality (1929): creativity ultimate; dipolar God; initial aim; consequent nature; "fellow-sufferer who understands"
HARTSHORNE	The Divine Relativity (1948); Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes (1984): classical omnipotence is INCOHERENT - to have ALL power is to leave none to anything else; "surrelativism"/ panentheism makes God supremely RELATED, not supremely UNAFFECTED
GRIFFIN	God, Power, and Evil: A Process Theodicy (1976); Evil Revisited (1991): persuasion is a METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY, not a chosen restraint
COBB	A Christian Natural Theology: the theological systematisation

CRITICISM: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be unworthy of worship; the metaphysics is contested; classical theists DENY that actuality entails self-determination.
REPLY: divine solidarity, and the OBJECTIVE IMMORTALITY of achieved value in the consequent nature - but the objection does not disappear.

1. Process is a theodicy, not a defence FACT:

ANALYSIS: This is a precise classificatory point and it is examinable. Process theodicy **claims to identify God's actual situation** - it is not offering a merely possible story. That is why it is refutable in a way Plantinga's defence is not, and why its metaphysical premises must be defended rather than merely entertained.

2. The surrounding reply-space ANALYSIS:

Response	Precise claim	Main cost
Greater-good / stable-order	Some goods - freedom, reliable agency, courage, compassion - require risk, regular law and the possibility of loss	May explain the <i>kind</i> of world without explaining the <i>amount</i> or <i>distribution</i> of suffering
Leibnizian best possible world	A perfect God chooses the best total compossible order, not a world containing every local good	There may be no unique best world; world-total optimisation can neglect goodness to particular persons
Eschatological fulfilment	No finite suffering is final; later fulfilment, restoration or union can prevent a life from being finally wasted	Compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it
Divine mystery	Finite minds may fail to grasp providential reasons	Without an access principle this becomes an unfalsifiable appeal; skeptical theism is the disciplined evidential version
Protest / anti-theodicy	Refusing to justify suffering can protect truthfulness, lament and the moral priority of resistance	Protest diagnoses the ethics of explanation but does not by itself settle the logical or evidential argument

ANALYSIS: **Compensation is not defeat.** A later good can compensate for loss while leaving the evil externally balanced. Adams' stronger requirement is that a horrendous evil be defeated within the person's life as a whole. Pastoral responsibility therefore requires listening, protection and action before speculative explanation; a theodicy never licenses passivity toward preventable harm.

3. Finite God and the general revision strategy ANALYSIS:

THE REVISION STRATEGY IN GENERAL

weaken ONE element of the classical profile and the problem loosens:

omnipotence -> process, finite God (goodness preserved)

personality -> impersonal Absolute, Advaita (evil at the empirical level; the ultimate is untouched)

creatorship -> Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (no defendant at all)

EVERY revision purchases relief with a RELIGIOUSLY SIGNIFICANT LOSS.

Naming the loss is what converts description into evaluation.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2025 stem is "*Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil.*"

The directive **explain the main tenets** buys enumerated doctrine, correctly attributed. The canonical trap is explicit: do not write "process theodicy (Whitehead)" and stop - name the layer you are using. Numbering the six tenets and attributing Whitehead, Hartshorne and Griffin separately is the difference between a competent and a strong script.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write that the process God is simply powerless; divine power is persuasive and relational.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the whole position to Whitehead; name Hartshorne and Griffin's distinct contributions.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse Griffin's metaphysical necessity with a chosen self-limitation.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not call process theodicy a defence; it claims God's actual situation.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not let "God's ways are mysterious" pass as an argument; without an access principle it is unfalsifiable.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not present eschatological compensation as automatic justification.

Revision notes

- Whitehead, *Process and Reality* (1929): creativity ultimate; dipolar God; initial aim; consequent nature; fellow-sufferer.
- Hartshorne, *The Divine Relativity* (1948) and *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984): classical omnipotence is incoherent.
- Griffin, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976) and *Evil Revisited* (1991): persuasion is metaphysically necessary.
- Cobb, *A Christian Natural Theology*: the theological systematisation.

- To be actual is to have some self-determination, so power is intrinsically distributed.
- Evil is deviation from the divine lure; God is not culpable.
- Process is a theodicy, not a defence - it claims actuality.
- Greater-good, best-world, eschatology, mystery and anti-theodicy each carry a stated cost.
- Compensation is not defeat.
- Verdict: God's innocence is purchased at the price of God's sovereignty; state the trade.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PROCESS THEODICY AND THE OTHER NON-CLASSICAL REPLIES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | PROCESS THEODICY AND THE OTHER NON-CLASSICAL REPLIES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

dipolar God · primordial and consequent nature · initial aim · persuasion not coercion · fellow-sufferer who understands · metaphysical necessity

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

If to be actual is to have some self-determination, divine power must be persuasive, so evil is deviation from the lure rather than divine permission.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

God's innocence is secured, but classical sovereignty and any guarantee of final victory are surrendered.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not stop at Whitehead's name, and do not confuse metaphysical necessity with chosen restraint.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Process theodicy purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty — and a first-class answer states the trade rather than concealing it.

SESSION 13 - THE INDIAN RESPONSE: KARMA, THE SCHOOLS AND THEIR COSTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Indian traditions mostly do not ask why God allows suffering. They ask where suffering comes from and how to get out of it, and they answer with a self-operating moral law that runs across lives.

Technical definition: FACT: **Karma-saṃsāra** holds that suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives and that the moral law is **self-operating**, so evil raises no problem for a creator's goodness: it is cosmic justice rather than divine cruelty.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

India's structural advantage is not that it explains evil better but that it answers a different question: not why evil is permitted, but why *this* person suffers - and it can drop the defendant altogether.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- karma-saṃsāra
- self-operating moral law
- karma-superintendent (karmādhyakṣa)
- beginninglessness
- empirical and ultimate levels (vyāvahārika/pāramārthika)
- victim-blaming control

How to use them: Distinguish the theistic from the non-theistic karma accounts, use beginninglessness precisely, and always attach the moral caution.

EXAM-READY LINE: Karma is not one doctrine across the Indian schools: Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and Jain accounts need no creator, while Nyāya and theistic Vedānta assign God a just administrative role rather than authorship of deserts.

THE INDIAN MOVE - STRUCTURALLY

WESTERN QUESTION : why does a good God PERMIT evil?

INDIAN QUESTION : how does BONDAGE ORIGINATE and how is it ENDED?

NON-THEISTIC ROUTES

Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā
no divine distributor required
the law operates by itself
-> THERE IS NO DEFENDANT

THEISTIC ROUTES

Nyāya, Rāmānuja
God dispenses karmic fruit
JUSTLY as karma-superintendent
(karmādhyaṅṣa)
-> God is a JUDGE, not an
arbitrary cause of evil

ADVAITA'S LEVELS

evil is real at the EMPIRICAL level (vyāvahārika);
under liberating knowledge it is sublated at the
ULTIMATE level (pāramārthika) - Brahman is untouched
ANALYSIS: COST: risk of minimising present suffering

BEGINNINGLESSNESS FACT:

the action-consequence series is treated as BEGINNINGLESS, so no
first wrongful act need be identified.
ANALYSIS: This blocks ONE regress question; it does NOT verify any
claimed past-life cause.

1. What karma explains that Western theodicy does not FACT:

Question	Western resource	Indian resource	Where they diverge
Why is there evil at all?	Free will; privation; soul-making	Ignorance (<i>avidyā</i>); inflow of karmic matter (<i>āśrava</i>); craving (<i>taṇhā</i>)	The West asks about <i>permission</i> ; India about the <i>origination of bondage</i>
Why this person?	ANALYSIS: Weak point - no standard answer	Karma across lives	The distribution question is India's structural advantage
Why so much ?	Nomic regularity; skeptical theism	Beginningless saṃsāra - no first excess to justify	The West must justify a quantity; India denies the frame
Is God culpable?	Theodicies; process denial of coercive power	Nyāya: God allots <i>per</i> karma, not arbitrarily; non-theistic schools: no defendant	India can drop the defendant; the West cannot
What defeats evil for the sufferer?	Adams' beatific intimacy; eschatology	Liberation (<i>mokṣa/nirvāṇa/kaivalya</i>) as ending the standpoint of suffering	Defeat <i>within</i> the life versus <i>exit from</i> the life-series
Animal suffering	Nomic regularity; neo-Cartesian	Karma in animal births (<i>tiryak-yoni</i>); graded Jain <i>jīva</i> ; non-injury (<i>ahiṃsā</i>)	India moralises it; the West mostly brackets it

2. The moral controls - non-negotiable ANALYSIS:

FACT: **Beginninglessness**. Karma traditions commonly treat the action-consequence series as beginningless, so they need not identify a first wrongful act. Beginninglessness blocks one regress question but does not verify any claimed past-life cause.

FACT: **Distributor**. Non-theistic Buddhist, Jain and Mīmāṃsā accounts do not require a divine distributor; Nyāya and theistic Vedānta assign God a just administrative role without making God the arbitrary author of deserts.

ANALYSIS: **Epistemic limit**. The inference from "this person suffers" to "this person deserves it for a specific past act" is unavailable to ordinary observers. Using karma that way is epistemically unsupported and converts explanation into victim-blaming.

ANALYSIS: **Residual pressure**. Karma addresses distribution more directly than the free-will defence, but natural suffering, collective harms and unequal starting conditions still press the fairness and verification of the mechanism.

FACT: **Duty of compassion**. Whatever its metaphysics, karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief; causal explanation is not moral permission to withhold aid.

3. Standing criticisms and replies ANALYSIS:

CRITICISM 1: victim-blaming

REPLY: classical Indian ethics makes compassion obligatory; explanatory karma does not authorise social judgement.

RESIDUE: the misuse is common enough to require the caution to be stated in the answer itself.

CRITICISM 2: infinite regress of karma

REPLY: the series is beginningless by doctrine, so the demand for a first term is misplaced.

RESIDUE: beginninglessness is a stipulation, not a verification.

CRITICISM 3: the a-morality of an impersonal law

REPLY: Nyāya supplies an intelligent just dispenser; Buddhism supplies conditionality without a moral legislator.

RESIDUE: the two replies pull in opposite directions and cannot be combined in one answer.

ANALYSIS: Route personal identity, rebirth mechanics and the metaphysics of liberation to *Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation*. This file owns karma **only** as an explanation of suffering and its distribution.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The canonical trap is explicit: **do not present karma as a single theistic doctrine across Indian schools**.

The examiner rewards a candidate who can say, in one sentence, that Mīmāṃsā and Buddhism need no God for karma to work while Nyāya does - and who then attaches the victim-blaming control instead of praising karma as a total solution.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present karma as one uniform theistic doctrine.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use karma to infer that a particular sufferer deserves their suffering.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat beginninglessness as evidence for any past-life cause.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not say Advaita denies suffering; it places it at the empirical level.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not let karma answer Adams' question; it answers distribution, not personal worth.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not import rebirth mechanics; they belong to the Soul topic.

Revision notes

- Karma-saṃsāra: suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives; the law is self-operating.
- Its structural advantage is *distribution* - why this person - which Western theodicy answers weakly.
- Nyāya and Rāmānuja: God dispenses karmic fruit justly as *karmādhyaṅkṣa*, a judge rather than an arbitrary cause.
- Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism and Jainism need no divine distributor at all.
- Advaita: evil is real at the empirical level and sublated at the ultimate level.
- The series is beginningless, which blocks a regress but verifies nothing.
- Victim-blaming is the standing moral cost; state the control explicitly.
- Compassion, protection and relief remain obligatory regardless of causal explanation.
- Natural suffering, collective harm and unequal starting conditions still press the mechanism.
- India can drop the defendant; the West cannot - that is the comparative sentence to write.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE INDIAN RESPONSE: KARMA, THE SCHOOLS AND THEIR COSTS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW THE INDIAN RESPONSE - KARMA, THE SCHOOLS AND THEIR COSTS			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS karma-saṃsāra · self-operating law · karma-superintendent (karmādhyaṅkṣa) · beginninglessness · vyāvahārika/pāramārthika · victim-blaming control	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Deeds generate consequences and rebirth widens the temporal field of justice, so distribution is explained without charging a creator.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The distribution question is answered where the West is weakest, at the price of an unverifiable mechanism and a real risk of victim-blaming.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not treat karma as uniform or theistic across the schools, and never infer desert from observed suffering.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: India's structural advantage is not that it explains evil better but that it answers a different question: not why evil is permitted, but why this person suffers — and it can drop the defendant altogether.			

SESSION 14 - EVIL AND THE PROFANE AS RELIGION-FORMING CATEGORIES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This session asks a completely different question from the rest of the topic: not whether evil disproves God, but whether religion itself is *built out of* the categories of evil, impurity and the ordinary.

Technical definition: FACT: On the sociological-phenomenological analysis, religion is constituted not by belief in God but by a **binary partition of the world into the sacred and the profane**, and by a practical response to **evil, suffering and impurity** as that which must be diagnosed, bounded and overcome.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evil and the profane found religion **structurally rather than doctrinally**: they supply the predicament, the boundary and the soteriological task without which religious practice would be unintelligible.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- sacred and profane
- hierophany
- world-axis (axis mundi)
- the numinous (mysterium tremendum et fascinans)
- predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology
- profane ≠ evil

How to use them: Treat the question as *functional*, not theological; run the four-step founding sequence; and correct the profane/evil confusion in the first paragraph.

EXAM-READY LINE: Durkheim's profane is the *ordinary*, not the wicked - and conflating them is the commonest error in this question.

THE THREE CANONICAL THEORISTS - DO NOT INTERCHANGE THEM

DURKHEIM	The Elementary Forms of Religious Life (1912)
SOCIAL SIDE	all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes - PROFANE and SACRED. Religion = a unified system of beliefs and practices RELATIVE TO SACRED THINGS, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a CHURCH. FACT: The definition is deliberately GOD-FREE.
OTTO	The Idea of the Holy (1917)
OBJECT SIDE	the sacred is an A PRIORI category of the mind's response - the NUMINOUS, <i>mysterium tremendum et fascinans</i> . Otto's "holy" is the OBJECT-side; Durkheim's "sacred" is the SOCIAL-side.
ELIADE	The Sacred and the Profane (1957)
SPATIAL / TEMPORAL	the sacred erupts as HIEROPHANY, generating sacred SPACE (a fixed centre, AXIS MUNDI, against homogeneous profane extension) and sacred TIME (recoverable and repeatable, against irreversible profane duration).

THE FOUR-STEP FOUNDING SEQUENCE ANALYSIS:

- (1) PREDICAMENT something is wrong: sin · impurity · suffering (duḥkha) · ignorance (avidyā) · karmic bondage · alienation
- ↓
- (2) BOUNDARY pure/impure · sacred/profane · saved/lost
→ generates ritual, prohibition and moral code
- ↓
- (3) INSTITUTION priesthood · initiation · purification · penance · community discipline
- ↓
- (4) SOTERIOLOGY the ordered path OUT
- THEREFORE evil and the profane are not embarrassments TO religion but part of its STRUCTURAL FOUNDATION: without a diagnosis of what is wrong, salvation-language has no work to do.

1. The ownership rule for this module FACT:

ANALYSIS: The **evil / profane** pole is owned here - this is the sole owner-module for the 2019 question. The **sacred / holy as the object of religion** pole is owned by *Religious Experience* (2018 Q7(a)). Each file carries the full conceptual pair so that either question can be answered from one file, and each routes the other half by cross-link. This is not duplication: the *questions* differ - here the category is **religion-founding**, there it is **object-identifying**.

2. Indian parity - mandatory FACT:

Tradition	Founding category	Exit
Buddhism	The First Noble Truth: suffering (<i>duḥkha</i>) made the explicit foundation of the whole religion - the clearest world case of "evil as religion-founding"	The path to cessation
Jainism	Inflow of karmic matter (<i>āsrava</i>) and bondage (<i>bandha</i>)	Stoppage (<i>saṃvara</i>) and shedding (<i>nirjarā</i>)
Advaita	Ignorance (<i>avidyā</i>) as the founding defect	Liberating knowledge
Brahmanical ritual	Purity and impurity (<i>śuddhi/aśuddhi</i>), cleanliness (<i>śauca</i>); auspicious and inauspicious (<i>maṅgala/amaṅgala</i>); demerit and merit (<i>pāpa/punya</i>)	Ritual rectification
Mīmāṃsā	Ritual purity codes	Correct performance

ANALYSIS: **The critical rider that earns the marks:** in Indian traditions the founding category is more often **ignorance or bondage** than **moral evil**, which changes the shape of the resulting religion - *diagnosis-and-insight* rather than *sin-and-forgiveness*.

3. The four categories that must not be merged FACT:

EVIL moral or natural harm
PROFANE the ordinary, the non-consecrated <- NOT wicked
IMPURE the ritually polluting
DEMONIC the actively anti-sacred

Durkheim's profane is merely the everyday. A ploughed field, a market and a weekday are profane; none of them is evil.

4. Presupposition, objections and verdict ANALYSIS:

Element	Content
Presupposition	ANALYSIS: That religion can be defined <i>functionally</i> by structure rather than <i>substantively</i> by its object; and that the sacred/profane binary is genuinely cross-cultural
Objection 1	ANALYSIS: The binary is a Durkheimian imposition; many traditions grade rather than dichotomise, and Eliade's universal "archaic ontology" is unfalsifiable
Reply 1	FACT: Treat the pair as an <i>ideal type</i> that organises comparison, not as a law
Objection 2	ANALYSIS: Founding religion on evil makes religion parasitic on suffering, so a world without suffering would be a world without religion
Reply 2	FACT: Worship, wonder and gratitude are independent religious roots; the sacred is not exhausted by the negative pole - which is exactly why the sacred/holy question is treated in <i>Religious Experience</i>
Verdict formula	ANALYSIS: "Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally : they supply the predicament, the boundary and the soteriological task without which religious practice would be unintelligible. But they found <i>religion</i> , not <i>theism</i> - which is why the same analysis covers Buddhism and Jainism, and why it leaves the theistic problem of evil entirely untouched."

5. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2019 stem is "*What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?*" The directive phrase "**what role do A and B play to provide a firm foundation to...**" buys a *functional* account, not a definition: predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology. A candidate who answers with the theistic problem of evil has answered a different question entirely.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not equate profane with evil; the profane is the ordinary.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not interchange Durkheim's social "sacred" with Otto's object-side "holy".
3. ANALYSIS: Do not answer this stem with theodicies; it is a functional-sociological question.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the Indian parity, and do not omit the rider that India's founding defect is usually ignorance or bondage rather than sin.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present the binary as a law; it is an ideal type.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude that evil founds *theism*; it founds *religion*.

Revision notes

- Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912): the sacred/profane classification; religion as beliefs and practices relative to sacred things uniting a moral community, a church; deliberately God-free.
- Otto, *The Idea of the Holy* (1917): the numinous, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*; the object-side.
- Eliade, *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957): hierophany, sacred space with an *axis mundi*, recoverable sacred time.
- Founding sequence: predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology.
- Buddhism's First Noble Truth is the clearest case of evil as religion-founding.
- Jain *āsrava/bandha* names the predicament; *saṃvara/nirjarā* the exit.
- Advaita's *avidyā* is the founding defect; Mīmāṃsā's purity codes organise practice.
- India's founding defect is more often ignorance or bondage than moral evil.
- Evil ≠ profane ≠ impure ≠ demonic - four distinct categories.

- Verdict: they found religion structurally, not doctrinally, and they found religion, not theism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EVIL AND THE PROFANE AS RELIGION-FORMING CATEGORIES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | EVIL AND THE PROFANE AS RELIGION-FORMING CATEGORIES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

sacred and profane · hierophany · axis mundi · numinous (mysterium tremendum et fascinans) · predicament-boundary-institution-soteriology

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A named predicament generates a boundary, the boundary generates institutions, and the predicament generates the path out.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The account covers Buddhism and Jainism as easily as theism, and therefore leaves the theistic problem of evil untouched.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not equate the profane with the evil, and do not answer this functional stem with theodicies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally: they supply the predicament, the boundary and the soteriological task without which religious practice would be unintelligible.

SESSION 15 - CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE AND COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The problem of evil only bites on a very particular idea of God. Change the idea and the problem shrinks, moves or disappears entirely - which tells us the problem is really a test of a concept.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: The problem is **concept-dependent**: it presses only on a God who is *simultaneously omnipotent, wholly good and creator*. Weaken any of those and the argument loses its grip - at a religiously significant price.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The problem of evil is a stress-test of a *particular* God-concept, not of religion as such - which is why the same suffering that refutes one theology leaves another entirely untouched.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **concept-dependence**
- **finite God**
- **impersonal Absolute**
- **no creator**
- **religiously significant loss**
- **assessment grid**

How to use them: Run the classical set against four God-concepts, show it dissolving in each, and price each dissolution.

EXAM-READY LINE: Weaken omnipotence (process), weaken personality (Advaita), or remove the creator (Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā) and the problem dissolves - but each dissolution purchases relief with a religiously significant loss.

RUN THE TRIAD AGAINST FOUR GOD-CONCEPTS

GOD-CONCEPT	WHAT HAPPENS TO THE PROBLEM	WHAT IS LOST
CLASSICAL THEISM omnipotent + good + omniscient creator	FULL FORCE - all three burdens live	nothing yet; the theodicies must now do the work
FINITE / PROCESS GOD persuasive power	DISSOLVED at the logical level - God could not prevent it	sovereignty; any guarantee of final victory over evil
IMPERSONAL ABSOLUTE Advaita: nirguṇa Brahman	RELOCATED - evil is real at the empirical level and sublated at the ultimate level	a personal God to address, petition or trust; risk of minimising suffering
NO CREATOR AT ALL Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, karma without God	REMOVED - there is no defendant; suffering is explained by conditions and deeds	providence, divine rescue and a cosmic guarantor of justice

THEREFORE the problem is CONCEPT-DEPENDENT.

ANALYSIS: But concept-dependence is NOT a solution: it relocates the cost from the argument to the theology. The theodicies (free-will, soul-making) are precisely the attempt to KEEP ALL THE ATTRIBUTES.

1. The assessment grid ANALYSIS:

Theodicy	Evil explained	Attribute preserved	Weakness
Free-will	Moral	Omnipotence + goodness	Natural evil left over
Augustinian privation	Moral, via the Fall	All attributes	Metaphysics of "privation" strained; innocence and animals
Soul-making (Hick)	Moral + natural	Purposive goodness	Scale, animal suffering, universalist eschatology
Process	All	Goodness, not omnipotence	Sacrifices classical omnipotence
Karma	All, including distribution	Cosmic justice, no creator-blame	Victim-blaming; verification; regress
Advaita	Empirical-level evil	Brahman untouched	Risk of minimising suffering
Skeptical theism	None - it is a defence	All attributes	Moral scepticism; unfalsifiability

2. The inter-thinker comparison table FACT:

Approach	Moral evil	Natural evil	Divine attribute changed or preserved	Cost
Free will	FACT: Strong account	ANALYSIS: Weak without supplement	Preserves the omni-attributes	Libertarian assumptions
Augustine	FACT: Privation and fault	ANALYSIS: Fallen order	Preserves creator goodness	Punishment and innocence problem
Hick	FACT: Growth through freedom	FACT: Environment of growth	Preserves purposive goodness	Proportionality and afterlife
Process	FACT: Finite agency	FACT: Finite causal powers	Revises omnipotence	Non-classical God
Karma	FACT: Moral causation	ANALYSIS: Extends explanation across lives	Creator optional	Verification and victim-blaming
Advaita	ANALYSIS: Evil at the empirical level	ANALYSIS: Sublatable under knowledge	Ultimate Brahman untouched	Risk of minimising suffering

3. The four standing criticisms with replies and rejoinders ANALYSIS:

1. **Excess evil.** ANALYSIS: Even if some hardship is needed, the scale seems unnecessary. **Reply:** epistemic limits and long-range goods. **Rejoinder:** unknown reasons cannot become a blanket licence.
2. **Natural evil.** ANALYSIS: Free will does not explain earthquakes or disease. **Reply:** stable natural law enables agency. **Rejoinder:** stability does not explain every extreme distribution.
3. **Divine responsibility.** ANALYSIS: Creating foreknown wrongdoers seems culpable. **Reply:** foreknowledge does not cause free action. **Rejoinder:** knowingly choosing the whole system remains morally relevant.
4. **Karma and compassion.** ANALYSIS: Desert explanations can blame sufferers. **Reply:** classical ethical practice can require compassion regardless of past causes; explanatory karma does not authorise social judgement.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2024 stem is *"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system."* Critically discuss. The directive requires the candidate to **show the dependence by varying the God-concept** - to run the triad against four concepts and watch it dissolve. The critical half is the price list: each dissolution costs something religiously significant, and a script that lists the dissolutions without the costs has only done half the question.

MEMORY: The winning answer **names the inconsistent triad, deploys two to three theodicies, adds the Indian karma bridge, and concludes on concept-dependence** - weaken an attribute and the problem dissolves.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present concept-dependence as a solution; it relocates the cost.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not claim that a finite God escapes the *evidential* problem entirely; it escapes the logical charge.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Advaita denies evil; it places it at the empirical level.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "no creator" systems as evasions; they answer a different question.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not list theodicies without their costs; the grid is the answer.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the Indian bridge in a 15- or 20-marker; it is the highest-value comparative move available.

Revision notes

- The problem bites only on a simultaneously omnipotent, wholly good, omniscient creator.
- Weaken omnipotence -> process and finite-God routes.
- Weaken personality -> Advaita's levels; the ultimate is untouched.
- Remove the creator -> Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā; no defendant.
- Every dissolution purchases relief with a religiously significant loss.
- Theodicies are the attempt to keep all the attributes.
- The assessment grid pairs each theodicy with what it explains, preserves and costs.
- The four standing criticisms are excess, natural evil, divine responsibility and karma's moral risk.
- Each criticism has a reply and a rejoinder; write all three moves.
- The 2024 verdict: the problem is a stress-test of one God-concept, not of religion as such.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE AND COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE AND COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS concept-dependence · finite God · impersonal Absolute · no creator · religiously significant loss · assessment grid	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Run the classical set against four God-concepts and observe the problem weaken, relocate or disappear, then price each dissolution.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Concept-dependence is not a solution; it moves the cost from the argument into the theology.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not list dissolutions without their costs, and do not treat non-creator systems as evasions.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The problem of evil is a stress-test of a particular God-concept, not of religion as such — which is why the same suffering that refutes one theology leaves another entirely untouched.			

SESSION 16 - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THE PROBLEM OF EVIL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This session converts everything above into a writing method: how to open, what to include at each mark level, which directive demands what shape, and how to finish with a graded verdict rather than a pious sentence.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: An answer architecture specifies, for each directive and mark band, the obligatory content, the ordering, the evidence density and the form of the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Always state *which version* of the problem you are answering in the first two lines: theodicies are version-specific, and a mismatched theodicy scores as an error rather than as content.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- version identification
- directive decoding
- graded verdict
- cost statement
- quotation discipline
- residue paragraph

How to use them: Open with the version, structure by the directive, close with a graded verdict that names the cost and the residue.

EXAM-READY LINE: A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is *measured* by it - so name the cost, then grade the reply against the version of the problem it was built for.

THE UNIVERSAL SPINE FOR THIS CLAUSE

- | | |
|--|--|
| (1) NAME the version | logical · evidential · existential ·
horrendous · animal · distributional |
| (2) STATE the set or the probability judgement | with the BRIDGING PREMISES, or with the inductive step made explicit |
| (3) RECONSTRUCT the reply | as numbered premises, correctly attributed |
| (4) OBJECT and REPLY | the strongest objection, then the proponent's best answer, then the residue |
| (5) COMPARE | one deliberate Indian or Western comparator |
| (6) GRADE | what it explains · what it preserves ·
what it costs · what it leaves untouched |

1. Answer architecture by mark band FACT:

10 marks

State the exact problem -> identify the God-concept it presupposes -> one response with its presupposition -> one objection -> verdict on COMPATIBILITY, not a devotional conclusion.

15 marks

Logical/evidential frame -> the doctrine's argument -> canonical example -> objection and reply -> Indian comparator -> assess the explanatory cost.

20 marks

Define evil and state the inconsistent set -> strongest theodicy in full ->
 rival theodicy or Indian view -> two objections with replies ->
 distinguish DEFENCE from THEODICY -> graded verdict.

ANALYSIS: **Band budgets.** 10 marks ≈ 150 words: version, set, one reply, one objection, one-line verdict. 15 marks ≈ 220-260 words: add the canonical example, the reply, and the Indian comparator. 20 marks ≈ 320-360 words: add a second objection with its reply, the defence/theodicy distinction, and the residue before a criterion-named conclusion.

2. Directive decoder FACT:

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss	The <i>set</i> and its bridging premises , not a lament	Write the propositions as a numbered set; show why they are not <i>formally</i> contradictory without the bridges	2020 Q6(b)
Discuss the paradox of...	A paradox stated as a dilemma with both horns	Horn 1 -> cost; Horn 2 -> cost; then the restriction that dissolves it	2021 Q5(e), omnipotence
Critically examine [a quoted thesis]	Fidelity to the quotation's <i>scope</i> before evaluation	Ask first: does the claim cover moral evil only, or natural too?	2022 Q6(c), absolute creator
"Quotation." - Critically discuss	Reconstruct the author's own system, then test it	Give Augustine's privation metaphysics before objecting	2023 Q8(a)
"Direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised." Critically discuss	Show the <i>dependence</i> by varying the God-concept	Run the triad against four God-concepts and watch it dissolve	2024 Q6(c)
Explain the main tenets of X	Enumerated doctrine, correctly attributed	Number the tenets; name Whitehead, Hartshorne and Griffin separately	2025 Q6(b), process theodicy
What role do A and B play to provide a firm foundation to...	A <i>functional</i> account, not a definition	Predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology	2019 Q6(b), evil and the profane

3. Graded verdict ladder FACT:

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"God is good but evil exists"; lists free-will and karma	Triad asserted without bridging premises; no version identified
Average (≈50%)	Logical/evidential distinction; two theodicies	Defence and theodicy used interchangeably
Good (≈60%)	Bridging premises stated; one theodicy fully reconstructed; Indian comparator	Natural and animal evil unaddressed
Strong (≈65-70%)	Version-matched theodicy; objection with reply; distribution question raised; cost of each move stated	Horrendous and skeptical-theist layer absent
Top (≈70%+)	All the above plus defeat-versus-balancing-off, or CORNEA, or the animal-suffering gap - and an explicit statement of what the theist has <i>given up</i> to survive	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *Logical problem*: "The set is inconsistent only with the bridging premises; deny either and the contradiction dissolves - but the theist then owes an account of what a good omnipotent being *would* tolerate, which is where the evidential problem restarts."
- ANALYSIS: *Theodicy stem*: "The theodicy answers the version of the problem it was designed for and leaves ____ untouched; its cost is ____, and a theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it."
- ANALYSIS: *Concept-dependence stem*: "The problem is a stress-test of one God-concept, not of religion. Weaken omnipotence (process), weaken personality (Advaita), or remove the creator (Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā) and it dissolves - but each dissolution purchases relief with a religiously significant loss."

4. Factual and quotation discipline FACT:

Item	Status	Safe use
The "if God is willing but not able..." dilemma	CAUTION: Traditionally ascribed to Epicurus but transmitted through Lactantius , <i>De Ira Dei</i> 13; no surviving Epicurean text contains it	Write "the dilemma transmitted by Lactantius and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus"
"Evil and Omnipotence"	FACT: J. L. Mackie , <i>Mind</i> (1955)	Source of the adequate/fallacious-solutions framing and the paradox of omnipotence
Transworld depravity	FACT: Alvin Plantinga , <i>God, Freedom, and Evil</i> (1974)	It establishes <i>possibility</i> , never actuality - say so
<i>Privatio boni</i> / "all evil is either sin or punishment for sin"	FACT: Augustinian doctrine; the sentence is the printed 2023 stem	Treat the stem as the object of analysis, not as a verified verbatim translation CAUTION:
"Vale of Soul-making"	FACT: John Keats , letter to George and Georgiana Keats, spring 1819	Keats coined it; Hick adopted it; Irenaeus supplies the image/likeness theology
<i>Evil and the God of Love</i>	FACT: John Hick (1966)	Source of "epistemic distance" and the Irenaean/Augustinian typology
"Fellow-sufferer who understands"	FACT: A. N. Whitehead , <i>Process and Reality</i> , final chapter	The canonical process anchor
Omnipotence is incoherent	FACT: Charles Hartshorne , <i>Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes</i>	Distinguish from Griffin's metaphysical-necessity version
<i>God, Power, and Evil: A Process Theodicy</i>	FACT: David Ray Griffin (1976)	The fullest process treatment of evil
Rowe's fawn	FACT: William Rowe , "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism" (1979)	Evidential, not logical
CORNEA	FACT: Stephen Wykstra (1984)	Spell it out; do not gesture at "mystery"
Horrendous evils	FACT: Marilyn McCord Adams (1999)	Use her technical definition in sense, paraphrased in words
Sacred/profane dichotomy	FACT: Emile Durkheim , <i>The Elementary Forms of Religious Life</i> (1912)	Profane ≠ evil
Hierophany, sacred space and time	FACT: Mircea Eliade , <i>The Sacred and the Profane</i> (1957)	-
The numinous	FACT: Rudolf Otto , <i>The Idea of the Holy</i> (1917)	Object-side, not Durkheim's social-side

5. Safe formulations to carry into the hall ANALYSIS:

- "The problem's force varies with the God-concept."
- "A successful defence defeats contradiction; it need not make suffering morally transparent."
- "Global balancing is not personal defeat: a world can be good on the whole while a life is not."
- "Evil and the profane found religion structurally, not doctrinally - they supply the predicament without which soteriology is idle."

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not open with a definition of God; open with the version of the problem.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use a devotional conclusion where a graded verdict is required.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not quote the four-horn dilemma as a surviving Epicurean text.

4. ANALYSIS: Do not exceed the band budget; a 10-marker with four theodicies has no analysis in it.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the residue paragraph in a 20-marker; the examiner is looking for it.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not use a scholar's name without the claim it carries; names without content earn nothing.

Revision notes

- Always name the version of the problem in the first two lines.
- The universal spine: name -> state -> reconstruct -> object and reply -> compare -> grade.
- 10 marks: problem, God-concept, one reply, one objection, compatibility verdict.
- 15 marks: frame, argument, example, objection and reply, Indian comparator, cost.
- 20 marks: definition and set, strongest theodicy, rival, two objections, defence/theodicy distinction, graded verdict.
- Directive decoding is worth more than extra content at every band.
- The verdict ladder runs from asserting the triad to stating what the theist has given up.
- Quotation discipline: Lactantius for the dilemma, Keats for the vale, Chisholm for defeat.
- Cost is a measure, not a refutation.
- A residue paragraph - natural evil, animals, amount and distribution - is the standing 20-mark differentiator.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THE PROBLEM OF EVIL

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THE PROBLEM OF EVIL			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS version identification · directive decoding · graded verdict · cost statement · quotation discipline · residue paragraph	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Name the version, state the set or probability judgement, reconstruct the reply, object and answer, compare, then grade by cost and coverage.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST A version-matched reply with a stated cost outscores a longer script that recites more theodicies.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not end devotionally, and do not cite a name without the claim it carries.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Always state which version of the problem you are answering in the first two lines: theodicies are version-specific, and a mismatched theodicy scores as an error rather than as content.			

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Problem of Evil* - covering the four versions of the problem and their burdens, the defence/theodicy distinction, the classification of evil, quotation and attribution discipline, Mackie's bridging premises and his adequate/fallacious framing, the paradox of omnipotence, Plantinga's free-will defence with transworld depravity, divine responsibility under absolute creation, Augustinian privation with the sin-and-punishment thesis and the inherited-guilt control, Hick's soul-making with epistemic distance and the Irenaean/Augustinian typology, concept-dependence, Rowe's evidential argument and its inductive step, Wykstra's CORNEA with the costs of skeptical theism, Adams' horrendous evils with balancing off versus defeat, animal and pre-human suffering, process theodicy with its named layers, the surrounding reply-space of greater-good, best-world, eschatological, mystery and anti-theodicy responses, the Indian karma frameworks across theistic and non-theistic schools, and evil and the profane as religion-forming categories. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause.

MCQ 1. Which version of the problem is on the table

A script answers a stem about the sheer quantity of undeserved suffering in the world by proving that God's existence and the existence of evil are not strictly contradictory. What has gone wrong?

- A. Nothing has gone wrong, because establishing logical consistency is sufficient to answer every formulation of the problem of evil.
- B. The script has answered the existential burden when the stem in fact raised the logical burden about a formal inconsistency.
- C. The script has answered the logical burden when the stem raised the evidential burden, where consistency does not restore probability.
- D. The script has confused moral with natural evil, which is a classificatory rather than a version-matching failure in this case.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: consistency answers Mackie alone, and Rowe explicitly grants consistency before pressing the improbability of divine permission.
- **B:** Incorrect: this inverts the two burdens, and the existential burden concerns whether a particular life can be a great good to the person living it.
- **C:** Correct: quantity and distribution belong to the evidential version, whose burden is probability, so a bare consistency proof leaves the charge standing.
- **D:** Incorrect: the classification of evil is a separate discipline, and the stem's fault here is the mismatch of reply-type to version rather than of kind.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates treat "the problem of evil" as one argument; the examiner treats it as four, and awards the first marks to whoever names the version in the opening two lines.

MCQ 2. What a defence claims and what a theodicy claims

Which statement states the difference between a defence and a theodicy correctly?

- A. A defence identifies God's actual reason for permitting evil, whereas a theodicy shows only that some such reason is logically available.
- B. A defence and a theodicy differ only in tone, the first being philosophical and the second devotional, but their success conditions are identical.
- C. A defence applies to natural evil while a theodicy applies to moral evil, so the two divide the field between them by subject matter.
- D. A defence shows that God could have a morally sufficient reason, whereas a theodicy claims to identify what that reason actually is.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the two, and it makes Plantinga's modest possibility claim into an assertion he explicitly declines to make.
- **B:** Incorrect: the success conditions differ sharply, since bare logical possibility suffices for a defence but never for a theodicy.
- **C:** Incorrect: the division is by claim-strength and not by subject matter, and both defences and theodicies address moral and natural evil.
- **D:** Correct: a defence discharges the consistency burden with a possible reason, while a theodicy asserts an actual reason and is refuted if that reason fails.

Examiner trap 2: Using "defence" and "theodicy" interchangeably caps a script at the average band, because the whole force of Plantinga's argument depends on his needing only possibility.

MCQ 3. Sorting the evil before selecting the reply

Consider the following statements about the classification of evil and the scope of the standard replies.

1. The free-will defence applies directly to moral evil and not directly to natural evil.
2. Hick's soul-making extends to natural evil by treating it as the environment of moral growth.
3. The free-will defence covers animal suffering because predation is a misuse of creaturely freedom.
4. Augustine reaches natural evil only by appealing to a fallen order, which is historically strained.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 4 only, because the scope of each reply is fixed by the kind of evil it was built to explain.
- B. 1 and 3 only, because freedom is the single source of all evil once creaturely agency is admitted.
- C. 2, 3 and 4 only, because natural and animal suffering are treated identically by every developmental theodicy.
- D. 1 and 2 only, because Augustine makes no attempt whatever to extend his account to natural evil.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: statements 1, 2 and 4 each state the scope of a reply accurately, and statement 3 fails because animals neither choose nor misuse freedom.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, and the canonical rule is that answering animal suffering with the free-will defence is itself a marked error.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 3 remains false, and soul-making covers animal suffering only instrumentally through human virtue toward animals.
- **D:** Incorrect: Augustine does extend the account to natural evil through the fallen order, which is why statement 4 belongs in the correct set.

Examiner trap 3: A script that writes "free will explains evil" without qualification has silently claimed to explain earthquakes, congenital disease and predation, and has invited the topic's commonest rejoinder.

MCQ 4. Attribution and quotation discipline in this clause

Which pairing of a formulation with its correct source is accurate?

- A. The four-horn dilemma is preserved in a surviving Epicurean treatise, and "the vale of Soul-making" was coined by Irenaeus in his image-and-likeness theology.
- B. The four-horn dilemma is reported by Lactantius, and "the vale of Soul-making" is Hick's own coinage in *Evil and the God of Love*.
- C. The four-horn dilemma reaches us through Lactantius, *De Ira Dei* 13, and "the vale of Soul-making" is John Keats's phrase from his spring 1819 journal-letter.
- D. The four-horn dilemma is Mackie's restatement in *Mind*, and "the vale of Soul-making" belongs to Chisholm's analysis of defeat and balancing off.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no surviving Epicurean text contains the dilemma, and Irenaeus supplies the image-and-likeness theology rather than the phrase itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: the Lactantius half is right, but Hick adopted an existing phrase and never presented it as his own invention.
- **C:** Correct: the dilemma is transmitted through Lactantius and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus, while Keats coined the phrase that Hick later borrowed.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mackie restates the logical problem rather than the dilemma, and Chisholm supplies the technical term "defeat" used by Adams.

Examiner trap 4: Attribution errors are cheap to avoid and expensive to make, because a misassigned phrase signals to the examiner that the doctrine behind it was never read.

MCQ 5. What actually makes Mackie's set inconsistent

Which statement identifies the role of the bridging premises correctly?

- A. The bridging premises are optional rhetorical devices, since "God is omnipotent", "God is perfectly good" and "evil exists" already entail a formal contradiction.
- B. Two additional principles are needed - that a good being eliminates evil as far as it can, and that omnipotence has no relevant limit on prevention.
- C. The bridging premises assert that evil is a positive substance, without which the set of propositions could not be brought into conflict at all.
- D. Only one bridging premise is required, namely that God's goodness must be recognisable to the creatures whose suffering is in question.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: nothing in the three propositions plus logic alone entails both a proposition and its negation, which is what formal contradiction requires.
- **B:** Correct: the goodness bridge and the power bridge together generate the inconsistency, and each is the target of a distinct family of theistic replies.
- **C:** Incorrect: the substantiality of evil is Augustine's target rather than Mackie's premise, and the set does not require it.
- **D:** Incorrect: recognisability is a separate hiddenness issue, and one bridge alone leaves the power side of the argument entirely unsupported.

Examiner trap 5: Declaring the triad self-contradictory and moving straight to free will concedes the analytical core of the 2020 question before the answer has properly begun.

MCQ 6. Mackie's own framing of the standard replies

In "Evil and Omnipotence" Mackie divides proposed solutions into adequate and fallacious ones. What is his criterion?

- A. An adequate solution abandons at least one of the disputed propositions, whereas a fallacious solution only appears to retain all of them.
- B. An adequate solution is one drawn from revealed theology, whereas a fallacious solution relies on philosophical reasoning alone about divine attributes.
- C. An adequate solution answers the evidential form of the argument, whereas a fallacious solution addresses only its weaker logical formulation.
- D. An adequate solution is accepted by most theists, whereas a fallacious solution has been abandoned by the mainstream theological tradition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Mackie treats the honest exits as those that give up a proposition, and classifies replies that quietly limit power or redefine goodness as fallacious.
- **B:** Incorrect: revelation plays no part in Mackie's taxonomy, which is conducted entirely in terms of the consistency of a set of propositions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the evidential formulation postdates Mackie's article by more than two decades and is not what his classification is about.
- **D:** Incorrect: popularity is not a logical criterion, and Mackie's charge is precisely that widely held replies are among the fallacious ones.

Examiner trap 6: Naming Mackie's adequate/fallacious framing shows the examiner that the article was read rather than the slogan, and it costs one sentence to include.

MCQ 7. The paradox of omnipotence, stated as a dilemma

Which statement expresses Mackie's paradox of omnipotence most accurately?

- A. If God is omnipotent, God can perform logically contradictory tasks, and the impossibility of such tasks therefore disproves divine omnipotence outright.
- B. If God cannot make beings God cannot control, second-order power is limited; if God can and does, first-order power over them is limited.
- C. If God is omnipotent, God must intervene in every case of suffering, and the observed absence of intervention therefore establishes that God is not good.
- D. If God creates free beings, God thereby ceases to be omniscient about their future choices, which is the real limitation the paradox exposes.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: almost no theist claims omnipotence covers the self-contradictory, so this attacks a position that the debate does not actually contain.
- **B:** Correct: the paradox turns on the incompatibility of unrestricted first-order and second-order power, and each horn carries its own cost.
- **C:** Incorrect: this restates the goodness bridge of the logical problem rather than the paradox about the structure of power itself.
- **D:** Incorrect: the foreknowledge issue is a distinct problem, and Mackie's paradox concerns power over things rather than knowledge of them.

Examiner trap 7: Reducing the 2021 question to the heavy-stone puzzle produces a riddle rather than an analysis and leaves the required connection to evil entirely unmade.

MCQ 8. The premise structure of the free-will defence

Which reconstruction of Plantinga's free-will defence is correct?

- A. Significant freedom is a great good, it entails genuine alternatives, God cannot causally determine a free creature to choose only rightly, so moral evil is possible alongside perfect goodness.
- B. Significant freedom is a great good, God therefore creates only agents who will in fact choose rightly, and the moral evil we observe must accordingly be an illusion.
- C. Significant freedom is a great good, and since God foresees every misuse of it, God bears no responsibility for any consequence that follows from creaturely choice.
- D. Significant freedom is a great good, so God permits moral evil in order to produce the greater good of courage, compassion and mature moral character.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the defence's actual chain, and step three is the self-cancelling description that blocks a causally guaranteed world of only-right choices.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the defence denies the reality of moral evil, and denying it would abandon the proposition the argument is meant to accommodate.
- **C:** Incorrect: foreknowledge is a separate issue, and Plantinga does not argue that divine foresight discharges divine responsibility.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is Hick's developmental rationale rather than Plantinga's modal one, and it converts a defence into a theodicy.

Examiner trap 8: Blending Plantinga's modal argument with Hick's developmental one produces a hybrid that neither author holds and that no objection in the literature actually targets.

MCQ 9. The modal status of transworld depravity

What exactly does Plantinga claim about transworld depravity?

- A. That it is an empirically established feature of human psychology, confirmed by the observed frequency of wrongdoing in every known society.
- B. That it is a necessary truth about creaturely essences, so that no possible free creature could ever refrain from wrongdoing in any circumstance.
- C. That it is a theological doctrine equivalent to the Augustinian Fall, transmitted to every human being through inherited guilt from an ancestral act.
- D. That it is possibly true of every creaturely essence God could instantiate, which is enough to block Mackie's demand for only-good free agents.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim is modal rather than empirical, and Plantinga needs no evidence about actual human behaviour to make the defence work.
- **B:** Incorrect: necessity is far stronger than the argument requires, and Plantinga is careful not to assert that transworld depravity is even actual.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Augustinian Fall is a theological narrative about historical origin, whereas transworld depravity is a claim about possible worlds.
- **D:** Correct: possibility suffices for a defence, and that possibility is precisely what defeats the demand for a world of free agents who never go wrong.

Examiner trap 9: Attacking transworld depravity as empirically unsupported misses the modal point entirely and shows that the difference between defence and theodicy was never grasped.

MCQ 10. Absolute creation and the location of responsibility

The 2022 stem asserts that if God is the Absolute Creator, responsibility for evil cannot belong to the human agent. Which combination of replies is philosophically appropriate?

- A. God creates the capacity while the agent supplies the act; evil is a privation rather than a created thing; and foreknowledge does not amount to causation.
- B. God creates every act directly, so responsibility is genuinely divine, and the human agent is correctly described by the stem as a mere instrument.
- C. The stem is answered by pointing out that natural evil exists, since earthquakes show that not all suffering can be traced to any agent at all.
- D. The stem collapses because omnipotence is incoherent, so there is no Absolute Creator whose responsibility could be discussed in the first place.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the three standard replies about authorship, metaphysics and knowledge, and together they locate responsibility with the acting agent.
- **B:** Incorrect: conceding the stem outright abandons the critical directive, which asks for examination rather than acceptance of the claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: natural evil is outside the stem's scope, which concerns moral evil and the agency of the human being who commits it.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the process route, which changes the subject rather than examining the conditional the stem actually asserts.

Examiner trap 10: The strongest scripts concede the rejoinder - that knowingly instantiating the whole system remains morally relevant - instead of pretending the free-will reply closes the matter.

MCQ 11. What the privation account establishes

Which statement about Augustine's privation account is correct?

- A. It establishes that suffering is an illusion produced by a defective perspective, since what has no positive being can have no real effect on a creature.
- B. It establishes that evil has an independent creative source opposed to God, which is why the created order contains both good and evil substances.
- C. It establishes that God is the direct cause of natural evil while remaining the indirect cause of moral evil through the freedom given to creatures.
- D. It establishes that evil depends parasitically on good and has no created substance of its own, without thereby justifying any particular permitted deprivation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a privation is a real lack in a subject that ought to possess the missing good, and blindness is not thereby rendered unreal.
- **B:** Incorrect: metaphysical dualism is exactly what the privation account is designed to avoid, since being as being is held to be good.
- **C:** Incorrect: the account denies that God creates evil at all, and it treats natural evil through the fallen order rather than direct causation.
- **D:** Correct: the account secures metaphysical economy and divine innocence in creation, while leaving the separate question of permission unanswered.

Examiner trap 11: The commonest misreading is that privation trivialises pain; a script that says so has attacked a position no serious Augustinian holds.

MCQ 12. The sin-and-punishment thesis and the inherited-guilt control

Which treatment of the 2023 thesis is philosophically strongest?

- A. Accept the thesis without qualification, since Augustine's authority settles the matter and the printed stem reproduces his considered position exactly.
- B. Reconstruct the thesis, then distinguish inherited personal guilt from an inherited damaged condition, and note that the second is more defensible but still owes an explanation.
- C. Reject the thesis immediately, since innocent suffering is obvious and no further reconstruction of Augustine's metaphysical framework is therefore required.
- D. Restate the thesis as a claim about natural law, since disease and disaster are the punishments that the sentence must have been intended to describe.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the directive is *critically discuss*, and unqualified acceptance forfeits the evaluative half of a twenty-mark question.
- **B:** Correct: the directive requires the system before the objection, and the guilt-versus-condition distinction is the sharpest available critical instrument.
- **C:** Incorrect: objecting before reconstruction breaches the directive and loses the marks reserved for faithful exposition of the author's position.
- **D:** Incorrect: this narrows the thesis to natural evil alone, whereas the sentence explicitly partitions all evil into sin and its punishment.

Examiner trap 12: Treat the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a verified verbatim translation; the doctrine is Augustinian, but the exact wording is the examiner's, not a certified rendering.

MCQ 13. The three components of Hick's soul-making

Which set of elements is indispensable to Hick's theodicy?

- A. Retributive justice, a historical Fall, and the eventual restoration of an original perfection that human beings once actually possessed.
- B. Divine hiddenness as an end in itself, the denial of libertarian freedom, and a purely eschatological account of all present goods.
- C. The compensation of victims, the punishment of wrongdoers, and the proportioning of happiness to virtue within the present life.
- D. Genuine freedom, an epistemic distance from God that leaves the world religiously ambiguous, and a stable law-governed order that can injure.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: these are the Augustinian type's components, which Hick explicitly contrasts with the forward-looking Irenaean type he defends.
- **B:** Incorrect: epistemic distance serves freedom rather than being an end in itself, and Hick requires libertarian freedom rather than denying it.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is Kant's structure of the highest good, and soul-making is developmental rather than retributive or distributive.
- **D:** Correct: these three convert the platitude that hardship builds character into a theodicy with a stated rationale and a stated cost.

Examiner trap 13: Reducing Hick to "suffering makes us stronger" discards the three components that carry the argument and leaves nothing for an objection to engage with.

MCQ 14. Varying the God-concept

The 2024 stem claims that the problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system. Which treatment best fulfils the directive?

- A. Assert that all religions face the problem equally, since suffering is universal and no conceptual variation can alter the force of the argument.
- B. Deny the claim outright, since the reality of suffering is independent of theology and therefore cannot depend on any concept of the divine.
- C. Run the classical set against classical theism, a finite or process God, an impersonal Absolute and non-creator systems, and price each dissolution.
- D. Concede the claim and conclude that theism is refuted, since a problem that varies with the concept cannot be a genuine philosophical problem at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: non-creator systems face no charge of divine culpability, so the claim of uniform force cannot survive a single comparative test.
- **B:** Incorrect: the reality of suffering is not in dispute; what varies is whether that suffering constitutes an objection to a given God-concept.
- **C:** Correct: showing the dependence requires varying the concept, and the critical half is naming the religiously significant loss each variation incurs.
- **D:** Incorrect: concept-dependence relocates the cost into the theology rather than refuting theism, and the theodicies exist precisely to keep all the attributes.

Examiner trap 14: Listing the dissolutions without their costs answers only half the 2024 question, because "critically discuss" buys the price list as much as the mechanism.

MCQ 15. The Irenaean and Augustinian types

Which contrast between Hick's two types is stated correctly?

- A. The Augustinian type is developmental and teleological, while the Irenaean type is retributive and explains suffering as deserved punishment for sin.
- B. The Augustinian type looks back to a fall from an original perfection, while the Irenaean type looks forward to growth from immaturity into likeness.
- C. The Augustinian type denies human freedom altogether, while the Irenaean type makes freedom the sole explanation of both moral and natural evil.
- D. The Augustinian type is a defence needing only possibility, while the Irenaean type is a theodicy claiming to identify God's actual purposes.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the two types and would make Irenaeus the source of the retributive framing that Hick contrasts with his own.
- **B:** Correct: the backward-looking Fall and the forward-looking image-to-likeness growth are exactly the axis on which Hick's typology turns.
- **C:** Incorrect: Augustine grounds moral evil in defective will, which presupposes rather than denies creaturely freedom.
- **D:** Incorrect: both are theodicies claiming actual reasons, and the defence category belongs to Plantinga and to skeptical theism instead.

Examiner trap 15: The typology is itself examinable content; naming it converts a list of theodicies into a structured account of how the tradition divides.

MCQ 16. Rowe's argument and its inductive step

Which statement about the evidential argument is correct?

- A. It is a deductive demonstration whose conclusion follows necessarily once the existence of any instance of intense suffering has been conceded.
- B. It concerns only moral evil, since natural suffering cannot be described as gratuitous in the absence of an agent who might have prevented it.
- C. It begins from the claim that some suffering serves no discernible justifying good, and its weakest point is the step from unseen reason to absent reason.
- D. It succeeds only if the theist grants that God's reasons must be transparent to human beings, which no classical theist has ever been willing to concede.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Rowe presents the argument as evidential rather than demonstrative, and he allows that a theist may remain rational in rejecting it.
- **B:** Incorrect: the fawn is a case of natural evil, and it was chosen precisely because no human agency is involved anywhere in it.
- **C:** Correct: the inductive step from "no justifying reason is seen" to "no justifying reason exists" is exactly what skeptical theism attacks.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument requires only that such reasons would probably be discernible, which is weaker than a demand for full transparency.

Examiner trap 16: Presenting the fawn as a deductive contradiction collapses the logical and evidential versions and triggers the most heavily penalised error in this clause.

MCQ 17. Wykstra's condition, stated exactly

Which formulation states CORNEA correctly?

- A. One may claim that p is absent whenever no evidence for p has been produced, since the burden of proof always rests on the party asserting existence.
- B. One may claim that it appears that p is absent only if it is reasonable to believe that p would likely be discernible, given one's cognitive situation, were it there.
- C. One may claim that p is absent only if a competent authority within the relevant religious tradition has confirmed that no such thing has ever been observed.
- D. One may claim that p is absent only if the claim can be verified by a repeatable procedure, which no claim about divine purposes could ever satisfy.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a generic burden-of-proof rule, whereas CORNEA is a specific condition on when an appearance of absence licenses a claim of absence.
- **B:** Correct: the Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access ties the legitimacy of a *noseeum* claim to the likelihood of discernment in one's actual cognitive position.
- **C:** Incorrect: appeals to religious authority form no part of Wykstra's epistemology, which is framed entirely in terms of cognitive access.
- **D:** Incorrect: a verificationist criterion would prove far too much and would also eliminate the theistic claims Wykstra is defending.

Examiner trap 17: Substituting "God works in mysterious ways" for a stated epistemic principle converts a defensible philosophical position into an unfalsifiable appeal worth no marks.

MCQ 18. What skeptical theism costs and what it covers

Consider the following statements about skeptical theism.

1. It is a defence rather than a theodicy, because it attacks an inference instead of identifying God's reason.
2. It targets the evidential argument rather than the logical problem.
3. Its principal cost is that the same scepticism threatens ordinary moral judgement and the duty to rescue.
4. It is refuted outright by the observation that we routinely infer absence from non-observation.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only, because the inference from non-observation to absence is a standard and reliable form of everyday reasoning.
- B. 2, 3 and 4 only, because skeptical theism claims to state God's reasons while denying that we can identify them.
- C. 1 and 2 only, because the moral-scepticism objection was withdrawn once the scope restriction to value-entailments was proposed.
- D. 1, 2 and 3 only, because the *noseeum* inference is legitimate in some domains and CORNEA specifies exactly when it fails.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 4 misstates the position, since CORNEA concedes that such inferences are often sound and specifies the condition under which they are not.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 1 is dropped here even though it is true, and the description offered of skeptical theism contradicts its defensive character.
- **C:** Incorrect: the moral-scepticism objection has not been withdrawn, and critics find the value-entailment restriction unstable and *ad hoc*.

- **D:** Correct: the position is a defence against the evidential argument, and its standing price is the threat it poses to ordinary moral confidence.

Examiner trap 18: Deploying skeptical theism and a positive theodicy in the same paragraph is self-undermining, because one says the reason is unknowable while the other names it.

MCQ 19. Horrendous evils and the distinction that answers them

Which statement captures Adams' position accurately?

- A. A horrendous evil is any evil of exceptional magnitude, and it is answered by showing that the world's total value nevertheless exceeds its total disvalue.
- B. A horrendous evil is one caused by human cruelty rather than by nature, and it is answered by the free-will defence supplemented by eventual divine judgement.
- C. A horrendous evil gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt their life is a great good to them, and requires defeat within that life rather than global balancing.
- D. A horrendous evil is one for which no explanation is available, and it is answered by conceding that theodicy has failed and that only silence is appropriate.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: magnitude alone is not the criterion, and a global sum is precisely the response Adams argues cannot answer the person's own question.
- **B:** Incorrect: perpetrators as well as victims are participants, and the definition is fixed by the threat to a life's overall worth rather than by causal origin.
- **C:** Correct: the definition is technical and the required response is personal-level defeat, which Chisholm's term distinguishes from mere balancing off.
- **D:** Incorrect: Adams offers a positive account through divine identification and beatific intimacy rather than a concession that no answer exists.

Examiner trap 19: Using "horrendous evil" as a loose intensifier discards the one distinction - defeat within a life versus balancing across a world - that the term was coined to carry.

MCQ 20. Which replies survive the animal-suffering case

Which assessment of the pre-human suffering problem is correct?

- A. Free will and retribution fail immediately, soul-making applies only instrumentally through human virtue, and nomic regularity alone partly survives on the Western side.
- B. Soul-making succeeds completely, because the suffering animal acquires the virtues of endurance and patience that constitute moral growth in any sentient creature.
- C. The problem dissolves once we accept that animals lack sentience altogether, a position now settled by consensus in both philosophy and the empirical sciences.
- D. The problem is answered by the fallen-order reply, which is the historically and scientifically best-supported explanation of pre-human natural suffering.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the animal neither chooses nor morally grows, so only the stable-order reply retains any purchase, and even that explains kind rather than amount.
- **B:** Incorrect: moral growth requires an agent capable of freely chosen virtue, which is exactly what the animal sufferer is not.
- **C:** Incorrect: the neo-Cartesian premise about higher-order awareness is philosophically and empirically contested rather than settled.

- **D:** Incorrect: a cosmic fall preceding human history is historically and scientifically strained and is among the weakest replies available.

Examiner trap 20: Naming the animal case as the point where two major theodicies both run out is itself a mark-earning move, and omitting it leaves a twenty-marker without its residue paragraph.

MCQ 21. Process theodicy and its named layers

Which statement correctly assigns a claim to its process author?

- A. Whitehead argued that classical omnipotence is incoherent, Hartshorne introduced the initial aim, and Griffin coined the phrase "fellow-sufferer who understands".
- B. Whitehead supplied the dipolar God with primordial and consequent natures, Hartshorne argued omnipotence is incoherent, and Griffin made persuasion a metaphysical necessity.
- C. Whitehead defended a self-limiting God who chooses restraint, Hartshorne systematised the theology, and Griffin treated evil as privation of a due good.
- D. Whitehead denied that God has any nature at all, Hartshorne restored divine immutability, and Griffin argued that evil is necessary for the greater good.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the incoherence argument is Hartshorne's, the initial aim is Whitehead's, and the fellow-sufferer phrase closes *Process and Reality*.
- **B:** Correct: this assigns the dipolar structure, the incoherence argument and the metaphysical-necessity move to their actual authors.
- **C:** Incorrect: chosen self-limitation is Plantinga's structure rather than Whitehead's, and privation belongs to Augustine rather than to Griffin.
- **D:** Incorrect: the dipolar doctrine is Whitehead's own, and process thought explicitly rejects both immutability and the greater-good instrumentalisation of evil.

Examiner trap 21: Writing "process theodicy (Whitehead)" and stopping forfeits the marks reserved for naming which layer of the position is doing the work in the argument.

MCQ 22. The reply-space around the classical theodicies

Which pairing of a response with its principal cost is accurate?

- A. The Leibnizian best-world response costs nothing philosophically, because a perfect being must by definition select the unique optimum among possible worlds.
- B. Eschatological fulfilment costs nothing, since a later restoration automatically converts any permitted suffering into a justified means to that restoration.
- C. The greater-good and stable-order response may explain the *kind* of world without explaining the *amount* or *distribution* of suffering within it.
- D. Protest or anti-theodicy costs nothing, because refusing to justify suffering settles the logical and evidential arguments in the objector's favour at once.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: there may be no unique best world, and world-total optimisation can neglect goodness to the particular persons who bear the losses.
- **B:** Incorrect: compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it, which is exactly the balancing-versus-defeat point.
- **C:** Correct: risk and regular law can be shown necessary for certain goods without thereby accounting for the observed quantity or allocation of harm.

- **D:** Incorrect: protest diagnoses the ethics of explanation but leaves the logical and evidential arguments themselves entirely unsettled.

Examiner trap 22: Every response in this space has a stated cost; a script that lists responses without costs has described the literature instead of evaluating it.

MCQ 23. Karma across the Indian schools

Which statement about the Indian responses to suffering is correct?

- A. Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and Jain accounts require no divine distributor, while Nyāya and theistic Vedānta assign God a just administrative role over karmic fruit.
- B. Every Indian school treats karma as administered by a personal creator God, which is why the Indian tradition faces the same problem of evil as classical theism.
- C. Karma is presented in all schools as a doctrine with an identifiable first act, since a beginningless series would make the assignment of desert impossible.
- D. Advaita denies that suffering occurs at all, and therefore has no need of any account of the empirical distribution of pain among embodied beings.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the theistic and non-theistic accounts differ precisely on whether a divine dispenser is required, and Nyāya's Lord allots according to desert rather than arbitrarily.
- **B:** Incorrect: the non-theistic schools drop the defendant entirely, which is the structural reason the Indian material can dissolve the classical problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the series is standardly treated as beginningless, which blocks the demand for a first wrongful act without verifying any particular past cause.
- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita locates suffering at the empirical level and treats it as sublated only under liberating knowledge at the ultimate level.

Examiner trap 23: Presenting karma as a single theistic doctrine across the schools is the canonical error, and it also destroys the comparison that makes the Indian material worth citing.

MCQ 24. Evil and the profane as religion-forming categories

Which statement about the 2019 owner-module is correct?

- A. The profane is a synonym for the evil, so Durkheim's binary is a moral classification of actions into the permitted and the forbidden.
- B. Otto's holy and Durkheim's sacred are interchangeable terms, since both denote the social classification through which a moral community is constituted.
- C. Evil and the profane found religion structurally by supplying the predicament, the boundary, the institutions and the soteriological task.
- D. Eliade's hierophany describes the moral judgement by which a community declares certain acts sinful and therefore excludes them from communal life.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Durkheim's profane is simply the ordinary and non-consecrated, and conflating it with the wicked is the commonest error on this stem.
- **B:** Incorrect: Otto's numinous holy is the object-side of religious response, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a social classification.
- **C:** Correct: the four-step sequence is the functional account the directive demands, and it founds religion rather than theism.

- **D:** Incorrect: hierophany is the irruption of the sacred generating sacred space and time, not a moral verdict on conduct.

Examiner trap 24: Answering this functional-sociological stem with theodicies answers a different question, because the 2019 examiner asks what evil and the profane *do*, not whether they disprove God.

Remedial MCQs - common-error repair

These eight drills target the specific errors that the canonical trap list identifies as recurring on this clause. Attempt them only after the twenty-four core diagnostics.

MCQ 25. Repairing the mismatch of reply to version

A candidate answers a stem on the amount and distribution of suffering by reconstructing the free-will defence in full. Which correction is required?

- A. None; the free-will defence is the standard reply to every formulation, and its coverage of moral evil is sufficient for any stem on suffering.
- B. The candidate should have used the free-will defence but added a devotional conclusion, since an evidential stem calls for pastoral rather than analytic treatment.
- C. The candidate should have replaced the free-will defence with the Augustinian privation account, which alone addresses the quantity of suffering in the world.
- D. The candidate should have named the evidential version and answered with a theodicy, skeptical theism or a revised God-concept rather than a bare consistency defence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the defence answers only the logical charge, and the amount of suffering is untouched by any argument that establishes bare possibility.
- **B:** Incorrect: a devotional conclusion is penalised at every band, and the fault here is structural rather than one of tone.
- **C:** Incorrect: privation addresses the metaphysical status of evil rather than its quantity, so the substitution repairs nothing.
- **D:** Correct: the evidential burden is probability, and only a positive reason, a blocked inference or a changed God-concept can discharge it.

Examiner trap 25: Version-mismatch is invisible to the candidate and obvious to the examiner, which is why naming the version explicitly in the opening is worth more than any additional content.

MCQ 26. Repairing "the triad is self-contradictory on its face"

A script asserts that omnipotence, perfect goodness and the existence of evil are contradictory without further argument. What must be supplied?

- A. A definition of evil as a positive substance, since only a substantial evil could stand in genuine logical opposition to divine goodness.
- B. The two bridging principles about what a good being does and what an omnipotent being can do, without which no formal contradiction arises.
- C. An empirical survey of the quantity of suffering, since the contradiction emerges only once the scale of the world's evil is established.
- D. A demonstration that God's goodness must be recognisable to creatures, since an unrecognisable goodness could not conflict with anything observable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: substantiality is Augustine's target rather than a requirement of Mackie's argument, which is about the consistency of propositions.
- **B:** Correct: the goodness and power bridges convert a merely uncomfortable set into an inconsistent one, and each is separately contestable.
- **C:** Incorrect: quantity belongs to the evidential version, and the logical charge is meant to hold even for a single instance of evil.
- **D:** Incorrect: recognisability concerns divine hiddenness, which is a distinct issue and no part of the logical formulation.

Examiner trap 26: The 2020 stem is answered in the bridges; a script that omits them has written the question's premise rather than its answer.

MCQ 27. Repairing "privation means the pain is not real"

A script argues that because Augustine calls evil a privation, Augustinian theodicy denies the reality of suffering. What is the correct repair?

- A. The script is right, and this is precisely why the privation account was abandoned by later Christian theology in favour of the Irenaean approach.
- B. The script should add that privation applies only to moral evil, so that natural suffering remains fully real while moral evil is merely an absence.
- C. The script should recognise that a privation is a real lack of a good that ought to be present, so blindness is a determinate deprivation rather than an illusion.
- D. The script should replace privation with the process account, since only a God of persuasive power can take the reality of suffering seriously.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the account was not abandoned, and its central claim concerns the metaphysical status of evil rather than the phenomenology of pain.
- **B:** Incorrect: privation is not restricted to moral evil, and the proposed split has no basis in the Augustinian framework.
- **C:** Correct: the account denies evil an independent substance while affirming that the lack is real in a subject whose nature calls for the missing good.
- **D:** Incorrect: substituting a different theodicy avoids the misreading instead of correcting it, and the question asks for a repair.

Examiner trap 27: Rot in wood is the canonical illustration: the rot is not a rival substance, and it is not therefore imaginary - it is the real loss of the wood's proper integrity.

MCQ 28. Repairing "soul-making just means suffering makes us stronger"

Which repair restores Hick's argument?

- A. Add epistemic distance, genuine freedom and a stable law-governed order, and distinguish the developmental rationale from retributive punishment.
- B. Add the claim that every instance of suffering produces a proportionate increase in virtue, which is what makes the theodicy explanatorily complete.
- C. Add the claim that Irenaeus coined the phrase "vale of Soul-making", which supplies the patristic authority the modern version otherwise lacks.
- D. Add the observation that soul-making covers animal suffering directly, since animals also develop resilience through the hardships they endure.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these three components convert a platitude into a theodicy with a rationale, and the contrast with punishment fixes its forward-looking character.
- **B:** Incorrect: Hick makes no proportionality claim, and asserting one exposes the theodicy to the scale objection in its strongest form.
- **C:** Incorrect: the phrase is Keats's from the spring 1819 journal-letter, and attributing it to Irenaeus is a marked factual error.
- **D:** Incorrect: the animal does not morally grow, so extended soul-making reaches animals only instrumentally through human virtue toward them.

Examiner trap 28: Keats supplied the phrase, Irenaeus the image-and-likeness theology and Hick the modern theodicy; collapsing the three is the single commonest attribution error in this topic.

MCQ 29. Repairing "the process God is simply powerless"

Which statement corrects the misdescription?

- A. The process God possesses full classical omnipotence but voluntarily declines to use it, which is why evil occurs without divine culpability.
- B. The process God has no relation to the world at all, so questions of power and culpability do not arise within the process framework.
- C. The process God is powerless in the strict sense, and process writers accept that this makes their deity unworthy of worship by their own admission.
- D. The process God exercises persuasive power by supplying each occasion its initial aim, and cannot coerce because to be actual is to have some self-determination.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: voluntary restraint is Plantinga's structure, whereas Griffin's point is that the limitation is metaphysically necessary rather than chosen.
- **B:** Incorrect: the consequent nature makes God supremely related to the world, which is the opposite of detachment.
- **C:** Incorrect: the worship objection is raised by critics and answered by appeal to solidarity and objective immortality, not conceded by process writers.
- **D:** Correct: persuasion through the initial aim is a real and maximal form of power, limited by the distributed self-determination of actual entities.

Examiner trap 29: The modal difference is the examinable point: Griffin's God *cannot* coerce, while Plantinga's God *chooses* not to intervene.

MCQ 30. Repairing "karma shows that this person deserved it"

A script infers from a person's suffering that they must have committed a specific wrong in a previous life. What is the correct repair?

- A. The inference is unavailable to ordinary observers, and using karma this way converts explanation into victim-blaming without any epistemic warrant.
- B. The inference is sound but should be stated compassionately, since the doctrine's truth is unaffected by the distress that stating it may cause.
- C. The inference is valid only in theistic schools, where a divine dispenser guarantees that each specific suffering matches a specific past act.
- D. The inference should be replaced by the claim that suffering is illusory, which is the Advaitic solution to the difficulty the script has created.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the mechanism is not observationally accessible, so no particular desert can be read off a particular case, and the misuse is a moral as well as epistemic error.
- **B:** Incorrect: the inference is not sound, and presenting an unwarranted judgement gently does not make it warranted.
- **C:** Incorrect: even where God allots fruit justly, the specific karmic history remains beyond the senses and known only through testimony.
- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita places suffering at the empirical level rather than denying it, and the substitution introduces a second error.

Examiner trap 30: Karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief; a causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid, and saying so protects the answer's ethical credibility.

MCQ 31. Repairing "the profane is the evil"

A script treating the 2019 stem writes that the profane is the wicked and the sacred the righteous. What is the correct repair?

- A. Replace the pair with the pure and impure, since ritual pollution is the only category that Durkheim's sociology actually recognises.
- B. Distinguish four categories - evil as moral or natural harm, the profane as the ordinary, the impure as the ritually polluting and the demonic as the anti-sacred.
- C. Replace Durkheim with Otto, since only the numinous account of the holy can supply the moral content that the sacred-profane binary lacks.
- D. Retain the identification but restrict it to Indian traditions, where purity codes make the profane and the morally wrong effectively equivalent.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the impure is one further category rather than a replacement, and Durkheim's classification is explicitly of things into sacred and profane.
- **B:** Correct: keeping the four apart is what the module requires, and the profane is the everyday rather than the wicked.
- **C:** Incorrect: Otto describes the object-side of religious response and does not supply a moral content to Durkheim's social classification.
- **D:** Incorrect: Indian purity and impurity codes are ritual categories, and demerit and merit form a separate moral vocabulary alongside them.

Examiner trap 31: A ploughed field, a market and an ordinary weekday are all profane and none of them is evil; one such illustration in the opening paragraph prevents the whole error.

MCQ 32. Repairing "God's ways are mysterious" as a philosophical position

A script offers divine mystery as its answer to the evidential argument. What is the correct repair?

- A. Replace mystery with the free-will defence, since a defence is always preferable to a theodicy when the burden is one of probability.
- B. Retain mystery and add that it is unfalsifiable, since unfalsifiability protects the claim from any possible empirical objection.
- C. Replace mystery with a full theodicy, because any appeal to human cognitive limitation is illegitimate in philosophical argument.
- D. State CORNEA or Bergmann's representativeness theses, which give the appeal to limitation a disciplined form and a stated cost.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the free-will defence discharges the consistency burden and leaves the probability burden exactly where the script found it.
- **B:** Incorrect: unfalsifiability is a cost rather than a protection, and it is one of the three standing objections to skeptical theism.
- **C:** Incorrect: appeals to cognitive limitation are legitimate when disciplined by an access principle, which is precisely what CORNEA supplies.
- **D:** Correct: skeptical theism is the disciplined evidential version of the mystery appeal, and stating its principle also obliges the script to state its price.

Examiner trap 32: Without an access principle, mystery is an unfalsifiable appeal; with CORNEA it becomes a position that can be argued, graded and - importantly for the examiner - costed.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved conceptual drills and distinction loops

Five short drills that fix the distinctions the examiner tests before any full answer is attempted.

Drill 1 - Defence or theodicy? Plantinga offers a **defence**: he claims only that a morally sufficient reason is *possible*, so no evidence for transworld depravity is required. Hick offers a **theodicy**: he claims to identify God's *actual* purpose, and is therefore refuted if soul-making is not in fact the purpose.

Drill 2 - Explanation or justification? Karma *explains* why this person suffers by locating a cause; it does not thereby *justify* the suffering or license withholding aid. Confusing the two is how an explanatory doctrine becomes victim-blaming.

Drill 3 - Privation or illusion? Privation says evil is a real lack of a due good, not a created substance. Blindness is a determinate deprivation in a creature whose nature calls for sight; it is not an illusion, and Augustine never says it is.

Drill 4 - Balancing off or defeat? Balancing off outweighs the evil within a larger sum, leaving it external to the good. Defeat - Chisholm's term - integrates the evil into a whole whose value it contributes to. Adams demands the second, and demands it *within the individual life*.

Drill 5 - Skeptical theism or positive theodicy? Skeptical theism says we cannot tell whether a justifying reason exists. A theodicy says what the reason is. Holding both in the same paragraph is self-undermining, and the examiner notices.

All 7 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks

All 7 items below are direct verified owner PYQs. Exact wording, years and marks are retained. Demand decoding, full model solutions, marks rationale, timing skeletons and examiner traps are pedagogic answer support, not an official answer key.

Corpus note: FACT: The audited Paper II corpus for 2018-2025 contains **7 primary-owned question-parts** for this syllabus item, out of 112 parts overall. The clause owns no part in 2018 and exactly one part in every paper from 2019 through 2025. Cross-linked questions owned by *Notions of God, Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation or Religious Experience* are not duplicated here.

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
1	2019	Q6(b)	15	Evil and the profane as religion-forming categories
2	2020	Q6(b)	15	The logical problem of evil
3	2021	Q5(e)	10	The paradox of omnipotence in the context of evil
4	2022	Q6(c)	15	Absolute creation and human responsibility
5	2023	Q8(a)	20	Augustine - all evil is sin or punishment for sin
6	2024	Q6(c)	15	The problem as an offshoot of the God-concept
7	2025	Q6(b)	15	The main tenets of process theodicy

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?"

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What role do A and B play to provide a firm foundation to...</i> - a functional account of how negative categories constitute religion, not a definition of either term
Core issue	Whether religion is founded on a diagnosis of what is wrong rather than on belief in God
Scope boundary	This is the sociological-phenomenological question; the theistic problem of evil is not what is asked
Ideal thesis	Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally - and they found <i>religion</i> , not <i>theism</i>
Non-negotiables	Durkheim, Otto and Eliade correctly distinguished; the profane ≠ evil correction; the four-step founding sequence; Indian parity with its rider

Model answer (≈250 words)

The question is functional, not theological: it asks what work negative categories do in constituting religion. **Durkheim**, in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), holds that all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, **profane** and **sacred**, and defines religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a church. The definition is deliberately God-free. ANALYSIS: A correction must be made at once: the **profane is the ordinary, not the wicked**; evil, impurity and the demonic are three further and distinct categories.

Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) supplies the object-side - the **numinous**, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - while **Eliade's** *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) shows the sacred irrupting as **hierophany**, generating sacred space around an *axis mundi* and recoverable sacred time.

The founding sequence follows. A religion first names a **predicament** - sin, impurity, suffering (*duḥkha*), ignorance (*avidyā*), karmic bondage. The predicament is marked by a **boundary** - pure and impure, sacred and profane - which generates ritual, prohibition and moral code. The boundary generates **institutions**: priesthood, initiation, purification,

penance. The predicament generates a **soteriology**, the ordered path out.

Indian material is the clearest case: the Buddhist **First Noble Truth** makes suffering the explicit foundation of an entire religion; Jain *āsrava* and *bandha* name the predicament and *saṃvara* and *nirjarā* the exit. ANALYSIS: India's founding defect is more often ignorance or bondage than moral evil, which yields diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness.

Verdict: the binary is an ideal type, not a law, and wonder and gratitude are independent religious roots; but evil and the profane found religion **structurally** - they supply the predicament and the boundary without which soteriology would be idle. They found religion, not theism.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** functional framing -> Durkheim with the profane correction -> Otto and Eliade -> four-step sequence -> Indian parity -> ideal-type qualification -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** sacred/profane classification; the God-free definition of religion; the numinous; hierophany, *axis mundi*, recoverable time.
- **Distinction:** evil ≠ profane ≠ impure ≠ demonic, made in the first paragraph rather than as an afterthought.
- **Comparison:** the Buddhist First Noble Truth as the world's clearest case of evil as religion-founding.
- **Technical terms:** *duḥkha*, *avidyā*, *āsrava*, *bandha*, *saṃvara*, *nirjarā*, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*.
- **Criticism:** the binary is a Durkheimian imposition and Eliade's archaic ontology is unfalsifiable; treat the pair as an ideal type.
- **Conclusion:** the structural-not-doctrinal verdict, plus the religion-not-theism rider that shows the candidate knows the question's scope.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Frame the question as functional, not theological
3 min : Durkheim + the profane ≠ evil correction
3 min : Otto (object-side) and Eliade (hierophany, space, time)
4 min : Predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology
2 min : Indian parity + the ignorance-not-sin rider
1 min : Ideal-type qualification; wonder and gratitude
1 min : Verdict - structural, not doctrinal; religion, not theism
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Equating the profane with the evil: **the single commonest and most heavily penalised error on this stem**.
- Answering with theodicies: **out of scope; the question is functional**.
- Interchanging Otto's holy with Durkheim's sacred: **factual error about which side of the analysis each occupies**.
- Omitting Indian parity: **loses the comparative marks the paper reliably rewards**.
- Presenting the binary as a universal law: **ignores the standing objection that many traditions grade rather than dichotomise**.
- Concluding that evil founds theism: **the wrong conclusion; it founds religion, including non-theistic religion**.

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What is... Discuss</i> - state the set precisely, then evaluate; a lament about suffering earns nothing
Core issue	Whether the theist's propositions are <i>formally</i> inconsistent
Scope boundary	The logical version only; the evidential problem appears at the end as the place the debate migrates to
Ideal thesis	The set is inconsistent only with the bridging premises , and the whole debate is a fight over those premises
Non-negotiables	Mackie 1955; the numbered set including omniscience; both bridges; adequate/fallacious framing; Plantinga's defence; the migration to Rowe

Model answer (≈255 words)

The logical problem alleges that a set of theistic beliefs cannot all be true. **J. L. Mackie**, "Evil and Omnipotence" (*Mind*, 1955), sets out the propositions: God is **omnipotent**; God is **perfectly good**; and **evil exists**. The full classical profile adds **omniscience**, which blocks the reply that evil escaped divine notice.

Crucially, these propositions are **not formally contradictory by themselves**. Nothing in them, plus logic alone, entails both a proposition and its negation. The contradiction is manufactured by two **bridging principles**: first, that a perfectly good being eliminates evil as far as it can; second, that an omnipotent being has no relevant limit on preventing any evil whose prevention is logically possible. Mackie sorts the replies into **adequate solutions**, which honestly abandon one proposition, and **fallacious solutions**, which appear to keep all three while covertly limiting power or redefining goodness.

The theist has three exits, each attacking a bridge. Insert "**unless there is a morally sufficient reason**" into the goodness bridge, and the whole space of defences and theodicies opens. Deny the power bridge and one gets **Plantinga's free-will defence**: significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose only rightly, so a world containing moral good may be unavailable without moral evil. Plantinga needs only **possibility**, which is why transworld depravity is asserted as possible and never as actual. Denying the reality of evil - privation, or the empirical level in Advaita - is the third and most costly exit.

Verdict: the logical problem is widely regarded as answered; the live debate has migrated to **Rowe's evidential** form, where consistency no longer suffices.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: numbered set -> why it is not a formal contradiction -> the two bridges -> the three exits -> verdict and migration.
- **Doctrine**: Mackie's article and date; the adequate/fallacious taxonomy; omniscience in the full profile.
- **Argument**: the bridges are written as separate premises, so the objections have something determinate to attack.
- **Distinction**: defence versus theodicy, deployed to explain why possibility suffices for Plantinga.
- **Technical terms**: inconsistent set, bridging premise, morally sufficient reason, transworld depravity.
- **Criticism**: the third exit's cost - denying evil's reality - is stated rather than passed over.
- **Conclusion**: naming the migration to the evidential problem is the highest-value sentence available in this question.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define the logical problem as a consistency charge
 3 min : The propositions as a numbered set, including omniscience
 3 min : Why the bare set is not a formal contradiction
 3 min : Bridge A and Bridge B, written out
 3 min : Three exits - morally sufficient reason, Plantinga, privation/levels
 1 min : Mackie's adequate/fallacious framing
 1 min : Verdict - answered; the debate migrates to Rowe
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Asserting contradiction without the bridges: **concedes the analytical core of the question**.
- Confusing Mackie's charge with Rowe's: **version error, the most penalised fault in this clause**.
- Writing that Mackie "proved God does not exist": **overstatement; he argued a set is inconsistent**.
- Omitting omniscience: **leaves the ignorance reply open and weakens the profile**.
- Presenting Plantinga as supplying God's actual reason: **misdescribes a defence as a theodicy**.
- Ending without the migration: **loses the one sentence that shows command of the current debate**.

PYQ 3 - 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss the paradox of...</i> - a paradox stated as a dilemma with both horns and both costs , then the restriction that dissolves it
Core issue	Whether unrestricted power over things and unrestricted power over what powers exist can coexist
Scope boundary	The context clause is mandatory: the paradox must be connected to evil, not discussed in the abstract
Ideal thesis	Unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is incoherent, and the free-will defence requires the restriction
Non-negotiables	Mackie 1955; first-order and second-order power; the three restrictions; the Plantinga/Griffin modal contrast

Model answer (≈160 words)

Mackie (*Mind*, 1955) frames the paradox as a dilemma: can an omnipotent being create things it cannot afterwards control? If it **cannot**, its **second-order** power - power to determine what powers exist - is limited. If it **can and does**, its **first-order** power over those things is limited. Unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is therefore incoherent.

Three restrictions dissolve it. Omnipotence may extend only to the **logically possible**, which almost all theists concede. Or it may be **second-order sovereignty freely self-bound** in the act of creating free agents. Or it may be abandoned, as in **process theism**, where power is intrinsically distributed and divine power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity.

The connection to evil is exact. The **free-will defence** requires one of these restrictions: God creates significantly free agents and cannot causally guarantee that they choose well. For Plantinga this restraint is **chosen**; for Griffin it is **metaphysically necessary**.

Verdict: the paradox does not refute theism; it forces theism to specify which sense of omnipotence it is defending, and to pay for the choice.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** dilemma -> both horns with costs -> three restrictions -> the link to evil -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the first-order/second-order distinction, which is the paradox's actual content.
- **Argument:** each horn is priced rather than merely stated.
- **Distinction:** chosen self-limitation versus metaphysical necessity, named with their authors.
- **Technical terms:** second-order sovereignty, self-binding, logically possible, persuasive power.
- **Criticism:** the self-binding route re-opens the intervention question, which the verdict acknowledges.
- **Conclusion:** the paradox forces a specification rather than a refutation - the correctly graded ending for ten marks.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : State the dilemma in one sentence
2 min : Horn 1 and Horn 2, each with its cost
3 min : The three restrictions, with the process option last
2 min : The link to evil via the free-will defence
1 min : Plantinga chooses; Griffin cannot
1 min : Verdict - specification, not refutation
Total : 10 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Using only the heavy-stone form: **a riddle rather than an analysis**.
- Omitting the connection to evil: **the stem's context clause is explicit and its omission is penalised**.
- Claiming the paradox disproves God: **overstatement; it shows an incoherence in one construal**.
- Merging Plantinga's chosen restraint with Griffin's necessity: **conflates a defence with a theodicy**.
- Drifting into the general coherence of omnipotence: **that belongs to Notions of God**.
- Exceeding the band: **a ten-marker with four theodicies has no analysis left in it**.

PYQ 4 - 2022, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine [a quoted thesis]</i> - fidelity to the claim's scope before evaluation
Core issue	Whether absolute creation transfers moral authorship from the creature to the creator
Scope boundary	The stem concerns moral evil and human agency; natural evil is the residue, not the subject
Ideal thesis	The conditional fails as stated, but its rejoinder - that knowingly instantiating the system remains morally relevant - survives
Non-negotiables	Free-will defence; privation; foreknowledge $\neq$ causation; the process alternative; the retained rejoinder

Model answer (~255 words)

The stem asserts a conditional: absolute creation entails that human agents cannot be responsible for evil. Its scope must be fixed first - it concerns **moral evil**, since no one attributes an earthquake to a human agent.

Three replies resist the conditional. First, the **free-will defence**: God creates the *capacity* for choice, while the agent supplies the *act*. Significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, and God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose rightly - the description cancels itself. A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents. Second, **Augustine's privation account**: God creates natures, all of which are good as created; evil is a **privation of a due good** arising in a **defective will**, so what God creates and what goes wrong are not the same item. Third, **foreknowledge is not causation**: knowing what an agent will freely do does not make the agent do it.

A fourth route rejects the antecedent. **Process theism** denies that God has the unilateral power the stem presupposes: power is intrinsically distributed, so no being determines another's becoming.

ANALYSIS: The critical half must concede what survives. Even granting that God does not cause the act, **knowingly choosing to instantiate the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant**. Foreknowledge does not cause free action, but it does not discharge the decision to create.

Verdict: the conditional is false as stated - creaturely authorship is preserved - but it is not empty. It correctly identifies a residual divine responsibility for the *system*, which the free-will defence answers by pricing rather than by denying.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** fix the scope -> three replies to the conditional -> one reply rejecting the antecedent -> the retained rejoinder -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** capacity versus act; *privatio boni*; the self-cancelling description of determined freedom.
- **Argument:** each reply is attached to the exact step of the conditional it blocks.
- **Distinction:** causing an act versus instantiating a system in which the act occurs.
- **Technical terms:** significant freedom, defective will, privation, unilateral power.
- **Criticism:** the rejoinder is conceded rather than suppressed, which is what "critically" buys.
- **Conclusion:** false as stated but not empty - a graded verdict rather than a flat rejection.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Fix the scope - moral evil, human agency
 4 min : Free-will defence: capacity vs act; the self-cancelling description
 3 min : Privation: God creates natures, not defects
 2 min : Foreknowledge is not causation
 2 min : Process denial of the antecedent
 2 min : The retained rejoinder about instantiating the system
 1 min : Verdict - false as stated, not empty
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Accepting the conditional: **abandons the critical directive**.
- Answering with natural evil: **out of scope; the stem is about human agency**.
- Suppressing the rejoinder: **produces an uncritical defence and caps the script below the strong band**.
- Treating foreknowledge as the whole issue: **the stem is about creation, not omniscience**.
- Using the process reply as the only answer: **changes the subject rather than examining the claim**.
- Ending with a devotional sentence: **penalised at every band on this clause**.

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Quotation." - <i>Critically discuss</i> - reconstruct the author's own system first , then test it
Core issue	Whether the sin-and-punishment partition covers all evil
Scope boundary	Augustine's framework in full, then the standing objections; rivals appear as comparators, not as substitutes
Ideal thesis	The thesis preserves divine goodness for moral evil but is incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering
Non-negotiables	Privation metaphysics; defective will; the Fall; the guilt-versus-condition distinction; Hick and karma as comparators; CAUTION: status of the printed wording

Model answer (~350 words)

Augustine's sentence partitions all evil into **sin** and its **punishment**. The metaphysics behind it must be stated before it is tested. Being, insofar as it is being, is **good**; God creates beings, not evil substances; corruption is **parasitic**, depending on a good nature to corrupt; and moral fault is **disordered willing**. Evil is therefore **privation of a due good (privatio boni)**, not a rival creative principle. ANALYSIS: Privation does not make pain unreal: rot is not a rival substance to wood but the real loss of the wood's proper integrity, and blindness is a determinate lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight.

On this basis the partition works as follows. **Moral evil is sin** - the misuse of created freedom. **Natural evil is punishment** - the consequence of a fallen, disordered order following the Fall.

The critical half has four parts. First, **innocent suffering**: infants and the congenitally afflicted fit a retributive reading poorly. Second, **animal and pre-human suffering**: no free-will defence and no retributive account applies to a creature that neither chooses nor sins, and CAUTION: a cosmic fall preceding human history is historically and scientifically strained. Third, **the metaphysics of privation** is strained for intense positive pain, which does not feel like an absence. Fourth, and most sharply, **inherited guilt**: the claim that later persons are *personally guilty* for an ancestor's act is far harder to defend than the claim that they inherit a **damaged condition** and a disordered social-natural order. ANALYSIS: The second reading reduces the objection but still owes an account of why a good creator permits the condition and its unequal effects.

Two comparators sharpen the verdict. **Hick's soul-making** replaces punishment with **development**: humans are created immature, at an epistemic distance, in a law-governed world where courage and compassion become possible. **Indian karma** replaces a single Fall with a **beginningless** series and thereby answers the **distribution** question - why *this* person - that Augustine cannot; its own cost is unverifiability and the risk of victim-blaming.

Verdict: treating the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a certified translation CAUTION:, the thesis succeeds for moral evil and preserves divine goodness in creation, but it is incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering, where a developmental or distributional account does more work.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: metaphysics first -> the partition -> four objections -> two comparators -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine**: convertibility of being and goodness; parasitic corruption; defective will; the Fall.
- **Argument**: the partition is derived from the metaphysics rather than asserted alongside it.
- **Distinction**: inherited guilt versus inherited condition - the sharpest available critical instrument on this stem.
- **Technical terms**: *privatio boni*, disordered willing, epistemic distance, beginninglessness.
- **Comparison**: Hick on development and karma on distribution, each with its own cost stated.
- **Conclusion**: success-with-remainder rather than flat refutation, plus the quotation-discipline note.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : State the thesis and announce the reconstruct-then-test order
5 min : Privation metaphysics as four premises + rot/blindness examples
3 min : The partition: sin and punishment
5 min : Four objections - innocence, animals, strained privation, inherited guilt
3 min : Hick on development; karma on distribution, each with cost
2 min : Verdict + quotation-discipline note
Total : 20 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Objecting before reconstructing: **breaches the directive and forfeits the exposition marks**.
- Saying privation makes pain imaginary: **attacks a position no Augustinian holds**.
- Treating the printed sentence as a certified verbatim translation: **overstates the textual claim**.
- Merging inherited guilt with inherited condition: **loses the sharpest critical distinction available**.
- Omitting animal suffering: **the residue the examiner expects in a twenty-marker**.
- Concluding that Augustine simply fails: **ungraded verdict; the correct finding is success-with-remainder**.

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss</i> a thesis about dependence - show the dependence by varying the God-concept, then price each variation
Core issue	Whether the argument's force is fixed by the concept of God under defence
Scope boundary	Four God-concepts, not a survey of every theodicy; the theodicies enter as the attempt to keep all attributes
Ideal thesis	The claim is correct, but concept-dependence is not a solution: it relocates the cost into the theology
Non-negotiables	The classical set; process/finite God; Advaita's levels; non-creator systems; the cost of each dissolution

Model answer (≈255 words)

The thesis is correct, and its demonstration is straightforward. State the classical set: God is **omnipotent**, **omniscient**, **perfectly good** and **creator**, and evil exists; the contradiction requires the bridging principles that a good being eliminates evil as far as it can and that omnipotence has no relevant limit. The argument bites only where all four attributes are held together.

Now vary the concept. Weaken **omnipotence** and the **process** God, whose power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity, is simply not the kind of being who could have prevented the evil unilaterally - the charge lapses. Weaken **personality** and **Advaita's nirguṇa** Brahman is untouched: evil is real at the empirical level (*vyāvahārika*) and sublated under liberating knowledge at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*). Remove the **creator** and Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā have **no defendant** at all: suffering is explained by conditions and by deeds, and the moral law is self-operating. Only classical theism carries the full burden.

ANALYSIS: The critical half is the price list. The process route surrenders sovereignty and any guarantee of final victory over evil. Advaita risks minimising present suffering. Non-creator systems give up providence, divine rescue and a personal guarantor of justice. Concept-dependence is therefore not a *solution*: it moves the cost from the argument into the theology. The theodicies - free-will, soul-making, privation - exist precisely because some theists refuse to pay that price and try to keep every attribute.

Verdict: the problem is a stress-test of a *particular* God-concept, not of religion as such - which is why the same suffering that refutes one theology leaves another entirely untouched.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the set -> vary the concept four ways -> price each dissolution -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the bridging premises; persuasive power; the two-level Advaitic ontology; self-operating moral law.
- **Argument:** the dependence is *shown* by variation rather than merely asserted.
- **Distinction:** dissolution versus solution - concept-dependence relocates rather than removes the difficulty.
- **Technical terms:** *nirguṇa*, *vyāvahārika*, *pāramārthika*, persuasive power, self-operating law.
- **Comparison:** three non-classical routes, each with a named tradition and a named loss.
- **Conclusion:** stress-test of one God-concept, not of religion - the exact verdict the stem invites.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Accept the thesis and announce the method - vary the concept
3 min : The classical set with its bridges
3 min : Weaken omnipotence - process
2 min : Weaken personality - Advaita's two levels
3 min : Remove the creator - Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā
2 min : The price list for all three
1 min : Verdict - stress-test of a concept, not of religion
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Listing dissolutions without costs: **answers half the question.**
- Concluding that theism is refuted: **misreads dependence as defeat.**
- Saying Advaita denies suffering: **factual error; it locates suffering at the empirical level.**
- Treating non-creator systems as evasions: **they answer a different question and should be graded, not dismissed.**
- Surveying every theodicy: **the stem asks about God-concepts, not about the catalogue of replies.**
- Omitting the bridges: **the variation has nothing determinate to act on.**

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Explain the main tenets of X</i> - enumerated doctrine, correctly attributed ; number the tenets
Core issue	How a revision of omnipotence answers evil without justifying permission
Scope boundary	Process thought specifically; other non-classical revisions appear only in the closing evaluation
Ideal thesis	Process theodicy purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty
Non-negotiables	Six tenets; Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb named separately; the Griffin/Plantinga modal contrast; the worship objection

Model answer (≈260 words)

Process theodicy answers evil by **revising omnipotence**, not by justifying permission. Its tenets are six.

(1) **Creativity, not God, is the ultimate**; actual entities are self-creative occasions of experience. (2) **God is dipolar**: the **primordial nature** is the ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its **initial aim**; the **consequent nature** receives and preserves what the world becomes. (3) **Power is intrinsically distributed**: to be actual is to possess some self-determination. (4) **Divine power is therefore persuasive by metaphysical necessity** - for **Griffin**, God *cannot* coerce, which is what separates process theodicy from the free-will defence, where God *chooses* not to intervene. (5) **Evil is the deviation of finite occasions from the divine lure**; God is not culpable because God could not unilaterally prevent it. (6) **God is "the fellow-sufferer who understands" (Whitehead)** - solidarity, not detachment.

The layers must be named separately. **Whitehead**, *Process and Reality* (1929), supplies the dipolar God, the initial aim and the consequent nature. **Hartshorne**, *The Divine Relativity* (1948) and *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984), argues that classical omnipotence is **incoherent**: to have all the power is to leave none to anything else. **Griffin**, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976) and *Evil Revisited* (1991), supplies the metaphysical-necessity move. **Cobb's** *A Christian Natural Theology* systematises the theology.

Criticism: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be **unworthy of worship**; the metaphysics is contested; and classical theists deny that actuality entails self-determination. The replies are divine solidarity and the **objective immortality** of achieved value in the consequent nature.

Verdict: it purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty - and the trade must be stated, not concealed.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** numbered tenets -> named layers -> criticism with reply -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** dipolarity, initial aim, consequent nature, distributed power, objective immortality.
- **Argument:** tenet (3) is shown to *entail* tenet (4), so the position is derived rather than listed.
- **Distinction:** Griffin's metaphysical necessity versus Plantinga's chosen restraint - the highest-value line in the answer.
- **Technical terms:** primordial and consequent natures, persuasive power, fellow-sufferer, surrelativism.
- **Criticism:** the worship objection is stated with its reply and its residue.
- **Conclusion:** the innocence-for-sovereignty trade, named explicitly as a cost.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Frame - revision of omnipotence, not justification of permission
6 min : The six tenets, numbered
3 min : Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin, Cobb - one claim each
2 min : Griffin cannot; Plantinga chooses
2 min : Worship objection, reply and residue
1 min : Verdict - innocence at the price of sovereignty
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "process theodicy (Whitehead)" and stopping: **forfeits the attribution marks the directive is buying.**
- Calling the process God powerless: **misdescribes persuasive power as no power.**
- Confusing Griffin's necessity with self-limitation: **collapses the distinction from the free-will defence.**
- Calling process theodicy a defence: **it claims God's actual situation and is therefore refutable.**
- Omitting the worship objection: **leaves the answer uncritical in a question that expects evaluation.**
- Failing to number the tenets: **"main tenets" is an enumeration directive.**

These six original models extend coverage rather than repeat a direct verified PYQ. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 words, 15 marks about 240 to 260, 20 marks about 340 to 360.**

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish a defence from a theodicy, and explain why the distinction determines what counts as a refutation. **(10 marks, 150 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Distinguish</i> and <i>explain why</i> - a conceptual distinction put to argumentative work
Core issue	Why bare possibility suffices in one case and not in the other
Ideal thesis	The distinction fixes the success condition, and therefore fixes what a refutation must show

Model answer (≈155 words)

A **defence** claims only that God *could* have a morally sufficient reason for permitting evil. Its target is the charge of **logical inconsistency**, and its success condition is therefore bare **logical possibility**. This is why **Plantinga** may assert transworld depravity as *possible* without asserting it as *actual*, and why an objector who shows that it is probably false has not touched the argument: to refute a defence one must show that the proposed story is **impossible**.

A **theodicy** claims to identify God's **actual** reason. **Augustine's** privation account, **Hick's** soul-making and **process theodicy** all make this stronger claim. Their success condition is plausibility and truth, so an objector refutes them by showing the proposed reason is false or insufficient - which is exactly what the animal-suffering and proportionality

objections attempt.

The distinction therefore fixes the burden on both sides. ANALYSIS: It also explains why skeptical theism and a positive theodicy sit awkwardly together: one says the reason is unknowable, the other names it.

Top-answer checklist

- Both terms defined by their **claim-strength**, not by tone.
- Success conditions stated separately for each.
- Plantinga cited for the possibility-only claim.
- At least two named theodicies with their actual-reason claim.
- The closing line about the tension between skeptical theism and positive theodicy.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: "Animal suffering is the point at which the free-will and soul-making theodicies both run out." Examine. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - test the accuracy of the formula and state what survives
Core issue	Why pre-human, pre-moral pain resists the two most-cited theodicies
Ideal thesis	The formula is accurate; only nomic regularity partly survives, and it explains the kind of world rather than the amount of pain

Model answer (≈160 words)

The formula is accurate. Animal pain from predation and disease **predates human moral agency**, so it cannot be the misuse of human free will; and the animal sufferer **does not morally grow**, so it cannot straightforwardly be the environment of soul-making for that sufferer. It cannot be called retributive either. **Rowe's fawn** - severe, apparently unobserved suffering after a natural fire - is the canonical evidential case.

The five replies each carry a cost. The **neo-Cartesian** claim that animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain matter, canvassed by Michael Murray in *Nature Red in Tooth and Claw* (2008), rests on a contested premise. **Extended soul-making** covers only human virtue toward animals and instrumentalises them. **Eschatological** animal fulfilment is undeveloped. A pre-human **fallen order** is CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained. Only **nomic regularity** partly survives.

ANALYSIS: Indian karma extends moral causation to animal births (*tiryak-yoni*) and answers distribution, at the price of an unverifiable mechanism.

Top-answer checklist

- The four-step argument for why the two theodicies fail.
- The fawn identified as **evidential**, not deductive.
- At least three of the five replies, each with its cost.
- Nomic regularity named as the sole partial survivor, with the kind/amount distinction.
- One line of Indian parity with its verification cost.

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Does skeptical theism answer the evidential argument from evil, and at what cost? Discuss. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Does... and at what cost? Discuss</i> - a two-part demand: effectiveness, then price
Core issue	Whether blocking the inference is a genuine answer or a purchased stalemate
Ideal thesis	It answers the inference successfully and pays for it with a general loss of moral confidence

Model answer (≈255 words)

Skeptical theism does not supply a theodicy. It attacks the **inference** in the evidential argument: from "I can see no justifying reason for this evil" to "there is no justifying reason". Its proponents are **Wykstra**, **Alston**, **Bergmann** and **Howard-Snyder**.

The mechanism is **Wykstra's CORNEA** (1984), the Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access: one may claim that it *appears* that p is absent only if it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p **would likely be discernible** if it were there. **Bergmann** adds that our sample of possible goods, possible evils and the entailment relations between them is **not representative** of the total space. Therefore the *noseeum* inference is unwarranted for goods that would justify divine permission. **Alston's** analogy is a novice examining a grandmaster's move and seeing no point in it; **Wykstra's** is an infant who cannot see why a painful procedure is performed.

ANALYSIS: The cost is threefold. The **moral-scepticism objection** (Almeida, Russell, Wielenberg) presses that if we cannot judge an evil gratuitous, we equally cannot judge that we ought to *prevent* it - which threatens the duty to rescue; the reply that obligation is fixed by what we know is found unstable. The **parity objection** presses that the same scepticism undercuts confidence in divine promises; restricting it to value-entailments looks *ad hoc*. The **bracketing objection** presses that, extended, no evidence could ever count against theism.

Verdict: it is the strongest defensive reply available and the most corrosive one, since it neutralises the atheist's inference only by conceding that the moral structure of the universe is opaque to us.

Top-answer checklist

- CORNEA stated in full, not paraphrased as "mystery".
- Bergmann's representativeness theses named alongside it.
- Both canonical analogies present.
- All three objections, each with its reply or residue.
- The verdict phrased as strongest-and-most-corrosive, with the concession named.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: "Karma answers the distribution question that Western theodicy cannot, but at a price." Critically examine. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> - accept what is true, then state the price precisely
Core issue	Whether trans-life moral causation is an explanatory gain or an unverifiable stipulation
Ideal thesis	The distributional gain is real and school-specific; the price is verification and the risk of victim-blaming

Model answer (≈255 words)

The claim is accurate on both sides. Western theodicy answers **why evil exists** - through freedom, privation or soul-making - but has no standard answer to **why this person**. **Karma-samsāra** answers exactly that: suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives, and the moral law is **self-operating**, so rebirth widens the temporal field of justice.

ANALYSIS: Karma is not one doctrine. **Mīmāṃsā**, **Buddhist** and **Jain** accounts require no divine distributor at all; **Nyāya** and theistic **Vedānta** assign God a just administrative role as **karma-superintendent (karmādhyakṣa)** - a judge, not an arbitrary cause of evil. The series is treated as **beginningless**, which blocks the demand for a first

wrongful act.

The price has four parts. First, beginninglessness is a doctrinal stipulation and **verifies nothing** about any claimed past-life cause. Second, the inference from "this person suffers" to "this person deserves it for a specific past act" is **unavailable to ordinary observers**, and using karma that way converts explanation into **victim-blaming**. Third, natural suffering, collective harms and unequal starting conditions still press the fairness of the mechanism. Fourth, karma answers **distribution**, not **personal worth**: it does not show that a sufferer's life is a great good *to them*, which is **Adams'** demand.

FACT: The standing control must be stated: whatever its metaphysics, karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief; causal explanation is not moral permission to withhold aid.

Verdict: the distributional gain is genuine and is India's structural advantage, but it is purchased with an unverifiable trans-life mechanism and a real moral hazard that the answer must name.

Top-answer checklist

- The distributional gain stated against the Western gap.
- Theistic and non-theistic karma schools separated, with *karmādhyaṣa* named.
- Beginninglessness used precisely - blocks a regress, verifies nothing.
- The victim-blaming control stated explicitly.
- Adams' distinction between distribution and personal worth invoked in the closing evaluation.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: "A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it." Critically discuss with reference to at least three theodicies. (20 marks, 350 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss with reference to at least three</i> - an evaluative principle applied to named positions
Core issue	Whether cost-accounting is the right method for grading replies to evil
Ideal thesis	The principle is correct and it is the examiner's own grading method, but it has a limit where a cost destroys the position's purpose

Model answer (≈355 words)

The principle is sound and it is how this clause should be graded. Every reply to evil buys relief by surrendering something; the philosophical task is to state the purchase, not to pretend it was free.

Free-will defence. Plantinga shows that significant freedom entails genuine alternatives and that God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose rightly, so moral evil is compatible with omnipotence and perfect goodness. Its **cost** is threefold: it presupposes **libertarian freedom**, which a compatibilist denies; it is silent about **natural evil**; and, being a defence, it establishes only **possibility**. None of these refutes it, because its target was the logical charge alone. Measured against that target, it succeeds.

Soul-making. Hick creates humans immature, at an **epistemic distance**, in a law-governed world where courage requires danger and compassion requires another's need. Its **coverage** is wider - it reaches natural evil as the environment of growth. Its **cost** is proportionality: much suffering builds nothing, animals do not morally grow, and the reply is a **universal eschatological fulfilment** that depends on contested afterlife commitments. Measured against the evidential burden it partly succeeds and partly fails, and the grade should say so.

Process theodicy. Whitehead's dipolar God supplies each occasion its **initial aim**; Hartshorne argues classical omnipotence is incoherent; Griffin makes persuasion a **metaphysical necessity** rather than a choice. Its coverage is the widest of the three - moral evil, natural evil and animal suffering all follow from finite self-determination. Its **cost** is the largest: classical **sovereignty**, and any guarantee of final victory over evil, which raises the worship objection.

ANALYSIS: The principle has a limit. A cost can be so severe that it destroys the position's **purpose**: if a reply saves God's goodness by removing the God whose goodness was in question, it has changed the subject rather than answered it. **Advaita's** two-level relocation and non-creator systems face exactly this charge, and answering it

requires showing that the religious life the position sustains is still recognisably the one in dispute.

Verdict: cost is a measure, not a refutation - but a theodicy whose cost includes its own point is not measured, it is superseded. Grading therefore requires both the price list *and* a judgement on whether the purchase was worth making.

Top-answer checklist

- Three theodicies, each with coverage and cost stated separately.
- Plantinga's three costs named, including libertarian freedom.
- Hick's eschatological dependence identified as a cost, not a bonus.
- Griffin's metaphysical necessity distinguished from chosen restraint.
- The stated **limit** of the principle, which converts agreement into critical discussion.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: Assess whether the horrendous-evils challenge shows that no general theodicy can succeed. **(20 marks, 350 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Assess <i>whether</i> - a determinate verdict on a strong claim, with the strongest case on both sides
Core issue	Whether a person-level requirement is satisfiable by any world-level account
Ideal thesis	The challenge defeats general theodicy as <i>global accountancy</i> but leaves a religion-specific personal answer standing

Model answer (≈355 words)

Marilyn McCord Adams (*Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God*, 1999) defines a **horrendous evil** as one whose participation - as perpetrator or victim - gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt whether their life could be **a great good to them on the whole**. The definition is technical, and using it loosely for "very bad evil" destroys the argument.

The case for the strong claim is powerful. Standard theodicies operate **globally**: they seek a reason why God permits evil in general, balancing it within the world's total value. But a global balance can be struck while a particular person's life remains, for them, a net disaster. **Chisholm's** distinction is decisive: **balancing off** outweighs the evil within a sum and leaves it external to the good, whereas **defeat** integrates the evil into a whole whose value it contributes to. A God who is good **to persons** - not merely a good producer of worlds - must defeat the evil **within the frame of the individual's life**. ANALYSIS: Compensation is not defeat: a later good can compensate for loss while leaving the evil merely balanced.

The case against the strong claim is that Adams herself supplies an answer. She argues that resources internal to a particular religion - divine identification with human suffering, and **beatific intimacy with God as an incommensurable good** - can accomplish personal-level defeat. Two objections follow, each with her reply. That the answer is **purely eschatological and unverifiable**, and seems to make the evil instrumentally necessary: Adams denies instrumentality, since the evil need not be *required*, only *defeated*. That it **abandons the neutral arena** by using Christian-specific resources: the atheological argument targets a *particular* theism, so a particular theism may answer.

Indian parity sharpens the verdict. Karma explains the **distribution** of horrendous suffering but not personal worth. **Advaita's** ultimate-level sublation and **Buddhist** liberation both address the predicament by dissolving the standpoint from which the life is evaluated - critics call this evasive, defenders therapeutic. The contrast is exact: **defeat within the life** versus **exit from the life-series**.

Verdict: the challenge defeats general theodicy understood as world-level accountancy, and it defeats any reply that offers compensation in place of integration. It does not show that *no* answer is possible; it shows that any successful answer must be **person-relative** - which is why the residual question is whether such an answer is a theodicy at all, or an admission that no general one succeeds.

Top-answer checklist

- Adams' definition used in its technical sense, with perpetrators included.
- Balancing off versus defeat, with Chisholm named.
- Goodness-to-persons contrasted with goodness as world-production.
- Both objections with Adams' replies.
- Indian parity used for the defeat-versus-exit contrast, and a genuinely graded verdict.

High-score answer protocol for the problem of evil

1. Name the version before anything else

Write, in the first two lines, which problem you are answering: logical, evidential, existential, horrendous, animal or distributional. Theodicies are version-specific, and a mismatched theodicy scores as an error rather than as content.

2. Write the set with its bridges

Never assert that omnipotence, goodness and evil are contradictory. Write the four-proposition profile, then the goodness bridge and the power bridge. Every subsequent move in the answer attaches to one of the two bridges.

3. Reconstruct, do not summarise

Each reply is a chain of premises. Plantinga's has four steps; Augustine's has four; process theodicy has six tenets. Numbering them converts recall into argument and gives the objection something determinate to attack.

4. Attach the cost to the reply, immediately

Never leave a theodicy on the page without its price: free will costs libertarian assumptions and natural evil; privation costs innocence and animals; soul-making costs proportionality and an afterlife premise; process costs sovereignty; karma costs verification.

5. Use one Indian comparator deliberately

Choose it for the work it does. Karma for **distribution**. Advaita for **levels**. Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā for **removing the defendant**. *Adṛṣṭa* as *atīndriya* and karmic ripening among the *acinteyya* for **epistemic parity with skeptical theism**. A comparator with no argumentative job is decoration.

6. Keep the four negative categories apart

Evil is moral or natural harm; the profane is the ordinary; the impure is the ritually polluting; the demonic is the actively anti-sacred. This single discipline protects the whole 2019 module and prevents the most common error on it.

7. Observe quotation discipline

The four-horn dilemma reaches us through **Lactantius**, *De Ira Dei* 13, and is traditionally ascribed to Epicurus; "vale of Soul-making" is **Keats**; "defeat" is **Chisholm's** term; "fellow-sufferer who understands" is **Whitehead's**; CORNEA is **Wykstra's**.

8. Marks-wise architecture

10 marks: version, set, one reply with its presupposition, one objection, a compatibility verdict. 15 marks: add the canonical example, the reply, and one Indian comparator. 20 marks: add a second objection with its reply, the defence/theodicy distinction, and the residue paragraph before a criterion-named conclusion.

9. Never end devotionally

A graded verdict answers the directive and follows from the body. "God's purposes are ultimately good" is not a verdict; "the theodicy answers the version it was designed for, at the cost of X, and leaves Y untouched" is.

10. Final twenty-second audit

Version named? Bridges written? Reply reconstructed as premises? Cost attached? Comparator doing work? Residue stated? Verdict graded? If any answer is no, the marks are still on the table.

Final rapid revision matrix

Position / doctrine	Thinker / school	Version answered	Coverage	Central cost	Likely question form
Logical problem	Mackie, <i>Mind</i> 1955	- (the charge itself)	All evil	Needs two bridging premises	What is the logical problem of evil?
Paradox of omnipotence	Mackie 1955	Logical	Divine power	Forces a restriction on omnipotence	Discuss the paradox in the context of evil
Free-will defence	Plantinga, <i>God, Freedom, and Evil</i> 1974	Logical	Moral evil	Libertarian assumptions; natural evil left over	Absolute creator and human responsibility
Transworld depravity	Plantinga 1974	Logical	Blocks only-good free agents	Possibility only, never actuality	Component of the above
Privation	Augustine, <i>Enchiridion, City of God</i>	Logical and metaphysical	Moral evil; natural via a fallen order	Strained for intense pain; innocence; CAUTION: fallen order	All evil is sin or punishment for sin
Sin-and-punishment thesis	Augustine	Logical	Moral evil	Retributive framing of natural evil	2023-type quotation stem
Soul-making	Hick, <i>Evil and the God of Love</i> 1966	Logical and partly evidential	Moral and natural evil	Proportionality; animals; eschatology	Critical comparison with Augustine
Epistemic distance	Hick 1966	Component	Freedom of response	Religious ambiguity	Component of soul-making
Evidential argument	Rowe 1979	- (the charge itself)	Amount and kinds	Rests on an inductive step	Gratuitous evil; the fawn
Skeptical theism	Wykstra, Alston, Bergmann, Howard-Snyder	Evidential	Blocks the inference	Moral scepticism; unfalsifiability	Does unseen reason mean no reason?
CORNEA	Wykstra 1984	Evidential	The <i>noseeum</i> step	Access principle must be defended	Component of the above
Horrendous evils	Adams 1999	Existential	Person-level defeat	Eschatological; religion-specific	Can any theodicy answer horrendous evils?
Balancing off vs defeat	Chisholm's term, used by Adams	Existential	The grading instrument	Compensation is not justification	Component of the above
Animal suffering	Rowe's fawn; Murray 2008	Evidential	The standing residue	Only nomic regularity survives	Does animal suffering defeat theodicy?
Greater-good / stable order	Standard theistic line	Evidential	Kind of world	Not the amount or distribution	Natural evil questions
Best possible world	Leibniz, <i>Theodicee</i> 1710	Logical	Global optimum	No unique best world; neglects persons	Comparative evaluation
Eschatological fulfilment	Hick and others	Existential	Finality of loss	Compensation is not defeat	Closing evaluation
Divine mystery	Traditional	Evidential	All	Unfalsifiable without an access principle	Contrast with skeptical theism
Protest / anti-theodicy	Modern	Existential and moral	The ethics of explanation	Settles no logical or evidential point	Closing qualification
Process theodicy	Whitehead 1929; Hartshorne 1948, 1984; Griffin 1976, 1991; Cobb	Logical and evidential	All, including animals	Classical sovereignty; worship objection	Main tenets of process theodicy
Karma-samsāra	Pan-Indian	Distributional	All, including animal births	Verification; victim-blaming	Indian comparison

Position / doctrine	Thinker / school	Version answered	Coverage	Central cost	Likely question form
<i>Karmādhyaṅṣa</i>	Nyāya; theistic Vedānta	Distributional	Just allocation	God becomes an administrator	Indian comparison
Non-theistic karma	Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā	Dissolution	Removes the defendant	Gives up providence	Religion without God overlap
Two-level ontology	Advaita	Dissolution	Empirical-level evil	Risk of minimising suffering	Concept-dependence stem
Sacred and profane	Durkheim 1912	Religion-founding	Structure of religion	An ideal type, not a law	2019 stem
The numinous	Otto 1917	Object-side	Holy as object	Not a social classification	Routed to Religious Experience
Hierophany	Eliade 1957	Religion-founding	Sacred space and time	Archaic ontology unfalsifiable	2019 stem

Last-minute memory spine

VERSIONS : logical (Mackie) | evidential (Rowe) | existential (Adams) | distribution (karma)
 BRIDGES : good eliminates evil as far as it can + omnipotence has no relevant limit
 REPLIES : DEFENCE = could THEODICY = is
 REVISION = change the God-concept DISSOLUTION = remove the defendant
 F-S-P-A-K: Free-will · Soul-making · Process · Augustinian · Karma
 PLANTINGA: significant freedom · no causally determined free rightness ·
 transworld depravity is POSSIBLE, never actual · silent on natural evil
 AUGUSTINE: privatio boni · defective will · Fall · sin/punishment ·
 rot in wood · guilt vs CONDITION · innocence + animals remain
 HICK : image->likeness (Irenaeus) · epistemic distance · law-governed world ·
 "vale of Soul-making" = KEATS 1819 · eschatological universalism
 ROWE : fawn = EVIDENTIAL · inductive step: no reason SEEN -> no reason THERE
 WYKSTRA : CORNEA - would p likely be DISCERNIBLE if it were there?
 Bergmann: our sample of goods/evils/entailments is NOT representative
 COST: moral scepticism · ad hoc restriction · unfalsifiability
 ADAMS : horrendous = doubt that MY life is a great good TO ME on the whole
 balancing off (sum) vs DEFEAT (Chisholm: organic integration)
 compensation IS NOT defeat
 ANIMALS : no free will · no growth · no desert -> only NOMIC REGULARITY survives
 PROCESS : creativity ultimate · dipolar (primordial: INITIAL AIM / consequent) ·
 power distributed · persuasion by METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY (Griffin) ·
 evil = deviation from the lure · "fellow-sufferer" (Whitehead)
 Hartshorne: classical omnipotence INCOHERENT
 INDIA : karma-samsara self-operating · Nyaya karmadhyaksa = JUDGE ·
 Mimamsa/Bauddha/Jaina need NO God · Advaita: vyavaharika/paramarthika ·
 BEGINNINGLESS series blocks regress, verifies NOTHING ·
 never infer desert from observed suffering
 2019 MOD : Durkheim (social sacred/profane, GOD-FREE) · Otto (numinous, object) ·
 Eliade (hierophany, axis mundi, recoverable time)
 predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology
 PROFANE = ORDINARY, NOT EVIL
 QUOTES : dilemma = LACTANTIUS De Ira Dei 13 (ascribed to Epicurus) ·
 vale = KEATS · defeat = CHISHOLM · fellow-sufferer = WHITEHEAD
 VERDICT : name version -> write bridges -> reconstruct -> object/reply ->
 compare -> GRADE by cost and residue

End of the premium solved-PYQ and practice workbook.

Timed-paper compression plan

ANALYSIS: Use this only after the full models above. It converts each solved answer into an examination-length script without discarding the elements that earn marks.

Demand type in this clause	Keep at every length	Cut first, in this order
Version-statement stem (2020 logical problem)	the numbered set including omniscience; both bridges; the three exits; the migration to the evidential form	Mackie's full adequate/fallacious taxonomy, then the privation exit, then the historical framing

Demand type in this clause	Keep at every length	Cut first, in this order
Paradox stem (2021 omnipotence)	both horns with their costs; one dissolving restriction; the explicit link to evil	the second and third restrictions; the Plantinga/Griffin contrast if time is critical
Quoted-thesis examination (2022 absolute creator)	the scope fix; capacity versus act; the retained rejoinder about instantiating the system	the privation reply; the process rejection of the antecedent
Quoted-thesis critical discussion (2023 Augustine)	the four privation premises; the sin/punishment partition; inherited guilt versus condition; one comparator	the fourth objection; the second comparator; the rot-and-blindness illustrations reduced to one
Dependence thesis (2024 concept-dependence)	the classical set with bridges; three varied God-concepts; the price of each	the fourth God-concept; the list of theodicies that try to keep all attributes
Enumeration stem (2025 process theodicy)	the six numbered tenets; one claim each for Whitehead, Hartshorne and Griffin; the worship objection	Cobb; the objective-immortality reply; the comparison with the free-will defence
Functional stem (2019 evil and the profane)	the profane $\neq$ evil correction; the four-step founding sequence; one Indian case	Otto or Eliade, whichever is less developed in your script; the second objection
Residue paragraph (any 20-marker)	animal suffering; amount and distribution; the defence/theodicy distinction	the horrendous-evils layer if and only if the animal layer is already present

ANALYSIS: **Band budgets for this topic.** 10 marks $\approx$ 150 words: version, set, one reply with its presupposition, one objection, a one-line compatibility verdict. 15 marks $\approx$ 240-260 words: add the canonical example, the proponent's reply, and one Indian comparator. 20 marks $\approx$ 340-360 words: add a second objection with its reply, the defence/theodicy distinction, and the residue before a criterion-named conclusion.

ANALYSIS: **What never gets cut:** the two bridging premises; the distinction between a defence and a theodicy; the fact that Plantinga's transworld depravity is a possibility claim; the Keats attribution; the profane/evil distinction; and the closing statement of what the reply costs and what it leaves untouched.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Everything below is enrichment after core learning and practice. Nothing here is required for a competent core answer: skeptical theism and horrendous evils were promoted to Core on 15 August 2026 and are taught in Basic Sessions 9 and 10, and every PYQ in this clause is answerable from the Basic sessions alone.

Advanced-dossier reconciliation

The section dossier marks **skeptical theism** and **horrendous evils** as promoted to core because the owner source now teaches CORNEA, representativeness, balancing-off versus defeat, and goodness-to-persons. Their optional residue is second-order: whether a positive theodicy can be combined consistently with global skepticism, and whether defeat within a sufferer's life is still a general theodicy. Free-will treatment of natural evil and victim-blaming critiques of karma remain high-value comparative refinements, not stand-alone catalogues.

Advanced seminar modules - from competent to examiner-grade

Each module states a thesis, its argument, the strongest objection, the reply, a qualification and a verdict. Deploy **one** refinement in a 15-marker and at most **two** in a 20-marker; none of them is needed to repair a core answer.

ADVANCED MODULE 1/24 - Modal logic without notation overload

[THESIS] The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true together in at least one possible world. The critic alleges that no possible world contains both the classical God and evil; the defender needs only one coherent possibility in which God has a morally sufficient reason to permit evil.

[ARGUMENT] Three modal ideas must be kept separate. First, **logical possibility** means that a description contains no contradiction. Second, **world feasibility** asks whether God can actualize that description given truths about undetermined creaturely choices. Third, **actuality** asks which world and history obtain. Plantinga argues at the first

two levels. He does not infer that the freedom story is the actual divine policy merely because it is possible.

[OBJECTION] The distinction between possible and feasible worlds appears to limit divine power by facts God does not control. If counterfactuals of freedom are independently true, what grounds them, and why cannot an omnipotent creator choose better agents or circumstances?

[REPLY] Libertarian freedom precisely denies that God determines the content of the free choice. The defender can say that creating agents includes accepting truths about how those agents would freely respond. The grounding question remains a serious objection to Molinist and feasible-world accounts, but it is not a proof of contradiction.

[QUALIFICATION] In an UPSC answer, modal vocabulary should clarify rather than display technique. Write: "A logically describable sinless free world may not be strongly actualizable by God if the truth of free creaturely choices is not under divine causal control." Do not use symbols unless they reduce ambiguity.

[VERDICT] Modal analysis is most successful as a negative result: the simple inconsistent-set argument needs more than the bare triad. It leaves open whether the actual world is a reasonable choice for a perfectly good creator.

ADVANCED MODULE 2/24 - The moral premises behind the logical problem

[THESIS] The dispute is not only about divine power. It is also about the content of goodness. The premise "a good being eliminates evil" is too strong unless it includes "when elimination does not sacrifice an equal or greater good, violate another's agency, or permit an equal or worse evil."

[ARGUMENT] Ordinary morality permits painful surgery, dangerous education and enforcement of just law when proportionate and necessary. The theist generalizes: divine permission may be morally justified where a good is logically connected with risk. The critic answers that ordinary permission is constrained by consent, necessity, proportionality, fair distribution and accountability. A parent may allow a difficult examination but not torture a child for character. Therefore "greater good" is not a blank cheque.

[OBJECTION] Applying human moral constraints to God may be anthropomorphic because creatorhood changes the relation between giver of life and creature.

[REPLY] If divine goodness has no recognizable continuity with moral goodness, the theist loses the very premise used to praise and worship God. Analogical predication may allow difference of mode, not reversal of evaluative content.

[QUALIFICATION] This creates a dilemma for extreme skeptical theism. Too much confidence in human moral standards makes evil evidentially forceful; too little makes "God is good" thin and removes the basis for positive theodicy.

[VERDICT] The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the conditions of creator responsibility, not as a mechanical contradiction among three dictionary definitions.

ADVANCED MODULE 3/24 - Freedom: value, range and responsibility

[THESIS] Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable. They must specify the kind of freedom, the range of consequences necessary for responsibility, and the distribution of opportunities for meaningful choice.

[ARGUMENT] Libertarian freedom holds that at least some choices are not determined by prior conditions. Compatibilist freedom identifies acting from one's own reasons without external constraint even if those reasons are causally determined. Plantinga's defence needs a libertarian relation to God: if God determines the choice, creaturely authorship cannot wholly transfer moral responsibility. Yet significant freedom need not entail unlimited power to harm. Human societies rightly restrict weapons and opportunities for catastrophic wrongdoing while preserving agency. The critic therefore asks why God permits consequences far beyond what meaningful choice needs.

[OBJECTION] Continuous divine restriction would make the world a moral nursery, obscure causal responsibility and prevent serious cooperation against evil.

[REPLY] The objection supports some regular consequences, not every scale of consequence. The theist must explain a threshold: which harms are integral to responsible agency and which are apparently excessive?

[QUALIFICATION] Social and structural evil complicates individualistic freedom. Poverty, oppression and institutions are produced through many choices and inherited systems. No single agent may intend the total harm, yet responsibility is distributed. A theodicy centered only on isolated decisions misses this cumulative structure.

[VERDICT] Freedom plausibly explains the possibility of moral fault. It less clearly explains the available magnitude of harm, unequal moral opportunity, structural evil and divine non-restraint.

ADVANCED MODULE 4/24 - Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess

CORE DISTINCTION: A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied.

[THESIS] A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied life, scientific understanding and purposive action. Some contemporary formulations describe creation as having relative autonomy rather than being a theatre of continuous intervention.

[ARGUMENT] Regular tectonics, weather, mutation, immunity and ecological competition have life-enabling and harm-producing aspects. A world in which harmful effects vanished whenever they threatened a person would cease to be cognitively reliable. Agents could not infer causes, coordinate plans or develop technologies. This supports a general permission of natural risk.

[OBJECTION] The critic distinguishes law from initial conditions, regularity from intensity, and ordinary vulnerability from apparently pointless agony. An omniscient designer could allegedly choose different constants, safer organisms, earlier warnings or selective interventions without abolishing order.

[REPLY] Whole-system comparison is difficult: changes that remove one harm may remove goods or produce unknown harms. Complex adaptive systems may require trade-offs that local observers cannot calculate.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] Difficulty of comparison is epistemic modesty, not positive evidence that the actual balance is optimal. It blocks confident atheistic inference only to the extent that access is genuinely poor; it also blocks confident theodicy.

[VERDICT] Creation-autonomy and law-order accounts explain why a serious world cannot be a hedonistic paradise. The question of preventable excess remains the central evidential residue.

ADVANCED MODULE 5/24 - Evolutionary evil and deep time

CORE DISTINCTION: Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy.

[THESIS] Evolutionary history intensifies the problem because pain, predation, parasitism and mass extinction occur over immense pre-human periods. The data weaken any account that treats natural evil chiefly as punishment for human sin.

[ARGUMENT] Evolution through variation, selection and ecological interaction generates adaptive complexity but also waste, failed organisms and sentient suffering. A theist may value a creation capable of bringing forth novelty through lawful processes rather than receiving every form by direct fiat. Such fecundity can be a good. Nevertheless, the process contains beings who cannot understand danger, consent to risk or acquire human-style virtue.

[OBJECTION] Calling evolutionary suffering the price of autonomy treats animals as disposable means. If God values each sentient creature, a species-level good is insufficient.

[REPLY] A defender may extend eschatological or redemptive goodness to non-human creatures, or argue that creaturely value is not exhausted by painless duration. These proposals are philosophically possible but source-dependent and speculative.

[QUALIFICATION] Karmic rebirth across animal forms supplies a different continuity story, but it can moralize animal pain without accessible evidence of desert. Jain concern for graded living beings and radical non-violence provides an ethical response even where metaphysical explanation is disputed.

[VERDICT] Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy. A theory that mentions animals only as instruments for human growth is incomplete.

ADVANCED MODULE 6/24 - Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence

[THESIS] The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic example. It combines apparently gratuitous instances with patterns of biological pain, unequal distribution, divine hiddenness and the failure of proposed reasons to cover all classes.

[ARGUMENT] Rowe asks whether at least one instance of intense suffering lacks a justifying connection. Draper asks a comparative question: is the pattern of pleasure and pain more expected if nature is indifferent than if guided by

perfect benevolence? The two approaches can reinforce each other. Rowe supplies local cases; Draper supplies pattern comparison. Neither requires the claim that evil is logically incompatible with God.

[OBJECTION] Theism is not a single bare hypothesis. It may include freedom, stable law, soul-making, eschatology and independent evidence from religious experience or cosmological arguments. Evaluating one datum in isolation distorts a cumulative worldview.

[REPLY] Auxiliary theodicies must have independent motivation and predictive discipline. A view that adds a new hidden purpose for every counterexample becomes resistant to evidence. Other evidence for God can offset evil, but Topic 02 arguments must be weighed rather than presumed.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not assign invented numerical priors. State only the comparative structure: evidence confirms a hypothesis to the extent that it is more expected on that hypothesis than on its rivals.

[VERDICT] Evidential evil functions as an undercutting and rebutting consideration within a total case. It rarely yields a stand-alone mathematical conclusion, but it can be philosophically weighty.

ADVANCED MODULE 7/24 - Skeptical theism: three boundaries

CORE DISTINCTION: Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

[THESIS] Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

1. **Epistemic boundary:** Human ignorance concerns the full network of divine reasons; it does not imply ignorance of every local good, evil or causal relation.

2. **Moral boundary:** Agents must act on accessible moral reasons. Unknown divine permission never authorizes human infliction or neglect.

3. **Religious boundary:** If the view blocks all inference from worldly goods to providence, it cannot selectively block only negative evidence while retaining every positive sign.

[ARGUMENT] Wykstra's accessibility principle is plausible when the scale difference between human and divine cognition is relevant. Bergmann's representativeness concern likewise warns that sampled goods may not exhaust possible goods. But a complete suspension of inductive judgement would damage ordinary reasoning.

[OBJECTION] The asymmetry between divine and human perspectives may itself justify selective skepticism: evil-permission could involve remote entailments, while some positive religious experiences are direct.

[REPLY] That distinction must be argued case by case. It cannot be assumed merely to protect a favoured conclusion. Moreover, the more opaque divine purposes become, the harder it is to infer that God is trustworthy in the recognizable moral sense.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism is best used as a defeater-defeater against overconfident noseenum reasoning, followed immediately by an affirmation of local moral responsibility.

ADVANCED MODULE 8/24 - Soul-making under the proportionality test

[THESIS] Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all suffering as development irrespective of outcome.

[ARGUMENT] A developmental environment needs danger, resistance, uncertainty and other persons' needs. These conditions enable courage, patience, compassion and practical wisdom. Yet formation requires an agent capable of learning, a challenge within some range of response, and an opportunity for recovery. Horrendous evils can fragment memory, trust and agency. Infant death and much animal pain offer no obvious subject of moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Goods may accrue to communities or other persons, and eschatological life may complete development interrupted here.

[REPLY] Community goods do not automatically justify using one person as material for another. Eschatology can widen the developmental horizon only if the individual sufferer is restored and the evil defeated within that person's good.

[QUALIFICATION] The distinction between first-order evil and second-order good should never be written as "evil is necessary for good." Some second-order virtues need vulnerability, but the same virtue may be elicited by many

degrees of hardship. Necessity and proportionality require separate argument.

[VERDICT] Hick supplies a powerful account of why a world with no adversity might be morally shallow. Adams supplies the needed correction: goodness must finally be goodness to persons.

ADVANCED MODULE 9/24 - Augustine after evolutionary criticism

[THESIS] Augustine's metaphysical privation claim can survive even if the historical-punitive account of natural evil is rejected.

[ARGUMENT] Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living systems, cruelty is disorder of agency, injustice is corruption of social relation. This ontological point does not require that earthquakes began after a first human sin. The historical fall narrative, by contrast, makes empirical and moral claims about original perfection, inherited disorder and punishment.

[OBJECTION] Separating privation from fall may save a fragment while abandoning the theodicy. Even if evil is ontologically parasitic, God creates the subjects and conditions in which privation occurs.

[REPLY] The defender can combine privation with finite creation and free development: a created world is good yet not divine or incapable of defect. This avoids dualism without claiming that every natural evil punishes sin.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] If defect is an inevitable condition of finite being, either God cannot create without evil or chooses a vulnerable order. The classical question returns at the level of creation.

[VERDICT] Use Augustine in layers. Privation is the strongest philosophical layer; defective freedom is strong for moral evil; universal punishment and a historical cosmic fall carry the heaviest burden.

ADVANCED MODULE 10/24 - Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation

[THESIS] Process non-coercion and classical kenotic self-limitation must be distinguished by modality. In a self-limitation view, God possesses unilateral power but refrains for the sake of freedom or relationship. In Griffin-style process thought, such unilateral coercion is not a metaphysical possibility.

[ARGUMENT] The distinction changes responsibility. Voluntary restraint still permits the question, "Why did God not make an exception here?" Necessary non-coercion answers that no exception was available. It therefore gives process thought a cleaner innocence claim but a greater assurance problem. A God who voluntarily risks creation may remain sovereign; a process God participates in a field of distributed creativity.

[OBJECTION] Process thought may redefine divine power until God resembles one influential cause among others.

[REPLY] Hartshornean and process accounts distinguish supreme relational or persuasive power from finite power. God offers the best possibility to every occasion and perfectly receives all value; supremacy need not mean monopoly.

[QUALIFICATION] The answer must state that Whitehead's dipolar terminology, Hartshorne's critique of omnipotence and Griffin's theodicy are related but not interchangeable. Do not attribute every later theological conclusion directly to Whitehead.

[VERDICT] Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but its success depends on whether worship and hope require guaranteed control.

ADVANCED MODULE 11/24 - Karma: desert, causation and social ethics

CORE DISTINCTION: A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior.

[THESIS] Karma can be interpreted as desert, impersonal moral causation, character formation or bondage mechanics. The ethical evaluation changes with the interpretation.

[ARGUMENT] A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior wrongdoing. An impersonal-causation reading treats deeds as producing tendencies without a divine judge. A formative reading emphasizes how action shapes character and future possibility. Jain karmic matter gives a more literal bondage mechanism, while Buddhist dependent continuity denies a permanent owner. Nyaya adds an intelligent allocator; Mimamsa can retain ritual efficacy without creatorhood.

[OBJECTION] Without memory, transparent proportionality or a stable person, retribution seems unfair. Beginninglessness avoids a first-cause regress only by denying a first temporal point; it does not show why the

system is morally good. Socially, observers may infer desert from misfortune and withhold reform.

[REPLY] Memory is not the sole ground of responsibility even within one life, and causal continuity can support concern. More importantly, no school licenses a bystander to know a victim's hidden karmic history. Compassion, dana, ahimsa and assistance are themselves morally required actions.

[VERDICT] Use karma as a comparative model of trans-life moral causation, never as a warrant for explaining a particular victim. Its strongest feature is distribution; its greatest risk is retrospective moralization.

ADVANCED MODULE 12/24 - Advaita and the reality-status objection

[THESIS] Advaita changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate non-duality, but it cannot responsibly answer suffering with the slogan "the world is unreal."

[ARGUMENT] At the empirical level, persons, Isvara, karma, dharma, ignorance and suffering are operative. Knowledge removes the fundamental misidentification of self with finite body-mind and reveals non-dual Brahman. At the ultimate level, no independent evil principle confronts Brahman. The classical creator-versus-evil duality is therefore not final.

[OBJECTION] If empirical suffering is sublated, the view may appear to trivialize victims and make moral action provisional.

[REPLY] Empirical validity is sufficient for duties, compassion, discipline and liberation practice before realization. Sublatability does not mean non-occurrence at its operative level. Dream pain can be real to the dreamer without being ultimate, though this analogy must not be used pastorally to dismiss actual trauma.

[QUALIFICATION] Ramanuja's critique is relevant: if the world and selves are real modes dependent on Brahman, their suffering cannot be assigned merely a lower ontological status. Visistadvaita therefore retains a more direct theistic governance problem alongside karma and grace.

[VERDICT] Advaita dissolves the ultimate metaphysical dualism but leaves an empirical ethical and soteriological problem that must be answered through knowledge, duty and compassion.

ADVANCED MODULE 13/24 - Buddhist and Samkhya diagnoses compared

[THESIS] Buddhism and Samkhya both avoid a creator theodicy but disagree radically about self and the cause of bondage.

[ARGUMENT] Samkhya locates suffering in purusha's apparent identification with prakriti's evolutes. Discriminative knowledge separates consciousness from material-nature activity, culminating in kaivalya. Buddhism denies a permanent purusha and analyses dukkha through dependent origination, impermanence, craving and ignorance. Cessation is not isolation of a substantial witness but ending the conditions that sustain appropriation and suffering.

[OBJECTION] Removing God avoids culpability but may not explain why the beginningless causal order has its painful character. Samkhya must explain the conjunction of radically different principles; Buddhism must explain responsibility and continuity without self.

[REPLY] Both systems present the "why" as a mistaken demand for a first creator-cause and redirect attention to operative conditions and liberation. A causal diagnosis can be sufficient for practice even without a cosmic justification.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a reframing, not a victory by default. Existential pain, compassion and fairness remain, while the logical inconsistent triad disappears.

[VERDICT] Creatorless systems demonstrate that the problem of evil is not coextensive with the problem of suffering. They exchange theodicy for diagnosis and soteriology.

ADVANCED MODULE 14/24 - Protest, lament and moral knowledge

[THESIS] Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of suffering as knowledge-bearing rather than as a defect of faith.

[ARGUMENT] Job's protest resists friends who infer guilt from suffering. Ivan Karamazov refuses to endorse a harmony that uses innocent agony. Camus makes solidarity and revolt an ethical answer without metaphysical reconciliation. These positions differ, but all reject the movement from "a total explanation may exist" to "the sufferer should accept our explanation."

[OBJECTION] Protest without metaphysical resolution may express emotion rather than answer the truth question.

[REPLY] Moral perception is part of the evidence. A theory that can preserve consistency only by erasing the prima facie wrongness of cruelty has changed the meaning of goodness. Protest also generates practical reasons to resist avoidable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Anti-theodicy should not be represented as the claim that no meaning, redemption or religious response is possible. Its central objection is to comprehensive third-person justification and instrumentalization.

[VERDICT] Protest is not a logical refutation of theism, but it is a constraint on what may count as a morally adequate theodicy.

ADVANCED MODULE 15/24 - Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint

[THESIS] The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a hospital bed, disaster site or bereavement. Philosophical competence includes knowing when an explanation is morally mistimed.

[ARGUMENT] A sufferer may need safety, truthful presence, lament and practical assistance before causal or theological interpretation. Offering karma, punishment or soul-making as a diagnosis of a particular person's suffering exceeds available evidence and can add moral injury. Prayer can include protest; trust can coexist with uncertainty; religious communities can embody solidarity without claiming a hidden plan.

[OBJECTION] Refusing explanation may leave religious belief cognitively empty when it is most challenged.

[REPLY] Restraint is not permanent evasion. General philosophical accounts can be assessed in appropriate contexts. The immediate moral duty is not identical with the later intellectual task.

[QUALIFICATION] The same rule protects against secular triumphalism. One should not use a person's trauma as an occasion to score an atheistic conclusion either. Victim-centered reason asks what the evidence supports and what the situation ethically permits.

[VERDICT] The practical implication of the problem of evil is active compassion under epistemic humility. A theory that excuses preventable harm fails regardless of its abstract elegance.

ADVANCED MODULE 16/24 - Full comparative audit grid

A. Classical defences

Test	Freedom	Soul-making	Augustine	Leibniz
Primary burden	Compatibility	Actual purpose	Origin/status	Optimal totality
Moral evil	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Systemic
Natural evil	Weak alone	Law/development	Punitive strain	Systemic
Animal suffering	Weak	Weak	Severe strain	Aggregate risk
Victim focus	Indirect	At risk	Punitive	Aggregate
Afterlife role	Optional	Usually central	Judgement	Harmony
Attribute cost	None formally	Epistemic distance	Fall burden	Best-world claim
Best use	Logical PYQ	Development comparison	2023 PYQ	Modal comparison

B. Process and Indian comparisons

Test	Process	Karma	Buddhism
Primary burden	Revised power	Distribution	Diagnosis
Moral evil	Distributed	Prior agency	Craving/action
Natural evil	Stronger	Trans-life	Conditioned
Animal suffering	Included	Moralization risk	Included as dukkha
Victim focus	Solidarity	Blame risk	Compassion/path

Test	Process	Karma	Buddhism
Afterlife role	Uncertain	Rebirth/liberation	Rebirth/cessation
Attribute cost	Omnipotence revised	Varies	No creator
Best use	2025 PYQ	Indian parity	Reframing

[VERDICT] No theory dominates every axis. The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of evil is covered, what divine attribute is preserved, what moral cost arises and what residue remains.

ADVANCED MODULE 17/24 - Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God?

CORE DISTINCTION: God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[THESIS] Evil first tests a concept of God and only then contributes evidence about whether any being answering to that concept exists. If "God" means an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good creator, apparently preventable suffering bears directly on the concept's instantiation. If God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[ARGUMENT] The conceptual stage asks which attributes generate expectations. Perfect goodness creates an expectation of opposition to evil; knowledge creates awareness; power creates capacity; creatorhood creates responsibility for the framework. The evidential stage compares those expectations with the world. A process God predicts struggle and partial achievement more readily than classical control. Advaita predicts an empirically operative but ultimately sublatale order. Buddhism predicts conditioned suffering without a providential distribution. Each view must be tested against what it actually asserts.

[OBJECTION] This method lets believers escape evidence by revising God whenever a difficulty arises.

[REPLY] Revision is legitimate only if independently motivated and if its religious cost is paid openly. An ad hoc finite God introduced solely to avoid evil has weak explanatory value. Process thought, by contrast, offers a wider metaphysics of power and becoming, though that metaphysics is contestable.

[VERDICT] Evil does not address an empty word. It confirms or disconfirms profiles. The strongest answer therefore moves in the order **concept -> expectation -> evidence -> revision cost**.

ADVANCED MODULE 18/24 - Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering?

[THESIS] Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual quantity and distribution of suffering is required.

[ARGUMENT] Courage needs perceived danger, compassion needs another's need, forgiveness presupposes wrong, and responsibility needs consequential action. These are relation-dependent goods. A world containing them cannot be wholly insulated from harm. Yet virtues differ: creativity, friendship, gratitude and understanding do not require atrocity. Even danger-dependent virtues may require only bounded challenge. The critic can therefore grant soul-making while denying that horrors are necessary.

[OBJECTION] The total network of virtues, histories and free relations may require risks that no local observer can calculate.

[REPLY] This possibility creates humility but not justification. The theist should avoid the universal claim that every evil is necessary and defend only a general risk structure. Adams's defeat condition must handle cases that exceed ordinary formation.

[QUALIFICATION] The question "Could God create virtue directly?" also concerns authenticity. Implanted dispositions may be good qualities, but achieved virtues include a person's authorship and history. That distinction supports development without proving every route to development morally permissible.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains why a frictionless world may lack important goods; proportionality and goodness-to-persons decide whether the explanation reaches actual horrors.

ADVANCED MODULE 19/24 - Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation?

[THESIS] Permission and causation are not identical, but a creator's permission can still carry responsibility where prevention is easy, knowledge complete and the stakes grave.

[ARGUMENT] A human wrongdoer can be the direct efficient cause of moral evil. God, on classical theism, causes the agent and sustaining order but does not determine the free choice. This supports derivative creaturely culpability. Nevertheless, knowingly selecting and sustaining a world creates a responsibility of framework and permission. Moral analysis therefore needs at least three levels: authorship of the act, design of available powers and consequences, and decision whether to intervene.

[OBJECTION] If God intervened whenever misuse became serious, creaturely action would not be real.

[REPLY] Responsibility does not require unlimited consequence. Legal and social systems constrain harm while retaining agency. The theist must identify why divine restraint is more limited than responsible human restraint should be.

[QUALIFICATION] Process thought changes the third level by denying unilateral prevention. Karma systems distribute responsibility across a life-series. Non-creator systems remove framework selection by God but retain causal questions about bondage.

[VERDICT] The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility: human authorship can be real while divine permission remains philosophically assessable.

ADVANCED MODULE 20/24 - Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy?

[THESIS] Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is not automatically a moral warrant for earlier permission.

[ARGUMENT] Hick needs eventual fulfilment because earthly opportunities are radically unequal. Adams needs a good powerful enough to defeat horrors within the participant's life. Augustine's judgement framework seeks cosmic moral order. These uses differ: completion of development, personal redemption and retributive balance are not interchangeable.

[OBJECTION] If eternal good infinitely exceeds finite suffering, the total life is good.

[REPLY] Aggregate outweighing does not settle consent, use and dignity. It would be wrong to harm a person deliberately merely because one later supplies a larger benefit. The theist needs an internal relation between redemption and the suffered evil, or a reason why permission respected the person throughout.

[QUALIFICATION] Eschatology is a substantive religious commitment, not publicly established by the problem of evil itself. It may belong in a cumulative theology, but should be labelled rather than smuggled into a supposedly neutral proof.

[VERDICT] Eschatology is strongest as a theory of defeat and hope, weaker as a retroactive licence. It deepens the response only when it remains victim-centered.

ADVANCED MODULE 21/24 - Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem?

[THESIS] Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God as able and willing to respond, while many urgent petitions appear unanswered. It can also transform the existential response through lament, solidarity and moral mobilization.

[ARGUMENT] If God sometimes prevents harm in response to prayer, selective non-prevention demands an account of distribution. If God never changes outcomes, petition requires reinterpretation. Stable-law defenders may say prayer is not a mechanism for suspending causation; it can align the agent with divine purpose and community action. Protest prayer preserves relationship without pretending to understand permission.

[OBJECTION] Unanswered prayer is merely another instance of limited human perspective.

[REPLY] That answer is available but costly. It makes claims of answered providence harder to interpret and can render petitionary expectations opaque. A consistent view must treat positive and negative cases with the same epistemic standard.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a bounded link to religious experience, reason and faith. The Problem of Evil owner uses prayer only to test lived implications, not to provide a full theory of prayer.

[VERDICT] Prayer does not solve evil. At its best it refuses isolation, voices protest and generates compassionate action without claiming privileged knowledge of hidden reasons.

ADVANCED MODULE 22/24 - Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness

CORE DISTINCTION: Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is.

[THESIS] Hiddenness aggravates suffering when a loving God could provide unmistakable presence, guidance or consolation without removing all freedom.

[ARGUMENT] Hick values epistemic distance because overwhelming awareness might compromise free relationship and development. The critic distinguishes coercive display from adequate availability: a parent can remain non-coercive while being recognizably present to a terrified child. Sincere nonbelief and divine silence during horror therefore add an interpersonal dimension to evidential evil.

[OBJECTION] Religious growth may require trust under ambiguity, and divine presence may occur in forms the sufferer cannot presently recognize.

[REPLY] Again, possibility is not proportionality. Some ambiguity may preserve freedom; extreme absence may destroy the very trust and agency soul-making requires. The distribution of religious awareness becomes relevant.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is itself always evil. Use it as an auxiliary pressure on epistemic-distance explanations.

[VERDICT] Hiddenness shows that the problem concerns not only prevention of pain but the quality of divine relationship under pain.

ADVANCED MODULE 23/24 - Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions?

CORE DISTINCTION: The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a.

[THESIS] Non-theistic traditions cannot be imported as ready-made theodicies, but they can correct theism's tendency to prioritize cosmic justification over diagnosis and practice.

[ARGUMENT] Buddhism starts from dukkha, traces conditions and prescribes a path. Jainism links bondage to disciplined non-violence. Samkhya diagnoses misidentification and seeks discriminative release. These approaches ask what sustains suffering and how agency can respond, without first vindicating a creator. Theistic traditions can likewise make lament, compassion and prevention central even while retaining questions of providence.

[OBJECTION] Borrowing practice while retaining creator belief avoids the distinctive metaphysical challenge.

[REPLY] The challenge remains; learning at the practical level is not a logical solution. It is a test of whether a proposed belief produces responsible action. Comparative philosophy need not erase doctrinal difference to identify shared ethical insight.

[QUALIFICATION] Karma should not be treated as the universal bridge. Buddhist no-self, Jaina jiva, Samkhya purusha and Vedantic selves differ fundamentally.

[VERDICT] The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a permission problem; non-creator systems supply alternative causal and soteriological grammars; each can be evaluated for compassion, responsibility and explanatory cost.

ADVANCED MODULE 24/24 - Essay laboratory - Final position options

[THESIS] A candidate need not claim a total solution. A reasoned final position can take one of four forms, provided its cost is explicit.

1. **Classical preservation:** Free will, stable law, soul-making and eschatological defeat jointly make theism coherent and not unreasonable. Cost: multiple auxiliary commitments and a residue of apparently gratuitous evil.
2. **Epistemically modest preservation:** Plantinga defeats contradiction; skeptical theism blocks overconfident induction; no complete theodicy is claimed. Cost: opacity of goodness and providence.
3. **Non-classical revision:** Process or finite theism reduces culpability through distributed power. Cost: weakened sovereignty and assurance.
4. **Non-theistic reframing:** Buddhism, Jainism or Samkhya removes the creator defendant and

prioritizes diagnosis and liberation. Cost: unresolved questions of causal order, identity or ultimate why.

[ARGUMENT] These are not equal answers to one fixed question. Each changes premises, explanatory burdens and religious practices. The examiner should be shown exactly what has been preserved, revised or abandoned.

[VERDICT] The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not established, evidential evil remains substantial, and moral protest limits every universal theodicy. Philosophical integrity requires continued action against suffering rather than premature closure.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Placement note: These register notes come **after** all teaching and practice, and cover **every one of the sixteen subtopics** taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer and a compressed recall instrument, not a repetition of the teaching introduction above.

FINAL REGISTER 1/16 - Versions, burdens and reply-types

EXAM-READY LINE: There is no single problem of evil: name the version in the first two lines, because theodicies are version-specific.

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	FACT: "Problem of Evil" - two words, so the candidate must impose the structure
Versions	FACT: Logical · evidential · existential/moral · distributional
Burdens	ANALYSIS: Logical -> show a possible morally sufficient reason · Evidential -> restore probability · Existential -> defeat within the life · Distributional -> explain allocation
Reply-types	FACT: Defence (could) · Theodicy (is) · Revision (change the God-concept) · Dissolution (remove the defendant)
Full divine profile	FACT: Omnipotent + omniscient + perfectly good + creator; omniscience blocks the "God did not notice" reply
Standing rule	ANALYSIS: A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it
Ethics control	FACT: Causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid
Mnemonic	MEMORY: F-S-P-A-K - Free-will, Soul-making, Process, Augustinian, Karma

FINAL REGISTER 2/16 - Kinds of evil and the classical dilemma

EXAM-READY LINE: Free will explains what agents do; it does not explain earthquakes, and it explains nothing at all about a fawn burned in a forest fire.

- FACT: **Moral evil:** harm traceable to misused creaturely freedom - cruelty, injustice, betrayal, oppression.
- FACT: **Natural evil:** suffering not caused by any will - earthquake, disease, congenital disorder.
- FACT: **Horrendous evil:** technically defined by the doubt it gives the participant about their own life's worth.
- FACT: **Animal / pre-human evil:** predation and disease before any moral agency existed.
- CAUTION: **The four-horn dilemma** - willing but not able / able but not willing / neither / both - reaches us through **Lactantius**, *De Ira Dei* 13, and is *traditionally* ascribed to **Epicurus**; no surviving Epicurean text contains it.
- ANALYSIS: The dilemma presupposes exactly the bridging premises it does not state.
- ANALYSIS: Three separate complaints hide inside "too much evil": **amount**, **kind** and **distribution**.
- ANALYSIS: Distribution is where Western theodicy is weakest and karma is structurally strongest.
- MEMORY: **M-N-H-A:** Moral, Natural, Horrendous, Animal - sort first, match second.

FINAL REGISTER 3/16 - Mackie's logical problem

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: The set becomes inconsistent only with the bridging premises; deny either and the contradiction dissolves.

- FACT: **Source:** J. L. Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence", *Mind* (1955).
- FACT: **The set:** God is omnipotent · God is perfectly good · evil exists - plus omniscience in the full profile.
- FACT: **Not a formal contradiction:** nothing in the propositions plus logic alone entails a proposition and its negation.
- FACT: **Bridge A (goodness):** a perfectly good being eliminates every evil it can.
- FACT: **Bridge B (power):** an omnipotent being has no relevant limit on preventing evil whose prevention is logically possible.
- FACT: **Mackie's taxonomy:** *adequate solutions* abandon a proposition; *fallacious solutions* only appear to keep all three.
- ANALYSIS: **Exit 1:** insert "unless there is a morally sufficient reason" -> defences and theodicies.
- ANALYSIS: **Exit 2:** deny Bridge B -> Plantinga, or process theism's outright rejection of classical omnipotence.
- ANALYSIS: **Exit 3:** deny the force of "evil exists" -> privation, or Advaita's empirical level. **Cost:** the seriousness of suffering.
- ANALYSIS: **Verdict:** widely regarded as answered; the live debate has **migrated to the evidential form**.

FINAL REGISTER 4/16 - The paradox of omnipotence

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Unrestricted omnipotence in both the first-order and second-order senses is incoherent, so theism must specify which sense it defends.

- FACT: **Source:** the same Mackie article, *Mind* (1955).
- FACT: **First-order power:** power to act on and control existing things.
- FACT: **Second-order power:** power to determine what powers exist at all.
- ANALYSIS: **Horn 1 - cannot make uncontrollable beings:** second-order power limited.
- ANALYSIS: **Horn 2 - can and does:** first-order power over them limited.
- FACT: **Restriction (a):** omnipotence covers the **logically possible** only - near-universally conceded.
- FACT: **Restriction (b):** second-order sovereignty **freely self-bound** in creating free agents. **Cost:** restraint becomes voluntary, re-opening the intervention question.
- FACT: **Restriction (c):** abandonment - process theism. **Cost:** no guarantee of final victory over evil.
- ANALYSIS: **Link to evil (2021 stem):** the free-will defence *requires* a restriction; Plantinga's God **chooses** not to override, Griffin's God **cannot** coerce.
- ANALYSIS: The attribute's independent coherence belongs to *Notions of God*.

FINAL REGISTER 5/16 - Plantinga's free-will defence

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents.

- FACT: **Source:** Alvin Plantinga, *God, Freedom, and Evil* (1974).
- FACT: **Premises:** (1) a world with significantly free creatures is more valuable; (2) significant freedom entails genuine alternatives; (3) God cannot causally determine a creature to *freely* choose rightly - the description cancels itself; (4) so moral evil is compatible with omnipotence and goodness.
- FACT: **Transworld depravity:** a creaturely essence goes wrong in some circumstance in every world where it acts freely. ANALYSIS: Plantinga claims only that this is **possible**, never that it is **actual**.
- FACT: It is a **defence**, not a theodicy - bare logical possibility suffices.
- ANALYSIS: **Presupposition:** libertarian freedom is coherent and sufficiently valuable; a compatibilist rejects premise (3).

- ANALYSIS: **Residue:** natural evil is untouched unless a further hypothesis is added.
- ANALYSIS: **2022 stem replies:** God creates the *capacity*, the agent supplies the *act*; privation; foreknowledge ≠ causation; process denial of the antecedent.
- ANALYSIS: **Retained rejoinder:** knowingly instantiating the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant.

FINAL REGISTER 6/16 - Augustinian privation

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Calling blindness a privation does not call it unreal - it is a real lack in a subject that ought to possess sight.

- FACT: **Sources:** Augustine, *Enchiridion* and *City of God*.
- FACT: **Premises:** being as being is good · God creates beings, not evil substances · corruption is **parasitic** on a good nature · moral fault is **disordered willing**.
- FACT: **Evil = privation of a due good (privatio boni)**, not a rival creative principle.
- FACT: **Canonical example:** rot is not a rival substance to wood but the loss of the wood's proper integrity.
- FACT: **The 2023 thesis:** moral evil = **sin**; natural evil = **punishment** through a fallen order.
- ANALYSIS: **Inherited guilt vs inherited condition:** personal guilt for an ancestor's act is far harder to defend than an inherited **damaged condition**; the second reduces the objection but still owes an account of why the condition and its unequal effects are permitted.
- ANALYSIS: **Objections:** innocent and animal suffering; privation strained for intense positive pain; CAUTION: a pre-human fallen order is historically and scientifically strained.
- ANALYSIS: **Quotation discipline:** treat the printed sentence as the object of analysis, not as a certified verbatim translation.
- ANALYSIS: **Verdict:** preserves divine goodness for moral evil; incomplete for natural and innocent suffering.

FINAL REGISTER 7/16 - Hick's Irenaean soul-making

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Courage requires danger and compassion requires another's need, so a world engineered to prevent all suffering would prevent the goods that make persons.

- FACT: **Source:** John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love* (1966).
- FACT: **Premises:** ready-made virtue is not achieved virtue · the great virtues require real difficulty · a law-governed world must permit harm · humans are created immature at an **epistemic distance**.
- FACT: **Irenaeus** supplies the **image -> likeness** theology; humans grow into likeness.
- FACT: **"The vale of Soul-making" is John Keats's phrase**, journal-letter to George and Georgiana Keats, spring 1819, preferred by him to "a vale of tears". Hick **borrowed** it. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute it to Irenaeus or call it Hick's coinage.
- FACT: **Typology:** Augustinian = backward-looking Fall from perfection; Irenaean = forward-looking growth from immaturity.
- FACT: **Coverage:** moral **and** natural evil - its advantage over the free-will defence.
- ANALYSIS: **Costs:** proportionality; animal suffering; dependence on a universal **eschatological fulfilment**.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap:** do not reduce it to "suffering makes us stronger"; the three components carry the argument.

FINAL REGISTER 8/16 - Rowe's evidential problem

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Rowe's fawn is an evidential case, not a deductive contradiction.

- FACT: **Source:** William Rowe, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism" (1979).
- FACT: **Premise 1:** there exist instances of intense suffering an omnipotent being could have prevented without losing a greater good or permitting an equally bad or worse evil.
- FACT: **Premise 2:** a wholly good being would prevent any intense suffering it could, absent such a reason.
- FACT: **Conclusion:** no omnipotent, omniscient, wholly good being exists.

- FACT: **The fawn**: trapped in a lightning-started fire, severely burned, suffering unobserved for days.
- ANALYSIS: **Why the case was built that way**: it removes free will, moral growth, desert and observer benefit at once.
- ANALYSIS: **The inductive step**: "no justifying reason seen" -> "no justifying reason exists" - the whole battleground.
- ANALYSIS: **Three theist routes**: attack the inference (skeptical theism) · supply a reason (theodicy) · revise the God-concept.
- ANALYSIS: Routes 1 and 2 sit awkwardly together; noticing this earns marks.
- ANALYSIS: Rowe claims **evidential force**, not demonstration, and allows the theist may remain rational.

FINAL REGISTER 9/16 - Skeptical theism

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: One may claim it *appears* that p is absent only if p would likely be discernible, given one's cognitive situation, were it there.

- FACT: **Proponents**: Stephen Wykstra · William Alston · Michael Bergmann · Daniel Howard-Snyder.
- FACT: **CORNEA (1984)**: Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access - the epistemic-access condition on any appearance-of-absence claim.
- FACT: **Bergmann's representativeness theses**: our sample of possible goods, possible evils and the entailment relations between them is **not representative** of the total space.
- FACT: **Target**: the *noseeum* inference - "no see 'um, so none there".
- FACT: **Analogies**: Alston's novice and the chess grandmaster; Wykstra's infant and the painful procedure.
- FACT: It is a **defence**, not a theodicy, and it targets the **evidential**, not the logical, problem.
- ANALYSIS: **Cost 1 - moral scepticism** (Almeida, Russell, Wielenberg): it threatens the judgement that we ought to prevent an evil; the "obligation is fixed by what we know" reply is found unstable.
- ANALYSIS: **Cost 2 - parity**: the same scepticism undercuts divine promises; restricting it to value-entailments looks *ad hoc*.
- ANALYSIS: **Cost 3 - bracketing**: extended, it makes theism unfalsifiable.
- ANALYSIS: **Indian parity**: *adṛṣṭa* as *aśīndriya*, known only through testimony; karmic ripening among the Buddhist *acinteyya*. Same parallel, same objection.

FINAL REGISTER 10/16 - Horrendous evils

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Global balancing is not personal defeat: a world can be good on the whole while a life is not.

- FACT: **Source**: Marilyn McCord Adams, *Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God* (1999).
- FACT: **Definition**: an evil whose participation - as perpetrator **or** victim - gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt whether their life could be a great good **to them on the whole**.
- FACT: **Argument**: standard theodicies are **global**; a global balance can be struck while an individual life is a net disaster; a God good **to persons** must **defeat** the evil within that life; only religion-specific resources - divine identification, beatific intimacy as an **incommensurable good** - can do so.
- FACT: **Balancing off** = the good outweighs the evil in a sum, leaving it external. **Defeat** (Chisholm's term) = the evil becomes an organic part of a whole whose value it contributes to.
- ANALYSIS: **Compensation is not defeat**.
- ANALYSIS: **Objection 1**: purely eschatological, unverifiable, and seemingly instrumentalising. **Reply**: Adams denies instrumentality - the evil need not be *required*, only *defeated*.
- ANALYSIS: **Objection 2**: religion-specific resources abandon neutral ground. **Reply**: the atheological argument targets a *particular* theism.
- ANALYSIS: **Indian parity**: karma answers **distribution**, not personal worth; Advaita's sublation and Buddhist liberation dissolve the evaluating standpoint - critics say evasive, defenders say therapeutic.

- ANALYSIS: **Contrast to name:** defeat *within* the life versus *exit from* the life-series.

FINAL REGISTER 11/16 - Animal and pre-human suffering

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Only nomic regularity survives on the Western side, and it explains the kind of world rather than the amount of pain in it.

- FACT: **Argument:** animal pain predates moral agency · it is not misused human freedom · the animal does not morally grow · it cannot be called retributive · therefore standard theodicies leave a major remainder.
- ANALYSIS: **Neo-Cartesian:** animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain matter - canvassed by **Michael Murray**, *Nature Red in Tooth and Claw* (2008). **Cost:** contested premise.
- ANALYSIS: **Nomic regularity:** a stable law-governed world is needed for any life at all. **Cost:** kind, not amount.
- ANALYSIS: **Extended soul-making:** danger makes stewardship toward animals possible. **Cost:** instrumentalises them.
- ANALYSIS: **Eschatological:** animal fulfilment in a final state. **Cost:** unverifiable and undeveloped.
- ANALYSIS: **Fallen order:** CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained.
- FACT: **Indian parity:** karma in **animal births (tiryak-yoni)**; Jain graded living selves grounding **non-injury (ahimsā)**; Buddhist **suffering (duḥkha)** and **compassion (karuṇā)** extended to sentient beings.
- ANALYSIS: **Objection:** an animal cannot learn from a fruit it cannot understand. **Reply:** karmic maturation is **causal, not pedagogical**; the compassion it demands is unaffected.
- ANALYSIS: Do not answer this with the free-will defence; saying so explicitly earns marks.

FINAL REGISTER 12/16 - Process theodicy and the non-classical reply-space

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: It purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty - state the trade.

- FACT: **Six tenets:** (1) creativity, not God, is ultimate · (2) God is **dipolar** - primordial nature supplying the **initial aim**, consequent nature receiving what the world becomes · (3) power is **intrinsically distributed** · (4) divine power is **persuasive by metaphysical necessity** (Griffin) · (5) evil is deviation from the divine lure · (6) God is "the **fellow-sufferer who understands**" (Whitehead).
- FACT: **Whitehead**, *Process and Reality* (1929) - dipolarity, initial aim, consequent nature, the fellow-sufferer.
- FACT: **Hartshorne**, *The Divine Relativity* (1948), *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984) - classical omnipotence is **incoherent**; surrelativism/panentheism makes God supremely **related**, not supremely unaffected.
- FACT: **Griffin**, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976), *Evil Revisited* (1991) - persuasion is a **metaphysical necessity, not a self-limitation**.
- FACT: **Cobb**, *A Christian Natural Theology* - the theological systematisation.
- FACT: It is a **theodicy**, not a defence: it claims God's actual situation.
- ANALYSIS: **Criticism:** a God who cannot guarantee victory may be unworthy of worship; the metaphysics is contested. **Reply:** solidarity plus the **objective immortality** of achieved value.
- ANALYSIS: **Reply-space:** greater-good/stable order (kind not amount) · Leibnizian best world (no unique best; neglects persons) · eschatological fulfilment (compensation ≠ justification) · divine mystery (unfalsifiable without an access principle) · protest/anti-theodicy (diagnoses ethics, settles no argument).

FINAL REGISTER 13/16 - The Indian response

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Karma is not one doctrine across the Indian schools: Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and Jain accounts need no creator; Nyāya and theistic Vedānta assign God a just administrative role.

- FACT: **Karma-saṃsāra:** suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives; the moral law is **self-operating**, so evil raises no problem for a creator's goodness.
- FACT: **Structural advantage:** it answers **distribution** - why *this* person - which Western theodicy answers weakly.
- FACT: **Nyāya / Rāmānuja:** God dispenses karmic fruit justly as **karma-superintendent (karmādhyakṣa)** - a judge, not an arbitrary cause of evil.

- FACT: **Advaita**: evil is real at the **empirical level (vyāvahārika)** and sublated under liberating knowledge at the **ultimate level (pāramārthika)**; Brahman is untouched. ANALYSIS: Cost: risk of minimising suffering.
- FACT: **Beginninglessness**: the action-consequence series needs no first wrongful act. ANALYSIS: It blocks a regress question but **verifies nothing**.
- ANALYSIS: **Victim-blaming control**: the inference from "this person suffers" to "this person deserves it for a specific past act" is **unavailable to ordinary observers**.
- ANALYSIS: **Residual pressure**: natural suffering, collective harms and unequal starting conditions still press fairness and verification.
- FACT: **Duty of compassion**: karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief.
- ANALYSIS: **Origination vocabulary**: ignorance (*avidyā*) · inflow (*āsrava*) · craving (*taṇhā*) - India asks about the **origination of bondage**, the West about **permission**.

FINAL REGISTER 14/16 - Evil and the profane as religion-forming categories

EXAM-READY LINE: FACT: Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally - and they found religion, not theism.

- FACT: **Durkheim**, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912): all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, **profane** and **sacred**; religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, uniting adherents into a moral community, a **church**. Deliberately **God-free**.
- FACT: **Otto**, *The Idea of the Holy* (1917): the **numinous**, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - the **object-side**.
- FACT: **Eliade**, *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957): **hierophany**; sacred **space** around an *axis mundi*; recoverable sacred **time**.
- ANALYSIS: **Founding sequence**: predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology.
- FACT: **Indian parity**: Buddhist **First Noble Truth** (the clearest world case) · Jain *āsrava/bandha* with *saṃvara/nirjarā* · Advaita's *avidyā* · *śuddhi/aśuddhi* and *śauca* · *maṅgala/amaṅgala* · *pāpa/puṇya* · Mīmāṃsā ritual purity.
- ANALYSIS: **Rider**: India's founding defect is more often **ignorance or bondage** than **moral evil** - diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness.
- FACT: **Four distinct categories**: evil (harm) ≠ profane (the ordinary) ≠ impure (ritually polluting) ≠ demonic (actively anti-sacred).
- ANALYSIS: **Objections**: the binary is a Durkheimian imposition and Eliade's archaic ontology is unfalsifiable -> treat as an **ideal type**; and religion also grows from wonder and gratitude.
- FACT: **Ownership**: this file owns the evil/profane pole; the sacred/holy-as-object pole belongs to *Religious Experience*.

FINAL REGISTER 15/16 - Concept-dependence and the comparative grid

EXAM-READY LINE: ANALYSIS: The problem is a stress-test of a *particular* God-concept, not of religion as such.

God-concept	Effect on the problem	Religiously significant loss
Classical theism	Full force; all three burdens live	None yet - the theodicies must do the work
Finite / process God	Dissolved at the logical level	Sovereignty; any guarantee of final victory
Impersonal Absolute (Advaita)	Relocated to the empirical level	A personal God to address; risk of minimising suffering
No creator (Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā)	Removed - no defendant	Providence, divine rescue, a cosmic guarantor of justice

Theodicy	Evil explained	Attribute preserved	Weakness
Free-will	Moral	Omnipotence + goodness	Natural evil left over
Augustinian privation	Moral, via the Fall	All attributes	Privation strained; innocence and animals

Theodicy	Evil explained	Attribute preserved	Weakness
Soul-making	Moral + natural	Purposive goodness	Scale; animals; universalist eschatology
Process	All	Goodness, not omnipotence	Sacrifices classical omnipotence
Karma	All, including distribution	Cosmic justice; no creator-blame	Victim-blaming; verification; regress
Advaita	Empirical-level evil	Brahman untouched	Risk of minimising suffering
Skeptical theism	None - a defence	All attributes	Moral scepticism; unfalsifiability

- ANALYSIS: **Four standing criticisms:** excess evil · natural evil · divine responsibility · karma and compassion - each with a reply *and* a rejoinder.
- ANALYSIS: Concept-dependence is **not a solution**; it relocates the cost from the argument into the theology.

FINAL REGISTER 16/16 - Answer architecture and quotation discipline

EXAM-READY LINE: ANALYSIS: A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it - name the cost, then grade the reply against the version it was built for.

- ANALYSIS: **Universal spine:** name the version -> write the set with its bridges -> reconstruct the reply as premises -> object and reply -> one deliberate comparator -> grade by cost and residue.
- ANALYSIS: **10 marks:** exact problem -> God-concept -> one response with its presupposition -> one objection -> compatibility verdict. ≈150 words.
- ANALYSIS: **15 marks:** logical/evidential frame -> the doctrine's argument -> canonical example -> objection and reply -> Indian comparator -> explanatory cost. ≈240-260 words.
- ANALYSIS: **20 marks:** define evil and state the set -> strongest theodicy in full -> rival theodicy or Indian view -> two objections with replies -> defence versus theodicy -> graded verdict. ≈340-360 words.
- ANALYSIS: **Verdict ladder:** ≈40% asserts the triad · ≈50% distinguishes logical from evidential · ≈60% states the bridges and one full theodicy · ≈65-70% version-matched with costs · ≈70%+ adds defeat-versus-balancing-off, CORNEA or the animal gap **and** says what the theist has given up.
- FACT: **Quotation discipline:** dilemma -> **Lactantius**, *De Ira Dei* 13 (traditionally Epicurus) · vale of Soul-making -> **Keats** 1819 · defeat -> **Chisholm** · fellow-sufferer -> **Whitehead** · CORNEA -> **Wykstra** 1984 · transworld depravity -> **Plantinga** 1974, possibility only · sacred/profane -> **Durkheim** 1912 · hierophany -> **Eliade** 1957 · numinous -> **Otto** 1917.
- ANALYSIS: **Safe formulations:** "The problem's force varies with the God-concept." · "A successful defence defeats contradiction; it need not make suffering morally transparent." · "Global balancing is not personal defeat." · "Evil and the profane found religion structurally, not doctrinally."
- ANALYSIS: **Never end devotionally.** A graded verdict answers the directive and follows from the body.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

The same diagram is installed as a standalone artifact beside the graphical flowchart package. It is the terminal-friendly, data-complete representation; the designed poster and tiled PDF are its graphical counterpart.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/22: The control question and the four versions

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/22: The control question and the four versions

PHILOSOPHY PAPER II – PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION 03

PROBLEM OF EVIL

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM – 22 PANELS

Syllabus, verbatim: "Problem of Evil."

Read top to bottom. Each panel is data-complete: premises, named critics, replies and verdict.

EVIL EXISTS. SO WHAT EXACTLY FOLLOWS?			
LOGICAL	EVIDENTIAL	EXISTENTIAL	DISTRIBUTIONAL
Mackie 1955	Rowe 1979	Adams 1999	karma traditions
"the set is inconsistent"	"gratuitous evil makes God improbable"	"is THIS life a great good TO THIS PERSON?"	"why THIS person rather than that one?"
BURDEN: show a POSSIBLE morally sufficient reason	BURDEN: restore PROBABILITY	BURDEN: DEFEAT within the individual life	BURDEN: explain ALLOCATION
REPLY-TYPE: DEFENCE	REPLY-TYPE: THEODICY or SKEPTICAL THEISM	REPLY-TYPE: goodness TO PERSONS	REPLY-TYPE: karma; the West has no standard one

MISMATCH = ERROR. Answering Mackie with Plantinga is correct.

Answering Rowe with Plantinga is a version error and loses marks.

FULL DIVINE PROFILE UNDER TEST: omnipotent + omniscient + perfectly good + creator.

Omniscience is not in Mackie's three propositions but blocks "God did not notice".

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/22: Defence, theodicy, revision, dissolution

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/22: Defence, theodicy, revision, dissolution

FOUR THINGS A REPLY TO EVIL CAN BE – DO NOT MERGE THEM

DEFENCE	THEODICY	REVISION	DISSOLUTION
God COULD have a morally sufficient reason Plantinga; Wykstra	This IS God's actual reason Augustine, Hick, Leibniz, process theodicy	change the God-concept so the charge lapses	remove the defendant altogether
success = bare LOGICAL POSSIBILITY; refuted only by showing the story is impossible	success = plausibility + truth; refuted if the reason is false or insufficient	process/finite God: goodness kept, omnipotence surrendered	Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa, karma without a creator

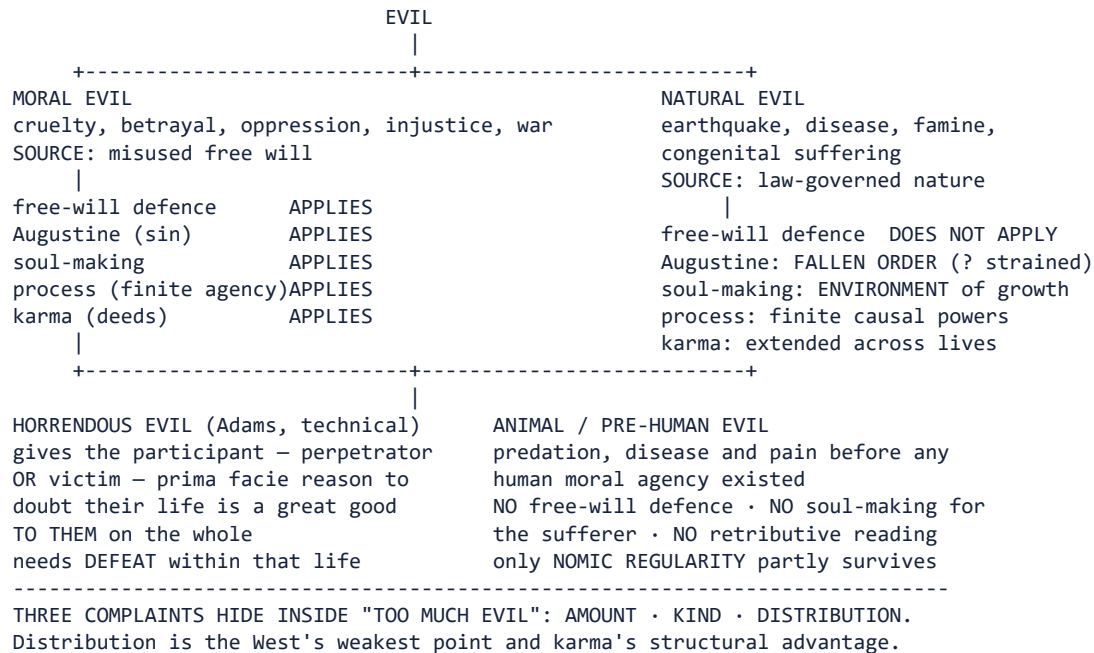
STANDING RULE: a theodicy is NOT REFUTED by its cost – it is MEASURED by it.

ETHICS CONTROL: causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid.

Pastoral care and philosophical argument answer different questions; do not fuse them.

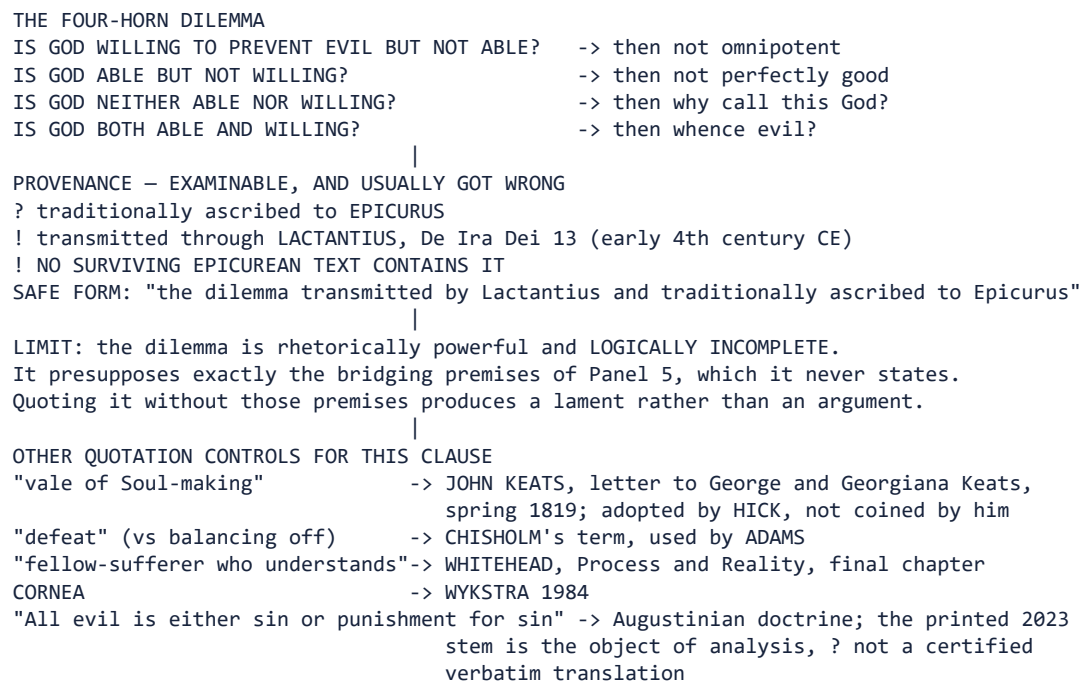
ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/22: Kinds of evil and the scope of every reply

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/22: Kinds of evil and the scope of every reply



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/22: The classical dilemma and its true provenance

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/22: The classical dilemma and its true provenance



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/22: Mackie's logical problem and the two bridges

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/22: Mackie's logical problem and the two bridges

J. L. MACKIE, "Evil and Omnipotence", MIND (1955)

THE SET AS USUALLY PRINTED

- (1) God is omnipotent
- (2) God is perfectly good
- (3) Evil exists

-> NOT a formal contradiction:
nothing in (1)-(3) plus logic
alone entails p and not-p

THE SET AS IT MUST BE WRITTEN

- (1) God is omnipotent
- (2) God is omniscient
- (3) God is perfectly good
- (4) Evil exists

+ BRIDGE A (goodness): a perfectly good being
eliminates every evil it can, unless it has
a morally sufficient reason
+ BRIDGE B (power): an omnipotent being has no
relevant limit on preventing any evil whose
prevention is logically possible
-> NOW the set is inconsistent

MACKIE'S OWN TAXONOMY

ADEQUATE SOLUTIONS honestly abandon one of the propositions

FALLACIOUS SOLUTIONS appear to keep all three while covertly limiting power or
redefining goodness – e.g. "good cannot exist without evil",
"evil is a necessary means to good", "the universe is better
with some evil", "evil is due to human free will"

THE THEIST'S THREE EXITS – EACH DENIES SOMETHING

deny BRIDGE A -> insert "unless there is a morally sufficient reason"
-> the entire space of DEFENCES and THEODICIES opens

deny BRIDGE B -> Plantinga (God cannot causally determine free rightness) or
process theism (classical omnipotence rejected outright)

deny (4)'s force -> privation (Augustine) or the empirical level (Advaita)
COST: the seriousness of suffering

VERDICT: the logical problem is widely regarded as ANSWERED. The live debate has
MIGRATED to Rowe's evidential form, where consistency no longer suffices.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/22: The paradox of omnipotence (2021 Q5(e), 10 marks)

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/22: The paradox of omnipotence (2021 Q5(e), 10 marks)

CAN AN OMNIPOTENT BEING CREATE A THING IT CANNOT AFTERWARDS CONTROL?

+-----+-----+	
YES	NO
there is now something it CANNOT do: control that thing -> FIRST-ORDER power limited (power to act on existing things)	there is something it CANNOT do: make such a thing -> SECOND-ORDER power limited (power to determine what powers exist)

MACKIE: unrestricted omnipotence in BOTH senses is incoherent.

THREE RESTRICTIONS THAT DISSOLVE IT, WITH THEIR COSTS

- (a) LOGICAL-POSSIBILITY omnipotence covers only the logically possible
COST: modest, near-universally conceded; but it does not
settle whether "free agents who never go wrong" is
actualizable by God
- (b) SELF-BINDING second-order sovereignty exercised IN creating free agents
COST: restraint becomes VOLUNTARY, re-opening the question
why God does not intervene in the worst cases
- (c) ABANDONMENT process theism drops classical omnipotence
COST: no guarantee of any final victory over evil

LINK TO EVIL – THE STEM'S CONTEXT CLAUSE IS MANDATORY

the FREE-WILL DEFENCE REQUIRES (a) or (b): God creates significantly free agents and
cannot causally guarantee that they choose well.

PLANTINGA: God CHOOSES not to override. GRIFFIN: God CANNOT coerce.

VERDICT: the paradox does not refute theism; it forces theism to SPECIFY which sense
of omnipotence it defends, and to pay for the choice.

BOUNDARY: the attribute's independent coherence belongs to Notions of God.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/22: Plantinga's free-will defence and transworld depravity

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/22: Plantinga's free-will defence and transworld depravity

ALVIN PLANTINGA, God, Freedom, and Evil (1974) – A DEFENCE, NOT A THEODICY

- (1) A world with significantly free creatures is more valuable, other things equal, than a world with no free creatures at all.
- (2) Significant freedom entails genuinely available alternatives: an agent free with respect to an action can perform it or refrain.
- (3) God cannot CAUSALLY DETERMINE a creature to FREELY do only what is right – that description cancels itself.
- (4) Therefore God can create free persons only by accepting the POSSIBILITY of misuse.
- (5) Therefore moral evil is COMPATIBLE with omnipotence and perfect goodness.

MACKIE'S OBJECTION: why not create free agents who ALWAYS freely choose the good? That is logically possible, so omnipotence covers it.

REPLY – TRANSWORLD DEPRAVITY: it is POSSIBLE that every creaturely essence God could instantiate would go wrong in some circumstance. If so, a world of free agents who never go wrong was not available to God to actualize.

MODAL STATUS: POSSIBILITY ONLY. Plantinga never claims it is ACTUAL, and does not need to. -> attacking it as "empirically unsupported" misses the modal point entirely.

PRESUPPOSITION: libertarian freedom is coherent and sufficiently valuable.

A compatibilist denies premise (3) and rejects the defence at its root.

RESIDUE: NATURAL EVIL is untouched unless a further hypothesis is added.

ANSWER LINE: a world of programmed beneficence lacks the MORAL AUTHORSHIP of a world containing genuinely responsible agents.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/22: Absolute creation and responsibility (2022 Q6(c), 15 marks)

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/22: Absolute creation and responsibility (2022 Q6(c), 15 marks)

THE STEM: "If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine."

SCOPE FIX FIRST: the stem concerns MORAL evil and human agency. Natural evil is the residue, not the subject.

THE STEM'S ARGUMENT

God creates everything – the agent, its powers, and the circumstances of its choice

therefore every act traces back to the creator

therefore human responsibility is an illusion

THE FOUR REPLIES

- (a) FREE-WILL DEFENCE: God creates the CAPACITY; the agent supplies the ACT. Authorship of the act is the agent's.
- (b) PRIVATION: God creates natures, not the defect in them; evil is a lack, not a created substance
- (c) FOREKNOWLEDGE IS NOT CAUSATION: knowing what will freely occur does not make it occur
- (d) PROCESS: rejects the ANTECEDENT – God does not have the unilateral power the stem assumes

RETAINED REJOINDER – CONCEDE IT, DO NOT SUPPRESS IT
knowingly choosing to instantiate the WHOLE SYSTEM, foreseeing its outcomes, remains MORALLY RELEVANT even if it is not causation.

VERDICT: the conditional is FALSE AS STATED – creaturely authorship survives – but it is NOT EMPTY: it correctly identifies a residual divine responsibility for the SYSTEM, which the free-will defence answers by PRICING rather than by DENYING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/22: Augustine - privation, sin and punishment (2023 Q8(a), 20 marks)

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/22: Augustine – privation, sin and punishment (2023 Q8(a), 20 marks)

AUGUSTINE, Enchiridion and City of God – RECONSTRUCT BEFORE OBJECTING

- (1) Being, insofar as it is being, is GOOD.
 - (2) God creates BEINGS; God does not create evil substances.
 - (3) Corruption is PARASITIC: it depends on a good nature to corrupt.
 - (4) Moral fault is DISORDERED WILLING – the will turning from a greater to a lesser good.
- => EVIL = PRIVATION OF A DUE GOOD (privatio boni), not a rival creative principle.

THE 2023 THESIS: "all evil is either sin or the punishment for sin"

MORAL EVIL = SIN	NATURAL EVIL = PUNISHMENT
misuse of created freedom	a fallen, disordered order
the will's own defect	consequent on the Fall

CANONICAL EXAMPLE: rot is not a rival substance to wood; it is the loss of the wood's proper integrity. Blindness is a REAL lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight. -> PRIVATION DOES NOT MAKE PAIN IMAGINARY. This is the commonest misreading.

FOUR OBJECTIONS

- [illegible]

COMPARATORS: HICK replaces PUNISHMENT with DEVELOPMENT; KARMA replaces a single FALL with a BEGINNINGLESS series and answers DISTRIBUTION, at the cost of verifiability. VERDICT: preserves divine goodness for moral evil; INCOMPLETE for natural, innocent and animal suffering.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/22: Hick's Irenaean soul-making

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/22: Hick's Irenaeian soul-making

JOHN HICK, *Evil and the God of Love* (1966)

- (1) Ready-made virtue is not ACHIEVED virtue.
- (2) Courage, compassion and trust require real difficulty, need and risk.
- (3) A world in which such virtues are possible must be LAW-GOVERNED and must therefore permit harmful consequences.
- (4) Humans are created IMMATURE, at an EPISTEMIC DISTANCE from God, so that faith and love are freely reached rather than compelled – the world is religiously ambiguous.
- (5) Therefore suffering can be the ENVIRONMENT of soul-making.

HICK'S OWN TYPOLOGY – ITSELF EXAMINABLE

AUGUSTINIAN TYPE	IRENAEAN TYPE
humanity created PERFECT	humanity created IMMATURE
FALL from that state	GROWTH toward LIKENESS
evil = privation + sin	evil = environment of growth
backward-looking, retributive	forward-looking, teleological

IRENAEUS supplies the IMAGE -> LIKENESS theology (2nd century).

ATTRIBUTION CHAIN – DO NOT COLLAPSE IT

KEATS coined "The vale of Soul-making" (journal-letter, spring 1819, preferred to "a vale of tears") · IRENAEUS supplies the THEOLOGY · HICK supplies the modern THEODICY

COVERAGE: moral AND natural evil – its advantage over the free-will defence.
COSTS: proportionality (much suffering builds nothing) · animals do not morally grow ·
the reply is a UNIVERSAL ESCHATOLOGICAL FULFILMENT resting on contested afterlife claims.
TRAP: "suffering makes us stronger" is NOT the theodicy. The three components are.
BOUNDARY: divine hiddenness as an independent argument belongs to Reason, Revelation
and Faith; epistemic distance appears here only as a structural component.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/22: Rowe's evidential problem and the inductive step

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WILLIAM ROWE, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism" (1979)

- (1) There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without thereby losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (2) An omniscient, wholly good being would prevent the occurrence of any intense suffering it could, unless it could not do so without losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (3) Therefore there does not exist an omnipotent, omniscient, wholly good being.

THE CANONICAL CASE – THE SUFFERING FAWN

a fawn trapped in a forest fire started by lightning, severely burned, lying in agony for days before dying; UNOBSERVED by any human; NO moral growth follows.

WHAT IT IS FOR: premise (1) – an EVIDENTIAL claim.

WHAT IT IS NOT: a deductive contradiction.

WHY BUILT THAT WAY: it removes free will, soul-making, desert and observer benefit from the case ALL AT ONCE.

THE INDUCTIVE STEP – THE WHOLE BATTLEGROUND

"I can see no justifying reason for this evil."

-> "There is no justifying reason for this evil."

-> "Gratuitous evil exists."

-> "An omnipotent, wholly good God probably does not exist."

The step is an inference from IGNORANCE to ABSENCE. It is not automatically fallacious: we make such inferences correctly whenever we WOULD EXPECT to see the thing if it were there. Everything turns on whether a divine justifying reason is such a thing.

THREE THEIST ROUTES

(a) attack the INFERENCE -> skeptical theism (Panel 12)

(b) supply a POSITIVE REASON -> theodicy (Panels 9, 10, 13)

(c) revise the GOD-CONCEPT -> process, finite God, non-creator systems

! (a) and (b) sit AWKWARDLY together: one says the reason is unknowable, the other names it. Noticing the tension earns marks.

Rowe claims EVIDENTIAL FORCE, not demonstration, and allows the theist may stay rational.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/22: Skeptical theism, CORNEA and its price

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/22: Skeptical theism, CORNEA and its price

PROPOSERS: STEPHEN WYKSTRA · WILLIAM ALSTON · MICHAEL BERGMANN · DANIEL HOWARD-SNYDER
IT IS A DEFENCE, NOT A THEODICY. IT TARGETS THE EVIDENTIAL, NOT THE LOGICAL, PROBLEM.

WYKSTRA'S CORNEA (1984) – Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access

"It appears that p is absent" is a legitimate claim ONLY IF it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p WOULD LIKELY BE DISCERNIBLE if it were there.

BERGMANN'S REPRESENTATIVENESS THESES

our sample of (i) possible GOODS, (ii) possible EVILS and (iii) the ENTAILMENT RELATIONS between them is NOT representative of the total space

THEREFORE the NOSEEUM inference – "no see 'um, so none there" – is UNWARRANTED for goods that would justify divine permission.

ANALOGIES

ALSTON : a novice examines a chess grandmaster's move, sees no point in it, and has no warrant to conclude there is none

WYKSTRA: an infant cannot see why a painful procedure is performed; that inability is no evidence that there is no reason

THREE STANDING COSTS

! MORAL SCEPTICISM (Almeida, Russell, Wielenberg): if we cannot judge an evil gratuitous, we equally cannot judge that we ought to PREVENT it – the duty to rescue is threatened. REPLY: obligation is fixed by what we KNOW. Critics: unstable.

! PARITY / DIVINE DECEPTION: the same scepticism undercuts divine promises and revelation. REPLY: restrict it to the value-entailment domain. Critics: ad hoc.

! BRACKETING: extended, no empirical evidence could ever count against theism – unfalsifiability is a cost even if it is not a refutation.

INDIAN PARITY: unseen moral potency (adrsta) is beyond the senses (atindriya), known only through testimony (sabda); the precise ripening of karma is among the Buddhist imponderables (acinteyya). Genuine parallel – and it inherits the SAME objection: a mechanism placed permanently beyond checking is evidence neither for nor against. TRAP: "God's ways are mysterious" is NOT skeptical theism. State CORNEA or Bergmann, or do not use the position at all.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/22: Horrendous evils – balancing off versus defeat

DEFINITION (technical): a HORRENDOUS EVIL is one whose participation – as PERPETRATOR or as VICTIM – gives the participant PRIMA FACIE reason to doubt whether their life could be A GREAT GOOD TO THEM ON THE WHOLE.
-> not a synonym for "very bad evil"; graphic detail is unnecessary.

- (1) Standard theodicies work at the GLOBAL level, balancing evil within the world's total value.
- (2) But horrendous evils threaten the INDIVIDUAL'S LIFE AS A WHOLE: a global balance can be struck while a particular life remains, for that person, a net disaster.
- (3) A God who is good TO PERSONS – not merely a good PRODUCER OF WORLDS – must DEFEAT the evil WITHIN the frame of the individual's life.
- (4) Only resources internal to a particular religion – divine identification with human suffering, beatific intimacy as an INCOMMENSURABLE good – can accomplish that.

BALANCING OFF the good OUTWEIGHS the evil in a sum; evil remains EXTERNAL to the good	DEFEAT (Chisholm's term) the evil becomes an ORGANIC PART of a whole whose value it CONTRIBUTES to; evil is INTEGRATED, not offset
GLOBAL defeat (world level) what theodicies deliver	LOCAL / PERSONAL defeat (this life) what Adams says is required

OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

REPLY: Adams DENIES instrumentality – the evil need not be REQUIRED, only DEFEATED

REPLY: the atheological argument targets a PARTICULAR theism, so a particular theism may answer

CONTRAST TO NAME: DEFEAT WITHIN the life vs EXIT FROM the life-series.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/22: Animal and pre-human suffering - the standing residue

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THE ARGUMENT

- (1) Animal suffering PREDATES human moral agency.
 - (2) It cannot be the misuse of human free will.
 - (3) It cannot straightforwardly be the environment of MORAL growth for the sufferer.
 - (4) It cannot simply be called retributive.
 - (5) THEREFORE standard theodicies leave a MAJOR REMAINDER.
- Rowe's fawn is the evidential illustration, not a deductive contradiction.

THE FIVE REPLIES, EACH WITH ITS COST

NEO-CARTESIAN	animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain MATTER morally (canvassed by MICHAEL MURRAY, Nature Red in Tooth and Claw, 2008)	COST: philosophically and empirically contested
NOMIC REGULARITY	a stable law-governed world is needed to support any life at all	COST: explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT
SOUL-MAKING EXTENDED	real danger is the only condition in which courage, compassion and stewardship TOWARD ANIMALS are possible	COST: uses animals INSTRUMENTALLY
ESCHATOLOGICAL	animal fulfilment or redemption in a final state (minority line)	COST: unverifiable and undeveloped
FALLEN-ORDER	a cosmic fall distorts nature prior to human history	COST: ? historically and scientifically strained

INDIAN PARITY

karma extends moral causation to ANIMAL BIRTHS (tiryak-yoni)
JAINISM ascribes living selves graded sense-capacity and grounds NON-INJURY (ahimsa)
BUDDHISM places animals within the same field of SUFFERING (duhkha) and extends COMPASSION (karuna) to sentient beings
COST is symmetrical to karma's general cost: unverifiable, and never to be used to infer that present suffering is deserved.
OBJECTION: an animal cannot LEARN from a fruit it cannot understand.
REPLY: karmic maturation is CAUSAL, not PEDAGOGICAL; the compassion it demands is unaffected by whether the animal grasps it.

VERDICT: only NOMIC REGULARITY survives on the Western side, and it explains the KIND of world rather than the AMOUNT of pain in it; Indian karma answers the DISTRIBUTION question the West cannot, at the price of an unverifiable trans-life mechanism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/22: Process theodicy (2025 Q6(b), 15 marks) - the six tenets

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/22: Process theodicy (2025 Q6(b), 15 marks) – the six tenets

SIX TENETS – "MAIN TENETS" IS AN ENUMERATION DIRECTIVE, SO NUMBER THEM

(1) CREATIVITY, not God, is the ultimate; actual entities are self-creative occasions.

(2) God is DIPOLAR:

PRIMORDIAL NATURE ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its INITIAL AIM

CONSEQUENT NATURE God's reception and preservation of what the world becomes

(3) POWER IS INTRINSICALLY DISTRIBUTED: to be actual is to have some self-determination.

(4) THEREFORE divine power is PERSUASIVE BY METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY (Griffin), NOT by self-limitation – the line that separates process theodicy from the free-will defence.

(5) EVIL = finite occasions DEVIATING from the divine lure; God is not culpable.

(6) God is "the FELLOW-SUFFERER WHO UNDERSTANDS" (Whitehead) – solidarity, not detachment.

NAME THE LAYER – DO NOT WRITE "PROCESS THEODICY (WHITEHEAD)" AND STOP

WHITEHEAD Process and Reality (1929): dipolar God, initial aim, consequent nature, the fellow-sufferer

HARTSHORNE The Divine Relativity (1948); Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes (1984): classical omnipotence is INCOHERENT – to have ALL the power is to leave none to anything else; surrelativism/panentheism makes God supremely RELATED, not supremely UNAFFECTED

GRIFFIN God, Power, and Evil: A Process Theodicy (1976); Evil Revisited (1991): persuasion is a METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY, not a chosen restraint

COBB A Christian Natural Theology: the theological systematisation

IT IS A THEODICY, NOT A DEFENCE: it claims God's ACTUAL situation and is therefore refutable in a way Plantinga's defence is not.

CRITICISM: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be UNWORTHY OF WORSHIP;

the metaphysics is contested; classical theists DENY that actuality entails

self-determination. REPLY: divine solidarity, and the OBJECTIVE IMMORTALITY of achieved value in the consequent nature – but the objection does not disappear.

VERDICT: process theodicy purchases GOD'S INNOCENCE at the price of GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/22: The non-classical reply-space and its costs

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THE REPLY-SPACE AROUND THE CLASSICAL THEODICIES – EVERY ENTRY IS PRICED

GREATER-GOOD / STABLE ORDER risk and regular law are needed for freedom, agency, courage and compassion

COST: explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT or the DISTRIBUTION of suffering

LEIBNIZIAN BEST WORLD Theodicee (1710), which also gives the word "theodicy": a perfect God chooses the best total COMPOSSIBLE order, not a world containing every local good

COST: there may be no unique best world, and world-total optimisation can neglect goodness to particular persons

ESCHATOLOGICAL FULFILMENT no finite suffering is final; later fulfilment, restoration or union can prevent a life from being finally wasted

COST: compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it

DIVINE MYSTERY finite minds may fail to grasp providential reasons

COST: unfalsifiable without an access principle; skeptical theism is the disciplined evidential version

PROTEST / ANTI-THEODICY refusing to justify suffering protects truthfulness, lament and the moral priority of resistance

COST: diagnoses the ETHICS of explanation but settles neither the logical nor the evidential argument

THE REVISION STRATEGY IN GENERAL

weaken OMNIPOTENCE -> process, finite God goodness preserved

weaken PERSONALITY -> impersonal Absolute, Advaita evil at the empirical level only

remove CREATORSHIP -> Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa no defendant at all

EVERY revision purchases relief with a RELIGIOUSLY SIGNIFICANT LOSS.

Naming the loss is what converts description into evaluation.

! COMPENSATION IS NOT DEFEAT. Pastoral responsibility requires listening, protection and action BEFORE speculative explanation; a theodicy never licenses passivity toward preventable harm.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/22: The Indian response – karma and the schools

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/22: Evil and the profane - the three theorists and the sequence

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/22: Evil and the profane – the three theorists and the sequence

2019 Q6(b), 15 marks. THIS IS A FUNCTIONAL, NOT A THEOLOGICAL, QUESTION.

It does not ask whether evil disproves God. It asks what evil and the profane DO.

THE THREE CANONICAL THEORISTS – DO NOT INTERCHANGE THEM

DURKHEIM The Elementary Forms of Religious Life (1912) – SOCIAL SIDE

all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, PROFANE and SACRED; religion = a unified system of beliefs and practices RELATIVE TO SACRED THINGS, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a CHURCH. The definition is deliberately GOD-FREE.

OTTO The Idea of the Holy (1917) – OBJECT SIDE

the sacred is an A PRIORI category of response: the NUMINOUS, mysterium tremendum et fascinans

ELIADE The Sacred and the Profane (1957) – SPATIAL / TEMPORAL

the sacred irrupts as HIEROPHANY, generating sacred SPACE (a fixed centre, AXIS MUNDI, against homogeneous profane extension) and sacred TIME (recoverable and repeatable, against irreversible profane duration)

THE FOUR-STEP FOUNDING SEQUENCE

(1) PREDICAMENT something is wrong: sin · impurity · suffering (duhkha) · ignorance (avidya) · karmic bondage · alienation

(2) BOUNDARY pure/impure · sacred/profane · saved/lost -> ritual, prohibition, code

(3) INSTITUTION priesthood · initiation · purification · penance · community discipline

(4) SOTERIOLOGY the ordered path OUT

=> evil and the profane are not embarrassments TO religion but part of its STRUCTURAL

FOUNDATION: without a diagnosis of what is wrong, salvation-language has no work to do.

FOUR CATEGORIES THAT MUST NOT BE MERGED

EVIL = moral or natural harm | PROFANE = the ORDINARY, the non-consecrated

IMPURE = the ritually polluting | DEMONIC = the actively anti-sacred

! DURKHEIM'S PROFANE IS NOT EVIL. A ploughed field, a market and a weekday are profane and none of them is wicked. Conflating them is the commonest error on this stem.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/22: Evil and the profane - Indian parity, objections and verdict

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INDIAN PARITY (MANDATORY)

BUDDHISM the FIRST NOBLE TRUTH makes suffering (dukkha) the explicit foundation of an entire religion – the clearest world case of evil AS religion-founding

JAINISM inflow (asrava) and bondage (bandha) name the predicament; stoppage (samvara) and shedding (nirjara) name the exit

ADVAITA ignorance (avidya) is the founding defect; liberating knowledge is the exit

BRAHMANICAL purity and impurity (suddhi/asuddhi) and cleanliness (sauca) organise

RITUAL practice; auspicious/inauspicious (mangala/amangala); demerit and merit (papa/punya)

MIMAMSA ritual purity codes; correct performance is the rectification

! RIDER: India's founding defect is more often IGNORANCE or BONDAGE than MORAL EVIL – diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness. This changes the SHAPE of the resulting religion and is the highest-value comparative sentence in the answer.

PRESUPPOSITION: that religion can be defined FUNCTIONALLY by structure rather than SUBSTANTIVELY by its object; and that the sacred/profane binary is genuinely cross-cultural.

OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

! the binary is a Durkheimian imposition; many traditions GRADE rather than dichotomise; Eliade's universal archaic ontology is unfalsifiable

REPLY: treat the pair as an IDEAL TYPE that organises comparison, not as a law

! founding religion on evil makes religion PARASITIC on suffering, so a world without suffering would be a world without religion

REPLY: worship, wonder and gratitude are INDEPENDENT religious roots; the sacred is not exhausted by the negative pole

VERDICT: evil and the profane found religion STRUCTURALLY RATHER THAN DOCTRINALLY – they supply the predicament, the boundary and the soteriological task without which religious practice would be unintelligible. But they found RELIGION, NOT THEISM, which is why the same analysis covers Buddhism and Jainism and leaves the theistic problem of evil entirely untouched.

OWNERSHIP: this file owns the EVIL/PROFANE pole; the SACRED/HOLY-AS-OBJECT pole belongs to Religious Experience (2018 Q7(a)). The questions differ: here the category is RELIGION-FOUNDING, there it is OBJECT-IDENTIFYING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/22: Concept-dependence and the assessment grid

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/22: Concept-dependence and the assessment grid

RUN THE CLASSICAL SET AGAINST FOUR GOD-CONCEPTS (2024 Q6(c), 15 marks)

GOD-CONCEPT	EFFECT ON THE PROBLEM	RELIGIOUSLY SIGNIFICANT LOSS
classical theism	FULL FORCE, all burdens live	nothing yet; theodicies must work
finite / process God	DISSOLVED at the logical level	sovereignty; any guarantee of final victory over evil
impersonal Absolute (Advaita, nirguna)	RELOCATED: evil real at the empirical level, sublated at the ultimate level	a personal God to address; risk of minimising suffering
no creator (Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa)	REMOVED: no defendant; conditions and deeds explain	providence, divine rescue, a cosmic guarantor of justice
! CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE IS NOT A SOLUTION. It relocates the cost from the ARGUMENT into the THEOLOGY. The theodicies exist precisely to KEEP ALL THE ATTRIBUTES.		

THE ASSESSMENT GRID

THEODICY	EXPLAINS	PRESERVES	WEAKNESS
free-will	moral	omnipotence + goodness	natural evil left over
Augustinian privation	moral via Fall	all attributes	privation strained; innocence and animals
soul-making (Hick) process	moral + natural all	purposive goodness goodness, NOT omnipotence	scale; animals; eschatology sacrifices classical omnipotence
karma	all + DISTRIBUTION	cosmic justice; no creator-blame	victim-blaming; verification; regress
Advaita	empirical evil	Brahman untouched	minimising suffering
skeptical theism	none (defence)	all attributes	moral scepticism; unfalsifiability

FOUR STANDING CRITICISMS – REPLY AND REJOINDER

EXCESS EVIL	reply: epistemic limits, long-range goods rejoinder: unknown reasons cannot become a blanket licence
NATURAL EVIL	reply: stable natural law enables agency rejoinder: stability does not explain every extreme distribution
DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY	reply: foreknowledge does not cause free action rejoinder: knowingly choosing the whole system remains relevant
KARMA AND COMPASSION	reply: classical ethics requires compassion regardless of cause; explanatory karma does not authorise social judgement

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/22: The answer route and the qualified conclusion

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/22: The answer route and the qualified conclusion

THE UNIVERSAL SPINE – USE AT EVERY MARK LEVEL

- (1) NAME the version: logical | evidential | existential | horrendous | animal | distributional
- (2) STATE the set WITH ITS BRIDGES, or the probability judgement with its inductive step
- (3) RECONSTRUCT the reply as NUMBERED PREMISES, correctly attributed
- (4) OBJECT and REPLY, then state the RESIDUE
- (5) COMPARE with one deliberate Indian or Western comparator that does argumentative work
- (6) GRADE: what it explains · what it preserves · what it COSTS · what it leaves untouched

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DIRECTIVE DECODER – WHAT EACH PRINTED STEM BUYS

"What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss"	the SET and its BRIDGING PREMISES	2020
"Discuss the paradox of..."	a dilemma: horn, cost, horn, cost,	
	then the dissolving restriction	2021
"Critically examine [a quoted thesis]"	fidelity to the claim's SCOPE first	2022
"'Quotation.' Critically discuss"	reconstruct the author's system,	
	THEN test it	2023
"Direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised"	show the DEPENDENCE by varying the	
	God-concept, then price it	2024
"Explain the main tenets of X"	ENUMERATED doctrine, correctly	
	attributed; number the tenets	2025
"What role do A and B play to found..."	a FUNCTIONAL account: predicament ->	
	boundary -> institution -> soteriology	2019

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BANDS: 10m ~150 words | 15m ~240-260 words | 20m ~340-360 words

VERDICT LADDER

~40% asserts the triad; no version identified
~50% distinguishes logical from evidential; two theodicies listed
~60% bridges stated; one theodicy fully reconstructed; Indian comparator present
~65-70% version-matched theodicy; objection with reply; distribution raised; costs stated
~70%+ adds defeat-vs-balancing-off, or CORNEA, or the animal-suffering gap – AND an explicit statement of what the theist has GIVEN UP to survive

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NEVER END DEVOTIONALLY. "God's purposes are ultimately good" is not a verdict.

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION: the problem of evil is a stress-test of a PARTICULAR God-concept, not of religion as such. Weaken omnipotence, weaken personality, or remove the creator and it dissolves – but every dissolution purchases relief with a religiously significant loss, and every surviving theodicy is priced. A theodicy is not refuted by its cost; it is MEASURED by it, and the answer's final task is to state that price.